Every Favour a Debt

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A Novel

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A work of fiction. Names, characters, places and incidents are products of the imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, is entirely coincidental.

For adult readers.

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Chapter One

The Dedication

. . .

She is early, because to be late in this city is to be read as careless, and careless women are charged more for everything. The morning is still blue at the edges. Below the Caelian the streets are already loud with handcarts and muleteers swearing at the gradient, with slaves carrying water up from the fountains in jars that knock against their hips. Antonia Cassia stands in her own courtyard and puts her hand, quite flat, to the painted plaster to feel whether the damp has come through again in the night. It has. A bloom of cold under the red. She makes a note of it in the part of her mind where repairs live, between the price of Falernian and the name of the fuller who does not steal.

Diomedes is waiting with the tablets. He does not look at her face first. He looks at her hands, as clerks do, to see if she is ready to hold a stylus or only to listen. “The dedication crowds will close the Forum by the third hour,” he says. “If the wine is to come up from the warehouses today it must come now.”

“Then now,” she says. “And pay the carter before he unloads, not after. I am tired of his face at the kitchen door.”

He marks it. The wax takes the point with a small, neat resistance that she has always liked. Everything in this house should resist a little before it yields. The doors. The accounts. The women, when a guest mistakes payment for ownership. Herself, most of all, when she is asked a question whose answer would be useful to the asker.

The house wakes in sections, like a theatre being lit from the back. First the kitchen yard, where the night porter hands his keys to the morning boy with a recital of grievances against the weather, the watch, and a cat that has adopted the woodpile and is raising, by the sound of it, a dynasty. Then the kitchen itself: fires coaxed, yesterday's ash raked out

and saved in a bucket for the fuller, because nothing in this house is thrown away until two people have agreed it cannot be sold, fed to something, or used to clean something else. Then water. A house on the Caelian drinks uphill. Every jar in it has come up the street on a human back, and Antonia, who carried water professionally in her youth, in a town built of stairs, has opinions about waste that she expresses without raising her voice and without repetition. The household can recite them. Guests, who are charged for waste in ways they never identify on the bill, are spared the recital.

Barbatus does the doors at first light, not because the street is dangerous at dawn — the street at dawn is full of bakers' boys and old women, Rome's true garrison — but because a door opened carelessly sets the tone of a day. He stands in the entrance in his vast, weathered calm and looks up and down the street the way he once looked across sand: not for enemies, exactly; for intentions. Tradesmen read him correctly and moderate theirs. A fishmonger's boy who arrived in November intending to short-weight the house on mullet now brings the mullet up to the threshold holding the scales like a votive offering. Barbatus has never threatened him. Barbatus, who spent eleven years being professionally threatened for the entertainment of thousands, has retired from the genre.

“The fish is better than the boy,” he reports to the kitchen, which is his way of passing an invoice.

Antonia does her first round while the house is still honest. Later, with the lamps lit and the hangings down and musicians tuning in the small room, the place will put on the face it is paid for; but at this hour it shows her what it is: a machine for converting money into ease, with all the belts and buckets visible. She checks the great dining room where last night's Alexandrians argued about harbour dues until the lamps drowned in their own oil. The floor has been washed; a couch has a wine stain blooming on its cover like a small purple province; somebody — a guest, a servant, history will not be told — has left a ring on the window ledge, gold, with a stone the colour of weak tea. She picks it up and

holds it to the light. In her first years in Rome a ring like that, lost in her rooms, would have gone to the Greek by noon and come back as rent. Now she puts it in the box in Diomedes' office labelled, in his upright hand, *Guests' Property, Forgotten*, where it will wait to be claimed by a man who will arrive at dusk in a panic of discretion, having told his wife one story and his steward another. He will overpay the house for its silence in some future transaction, never knowing he has done it, and the ring will have earned more in the box than it ever would at the Greek's. This is what Antonia means when she tells the younger women that honesty is a long position. They think she is joking. Eirene, who has seen the box's contents turn over the years like a small, glittering tide — rings, a senator's seal-stone, once, memorably, a set of false teeth in a cedar case — knows she is not.

In the kitchen the pastry cook is already at war. He is from Alexandria, he is called Ammonius, and he regards Roman cooking the way Roman generals regard other people's countries: as raw material awaiting improvement. This morning's enemy is the price of pine nuts, which has risen, and the quality of the honey, which in his formulation has *fallen morally*. Antonia listens to the whole dispatch while tasting yesterday's stock. It is a ritual. He requires an audience with the power to fund him; she requires him to believe the funding is in doubt, because a cook who feels secure begins to cook for other cooks, and other cooks do not pay her bills.

“You may have the pine nuts,” she says at last, “at the old price, from the man in the Forum Boarium. Tell him the house remembers the short measure at Saturnalia. He will remember being remembered.”

“And the honey?”

“The honey is from our own man outside the Colline Gate. If it has fallen morally, Ammonius, it has done so in your storeroom, among your jars, under your seal.” She rinses the spoon herself — a hairdresser's daughter does not leave spoons; it is the same religion as the hair — and puts it back in its place. “Reform it.”

Ammonius bows with the grandeur of a man accepting a province and turns back to his fires, already composing the menu for a night still twelve hours away, while the kitchen boy — eleven years old, freeborn, apprenticed by a mother who came to Antonia first for a midwife's fee and stayed, over the years, for arithmetic lessons she pretends are recipes — mouths the words *fallen morally* over the onions with the deep satisfaction of a person stocking a phrase for later use. Antonia sees him do it. She lets him keep it. A house survives on what its people steal from it in language.

Upstairs, the women are waking in the order of their engagements, which is to say that Philomela, who sang until the second watch, is not waking at all, and has hung a strip of red wool on her door, the house's flag for *a voice is sleeping; knock and be billed*. Daphne is awake and practising scales at a volume calculated to annoy nobody who matters. There are rules here too, arrived at over eleven years and written nowhere, which is why they work: no woman in this house descends to the dining rooms before she has eaten; no woman entertains a guest who has struck a servant, once, anywhere, on any provocation — Rome calls this an eccentricity and pays a premium for it; no woman's earnings pass through any hand but Diomedes', and his pass through Antonia's every quarter, in her presence, with the tablets open. Twice a year a new arrival, hired from some lodging house by the theatres where the rules were different, tests the ones about money. Twice a year Antonia explains, sitting down, in the small room, that she did not climb out of Baiae on stairs of other women's wages and does not intend to be carried up fresh ones. The explanation takes four minutes. It has not yet needed repeating to the same woman.

She is on the stairs herself when the carter arrives early, contrary to instruction, and with only half the wine. She hears Barbatus admit him to the yard and hears, in the quality of the cart's complaining axle, a story preparing itself: the warehouses, the dedication crowds, a mule with opinions. By the time she reaches the yard the man has got as far as the mule.

“The other half,” Antonia says, “is where?”

“Coming, mistress. On the second cart. By the third hour, the fourth at the outside. The Forum—”

“The Forum was built over twelve years. It did not surprise the warehouses this morning.” She looks at the amphorae he has brought: sealed, stamped, the Falernian she ordered, a cheaper Campanian she did not, riding among them like a poor relation in a good cloak. She rests her hand, quite gently, on the shoulder of one of the impostors. “And these?”

The carter looks at Barbatus. Barbatus looks at the street. It is a conversation men have in this yard about twice a year, usually at the point where someone's arithmetic meets hers.

“A mistake at loading,” the carter says. “It being dark.”

“Then it can be unloaded in the light. Take the Campanian back, bring the rest of the Falernian by the third hour, and I will pay the full contract, including today's cartage, as agreed. Bring it by the fourth, and I will pay for the wine and not the cartage, because the afternoon of an imperial dedication is not when I conduct my cellar down a public street. Bring me another mistake in the dark at any hour you choose—” she takes her hand off the amphora “—and you may explain the darkness to the Greek at the Basilica, who holds your note for the mule. He holds most people's notes. It is why his office is so quiet.”

The carter begins unloading with the energy of a man who has just remembered an appointment with honesty. Diomedes, arriving with a stylus, records the amended delivery without expression. He has a category for this in the day-book. Every house in Rome has, whether it writes it down or not: *attempted, at dawn, in the dark*. Antonia watches a moment longer, to give the lesson its full weight of witness, and it is while she is standing in the yard among the amphorae, with the January light coming up over the roofs and the whole city beginning to make its dedication-day noise below the hill, that she hears the courtyard door, and Eirene's step on the stones.

Eirene comes across the courtyard with a bowl of warm water and a cloth over her arm, her hair still pinned for sleep. She is Antonia's age and has the particular beauty of women who have stopped arranging their faces for other people before noon. “You have ink on your jaw,” Eirene says.

“Then I was working in my sleep.”

“You were working instead of it.” Eirene wipes the mark away. Her fingers are cool. “The new hanging is here. The embroiderer herself brought it. She would not give it to the porter.”

“Good for her. Give her breakfast and keep her from Barbatus. He thinks courtesy is a kind of wrestling.”

Diomedes turns a tablet over. “There is also a notice. From the aediles' office. It was left before dawn, which is either diligence or a wish not to be seen leaving it.”

Antonia takes it. The seal is correct. The hand is a clerk's hand, trained to make threats look like administration. An inspection. A review of contributions, of registrations, of the uses to which rooms in this insula are put after dark. Words that have been washed so often they no longer smell of anything: order, decency, precedent. At the foot, a name cited as proposing the review to the Senate's committee. She reads it twice, not because she doubts her eyes but because her eyes, at thirty-eight, prefer close work in better light, and because she wants the small delay in which a feeling can be put down somewhere it will not be seen.

Gnaeus Cornelius Lentulus.

Eirene is watching her. Diomedes is very interested in the courtyard roses, which are overwatered and know it.

“Well,” Antonia says. “The emperor dedicates a forum today, and Lentulus dedicates himself to my drains. We all build what we can.”

She hands the notice back. “File it with the tax receipts. Answer nothing today. If a man sends a clerk before dawn he wants a reply before noon, and I have never yet let Lentulus set the hour in my house.”

■

He is being shaved when his son comes in, which means he cannot turn his head, which means his son must say whatever he has come to say to a profile held still by another man's hand. Gnaeus Cornelius Lentulus has found, over twenty years of public life, that a razor at the throat improves the quality of other people's sentences. They become shorter. They become, if not honest, at least economical.

“The Forum today,” the boy says. He is twenty and calls this an opening.

“Yes.”

“Shall I ride with you or with Uncle Postumus?”

“With me. Postumus will talk through the sacrifices and then claim he foresaw the omens.”

The barber's thumb pulls the skin taut under his jaw. In the mirror — polished bronze, his grandfather's, the rim dented where a slave dropped it the winter the Tiber froze at the edges — Lentulus can see his son shift from foot to foot in a way that his tutors were paid to correct and did not. The boy has his mother's height and, Lentulus thinks, with the clarity that comes when one may not move, none of his mother's patience and all of his own appetite for being elsewhere.

“There is talk,” the boy says, “about your proposal. The inspections.”

“There is always talk. It is the city's second water supply.”

“They say it is aimed. At one house in particular.”

The razor pauses. The barber, who has shaved three consuls and buried two, knows when a household has stepped on its own hem.

“Who are they, Marcus?” Lentulus asks.

“Men at the baths. Men who owe me money at dice and pay in information because it is cheaper.”

“A proposal on registrations is aimed at everyone who has failed to register. If one house feels it more than others, that may be because one house has grown very large on very small paperwork.” He can hear how well this will sound in the Senate, and how thin it sounds here, with soap

on his neck. “You will not repeat bath-house talk at the dedication. You will stand where you are put, you will be seen to attend to the emperor, and you will remember that your sister's negotiations require this family to look like a wall, not a window.”

Marcus bows, correctly, which in this family is what young men do instead of slamming doors the slaves would have to repair.

When he has gone, the barber resumes. “Shall I leave the scar, dominus?”

The scar is small, under the left ear, older than the boy who just left the room. Lentulus says, “You always leave the scar, Felix. It is not a decision I need to make fresh each morning.”

“No, dominus.” Felix wipes the blade. “Some men like to think it is.”

Out in the atrium the ancestral masks look down from their cupboards, wax faces darkened by smoke and time, each with its painted inscription: offices held, triumphs voted, provinces governed. Lentulus passes them as he passes them every morning, with the brief, involuntary arithmetic of the living: what he has added, what he has merely maintained, what the debts secured against the Campanian estates would look like if debts were inscribed under a man's name as offices are. He touches nothing. A Cornelius does not touch the masks for luck. He behaves as if luck were a vulgarity other families require.

His wife is at the household shrine, making the morning offering with the household gathered in the order she has arranged and rearranged over nineteen years until it looks like nature. Servilia does not look up when he joins her. She pours, she speaks the words, she sets the cup down exactly within the ring its predecessors have left on the stone. Only when the slaves have withdrawn does she say, “You sent the notice before dawn.”

“The aediles sent it. I proposed a review. These are distinct actions.”

“In the Senate they will be. At dinner they will not.” She straightens the fold of his toga where it crosses his chest. Her hands are expert and entirely without tenderness, which is not the same as without care. “If you mean to make war on that woman, Lentulus, do it in daylight and

win it quickly. This family has a daughter to marry. We cannot afford a siege that everyone in Rome watches while eating."

"I do not make war on women," he says.

"No," Servilia says. "You make proposals. Rome will supply the war."

Servilia leaves him to the dressing, which in this house is a liturgy with a staff. The toga is not put on a senator; it is built around him, fold by negotiated fold, by a slave whose grandfather dressed a Cornelius for a triumph and whose professional opinion, delivered through his hands, is that the modern chest is narrower and the modern occasion fatter. Lentulus stands for it the way he stands for clients: as an act of office performed by other people's competence. In the bronze mirror his reflection is assembled by degrees out of the room's grey light — first a shape, then a senator, then, if you know where to look, which Felix does and the dresser does and Servilia has for nineteen years, the man inside the arrangement, holding still.

"Your father," the dresser says — he is old enough to be allowed uncommissioned sentences, a liberty the household grants by age the way Antonia's grants by invoice — "wore his to the left an inch further. For the sword arm, he said. There was no sword, in the Forum, in my memory."

"There was always a sword in my father's memory," Lentulus says. "It is what the memory was *for*."

He does not say — the room is not one of his locked ones, it is full of hands — that he has started, this winter, to hear his father's sentences arriving in his own voice at committee pitch: *order*, *decency*, *precedent*, the washed words, the ones that have been through the fullers so often they have lost their original colour and can be worn to anything. At twenty-four he believed a man chose his vocabulary the way he chose his friends. At forty-five he knows a man's vocabulary is issued to him, like the toga's folds, by people who dressed his grandfather, and that the freedom lies, if it lies anywhere, in the inch to the left or right that nobody else notices.

Cornelia is in the corridor when he comes out, which means she has timed it, which means Servilia knows she has timed it and has permitted the corridor as a theatre. She is dressed for the dedication in the white of a senator's unmarried daughter — a colour that is also a locked room, and better guarded than most in this house — and she has her mother's way of asking a question by arranging to be present when it answers itself.

“Will the emperor speak?” she asks.

“He will dedicate. Speaking is what the inscriptions do afterwards, at greater length and with fewer interruptions.”

“Marcus says the column will have the whole war on it, going round and round.”

“Marcus says a great many things going round and round.” But he says it without the edge he keeps for the boy in public, and his daughter receives the distinction the way she receives everything in this family: filed, accurately, for a future she is not yet charging interest on. “The war will go round and round, yes. Wars do, on stone. It saves the survivors the trouble of describing the parts no one can see from the ground.”

She thinks about this with her whole forehead. At sixteen her thinking is still visible, a condition her education is designed to cure by the vintage. “Who is it for, then? The part nobody can see.”

“The gods,” her father says, because it is the answer the dedication requires, and then — the inch to the left, unnoticed by anyone except the girl it was always going to matter to — “and the people who carried the baskets. Someday somebody will climb up inside it and read it all. Historians,” he says, “are just clients who arrive very late and cannot be turned away.”

Cornelia nods as if a purse of the middle size has been placed, correctly, in her hands. Servilia, appearing at the corridor's end with the household deploying behind her like a fleet in line, takes in father, daughter, and the exact quality of the moment she has scheduled, and says only, “The litters,” which in her Latin covers a multitude of

approvals she would regard it as wasteful to itemise.

■

By the third hour the new Forum is a press of white wool and oiled hair and January sun striking gilding fit to blind a man into piety. Trajan moves through his own magnificence like a surveyor who happens to own the land: a soldier-emperor among columns, basilicas, libraries rising in Greek and Latin on either side of a courtyard where a column will stand when the carvers have finished telling the Dacian wars in a spiral no one at ground level will ever fully read. Antonia, who has no business being seen at an imperial dedication and every business seeing it, stands at the margin with Eirene and a veil drawn in the respectable style, in the company of contractors' wives and a dealer in purple dye who owes her money and is therefore delighted to make room.

She does not look for Lentulus. This is a discipline, like not touching a loose tooth. She looks instead at the stone-cutters' marks still visible on a base course, at a secretary of the emperor's household she knows to be short-sighted and vain about it, at the way the crowd makes a lane for men it believes important and closes, just as instinctively, against men it has finished with. Power in Rome is mostly this: a lane opening.

The dealer in purple is called Gaius Septimius, he dyes for half the bridal trade of Rome, and he owes Antonia nine hundred sesterces on a note she bought from his landlord in the autumn, at a discount, for reasons that were partly business and partly that the landlord's son had beaten a servant in her house two years ago and she collects such accounts in whatever currency presents itself. Septimius does not know she holds the note. He knows she is a woman who once found him, at two days' notice, a buyer for a consignment of cloth ruined — *improved*, he said at the time, sweating — by an apprentice's error with the mordant. Gratitude of that vintage does not thin. He makes room for her and Eirene beside his wife, a gaunt, handsome woman with dyer's hands she hides in public inside her sleeves, and launches, by way of rent on

the standing space, into the cost of everything in sight.

“You see the gilding on the basilica entablature? Gold leaf, Antonia. Not wash. Leaf. My cousin had the contract for the glue alone and bought a farm at Tibur.”

“Then the empire is in good health,” Antonia says. “When the glue men are buying farms, the world is sticking together.”

Septimius' wife makes a sound inside her veil that is either a laugh or a cough being strangled for respectability. Eirene, who has the stillness of a woman listening with her whole skin, says, “Tell her about the library steps. He has been telling the street all morning. It improves with an audience that pays by the piece.”

But Antonia is not listening to Septimius, not with the front of her mind. She is doing what she does in every crowd: reading it as a ledger. There — a contractor who supplied lime for the Forum vaults, gone rich and strange with it, wearing a ring on every finger as if his hands were a manifesto; his wife assessing other wives' jewellery with the care of a money-changer at a doubtful coin. There — two young equestrians she dined last month, deep in an attempt to look senatorial, an aspiration their tailors have funded and their posture betrays. There — very still, in the grey that costs more than colour — Servilia. Antonia has seen her perhaps a dozen times in twenty years, always at this distance, which is the distance Rome keeps between the women in its arrangements: close enough to evaluate, too far to require a greeting. Servilia's veil is arranged as if by engineers. She is listening to an older woman — an aunt, an Acilia, somebody with a priesthood in the family — with an attention so complete it must be costing her something, and Antonia, who prices attention professionally, thinks: *that is a woman being told the cost of a marriage. It takes one to itemise one.*

She does not permit the thought a second sentence. Servilia is filed, has been filed for nineteen years, under *the settlement*, and Antonia does not open other women's files in public; she has a house that lives by the principle.

The crowd has its own weather. It thickens toward the imperial party, thins at the altars where the smoke will be, eddies around a man selling, with an entrepreneur's instinct for a captive Senate, little clay columns no taller than a thumb, already spiralled, already triumphant. A child is crying somewhere in the particular key that carries. A legionary veteran on a crutch is being helped, by two strangers and a third man's elbow, up onto a plinth for a better view, and the crowd makes that small, satisfied noise cities make when they have done a decency within sight of each other. Somewhere a rope gives way at a barrier and there is a surge and a counter-surge and a voice raised in official Latin, and a pickpocket — Antonia watches his whole career: the drift, the gather, the repaired innocence of the hands — decides, feeling Barbatus's attention from twenty paces like weather on his neck, to become a spectator instead. Barbatus is not beside her today; Barbatus is never beside her at dedications, it would be a statement, and statements are for clients. But a man who has worked a door for eleven years radiates. She has seen his attention work from across a courtyard full of wine. A Forum is merely a courtyard with an emperor in it.

“What do you suppose it cost?” Eirene asks, meaning the whole thing: forum, basilica, libraries, the column still in its scaffold of timber like a tree not yet allowed to be stone.

“The Dacians,” Antonia says. “Personally. That is the official answer and for once it is also the accounts. Gold in the mountains, men in the mines, marble in Rome.” She watches a team of oxen, garlanded to the edge of dignity, being walked in a wide, patient circuit to keep them calm before the sacrifice. Their hides shine. Handlers talk to them in the low, continuous murmur men use for animals they respect and intend to kill, a tone not unknown in the Senate. “Everything here has been somewhere else first, Eirene. That's the dedication they're actually performing.”

“You should write speeches.”

“I should charge for them. Septimius — your wife's sleeve is better dyed than the priest's border, and if you tell her I said so she will charge

you for the compliment in kind.”

She says it because Septimius' wife has taken her hands out of her sleeves to settle her veil and the purple under her nails is the deep, true, sea-snail purple that money cannot quite buy and work cannot wash out. The woman hears. Under the veil something changes — not a smile, which would need witnesses; an acknowledgement, tradeswoman to tradeswoman across a dyer's husband, that the hands have been seen and priced correctly. It is the kind of transaction Antonia values: exact, unrecorded, impossible to tax. Rome runs on them underneath everything it inscribes.

Now the procession of office is forming on the far side: lictors, priests, the colleges in their order, boys with incense swinging their arms wide the way boys have swung incense since Romulus, half devotion, half showing off. The emperor is visible for whole seconds at a time between shoulders: a soldier's head, grey now, the famous plainness of dress that costs more to maintain than purple, since it must never look maintained. Antonia has fed half the men walking behind him. She catalogues them without appetite: who is up, who is being carried by his wife's money, who has begun, in the last year, to have his dinners at home and his truths told by others, which is the first symptom. Power in Rome is mostly this, she thinks again — and then the crowd shifts, in that organic, prescient way it has, a lane beginning to open before the reason for it is visible, the way water finds out about the stone before the stone arrives.

It opens, inevitably, not far from her. Senators in their broad stripes. A priest with his cap tied under his chin. And Lentulus, in the fold and fall of wool that costs more than a good horse, listening to the emperor with his head inclined at the angle that, in their youth — she puts the thought down, hard, like a cup that might spill — that men of his family are taught before they are taught Greek. He is forty-five. There is grey now at his temples that the barber cannot shave away. It suits him, which she notes as she would note a competitor's new cook: professionally, and with resentment held at a distance where it can be of

use.

He sees her. Of course he sees her. Twenty years of not speaking in public requires a highly developed awareness of where the other person is standing.

Neither of them inclines a head. The crowd shifts. A child on his father's shoulders points at the equestrian statue and shrieks with the pure, unpatronised joy of a person who does not yet know what anything costs. Somewhere a trumpet tests the air and the pigeons rise off the new marble in a single grey applause.

Eirene says, very quietly, “The embroiderer is still at the house. She asked whether the mistress pays by the piece or by the day, and when Diomedes said by the piece she said, good, because her days belong to her father. I liked her for it.”

“Pay her by the piece,” Antonia says, still looking at the Forum, at the lane closing now behind the senators. “And then add a day's wage, and write it in the book as thread. If her days belong to her father, we will not be the ones to inform him that her work is worth more than he thinks. Let her tell him herself, when she is ready.”

She turns before the sacrifices begin. She has a house to run, an inspection to outlive, and a long-practised conviction that the gods, like senators, prefer to be addressed by people who have first attended to their drains.

Chapter Two

Registrations

. . .

The inspector arrives at the hour when respectable houses are still receiving clients and houses like hers are changing the flowers. He is a man in his thirties with a clerk and a measuring rod and the careful blankness of someone who has been told, by a person who outranks him, that this inspection matters, and told, by a person who pays him, that it would be a shame if it mattered too much. Antonia receives him in the small dining room, not the great one. She has learned to size a room to a man's self-regard: too large and he must fill it, too small and he must escape it.

“You keep a lodging house,” he says, “with dining.”

“I keep a house,” she says, “where men of business may dine in private and hear music. The registrations are there.” Diomedes lays them out like a hand of cards he expects to win with: names, fees, the tax paid quarterly and stamped, the licence for the sale of wine, the lease of the premises from an owner in Ostia who has never, in eleven years, inquired what music is playing so long as the rent arrives before the Kalends.

The inspector runs a finger down the column of women's names. Each name is a legal condition before it is a person: freedwoman, freeborn, citizen, alien. Each has a fee against it. Rome taxes what it condemns with an efficiency it brings to few of its virtues, and Antonia pays the tax on the day, in full, in coin that rings. She has always paid. A woman in her position who cheats the treasury is a story; a woman who overpays it slightly, through rounding, is a footnote, and footnotes survive.

“And this one?” The finger stops. “Daphne. No family name.”

“Daphne, freedwoman of Gaius Antonius, manumitted three years ago before witnesses whose names Diomedes can supply. She sings. She also plays the lyre indifferently, which we do not register, out of kindness.”

The clerk writes. The rod measures a doorway and finds it a doorway. In the corridor, one of the kitchen boys drops a tray and the crash arrives in the small dining room as a useful reminder that this is a working house and not a proposition. The inspector, to his credit, does not flinch. He is looking, Antonia sees, for the thing he has been sent to find, and beginning to understand that if it exists it will not be written in the book she keeps for inspectors, nor in the second book either — the one Diomedes keeps for her — but in the third accounting, which is her memory, and which does not admit measuring rods.

“The premises, then,” the inspector says, in the tone of a man moving to evidence he can measure, and Antonia rises and gives him the house the way she gives a new guest the menu: in full, in order, with nothing saved for a second, more expensive telling. Diomedes walks a pace behind with the tablets. The clerk, who is younger than the rod he carries and in love, as clerks are, with the prospect of scandal in good rooms, walks a pace behind Diomedes with his eyes drinking.

They begin, at Antonia's direction, in the kitchen, which is not where an inspector of morals expects to begin, and is therefore exactly where she begins them all: landlords, tax men, a praetor's steward two years ago with a warrant he eventually used as a napkin. A kitchen argues. Hers argues in copper — pans scoured to mirrors, the new stove drawing cleanly, Ammonius enthroned among his fires with a ladle in his hand and an expression that suggests the aediles may inspect his saucepans when they have published their own. The stores are chalked and dated. The wine cellar book matches the seals. The inspector, who has inspected the kitchens of the Subura and does not speak of them the way veterans do not speak, lets his clerk write *stores in order* with a hand that has had, Antonia guesses, little practice at the phrase.

“The women eat from the same kitchen?” he asks.

“The women eat first from the same kitchen, before the guests are admitted. A house rule.” She does not offer the reason. The reason is twenty years old and lives in Baiae, in a house where the staff ate what was left and learnt their value from the leavings. “You may ask them. It is permitted to ask them anything that is written in your commission.”

He asks Philomela, because Philomela is in the corridor with a lyre and the air of a woman it would be a clerical error to overlook. Philomela is twenty-six, freeborn in Corinth, professionally a singer in the way generals are professionally soldiers: it explains her rank in any room she enters. She gives the inspector her registration particulars the way she gives a difficult interval — precisely, and with a faint suggestion that lesser instruments exist. Age. Status. The name of the agent who brought her to Rome, a man whose contract Antonia bought out in the first month and burnt in this kitchen's predecessor, a ceremony Philomela attended with a cup of the house's second-best wine, *not the best*, she still says, *she's not sentimental, our mistress; she filed it under fuel*.

“Are you content in this house?” the inspector asks. It is not in his commission. It escapes him the way questions do in clean kitchens.

“Officer,” Philomela says, “I am a singer. Contentment is for audiences.” She tunes a string; the note goes through the corridor like a wire through cheese. “I am paid, I am registered, I sing what I choose and I refuse what I don't, and when my voice goes — voices go, officer, write that down too — I have money with a Greek at the Basilica that no husband, patron or tax farmer has the address of. If that is contentment in your Latin, then I am content. In mine it is called *not being a fool*, which my mother taught me in Corinth at her usual rates.”

The clerk writes nothing. There is no column for it. Antonia watches the inspector decide — she can see him do it, the way you can see a man at her tables decide not to say the true thing over the fish — to make the rest of the inspection be about doors.

So doors it is: widths, hinges, the number of dining rooms and their disposition, the little courtyard room where linen is kept and

needlewomen are given the light, the bedrooms upstairs that are, for the register, *resting rooms for artists*, and are in fact whatever paying adults have agreed between themselves behind them, under house rules the inspector has not been commissioned to imagine. He measures. The rod reports that the house is the size it is. In the great dining room the new hanging stops him — not its beauty, though Eirene, passing with flowers, notes him registering that too and tells the kitchen later — its border. A man whose trade is paper looks at two hundred small red flowers, each one stitched, each one paid for, and has for a moment the expression of a person who has wandered out of his commission into the actual economy.

“From Transtiberim,” Antonia says. “A fuller's daughter. The house commissions its cloth work across the river. Better light, better prices, better women. You may record the neighbourhood as a moral influence, if the form has room.”

“The form,” the inspector says, surprising himself into honesty, which clean kitchens will do, “has very little room, madam. It was designed by men who expected smaller facts.”

They return to the small dining room by way of the courtyard, where the damp map is drying in a bar of sun and the roses are looking, as they always look in this house, handsomely overwatered, like guests who will not be refused a third cup. Barbatus is at the street door admitting a delivery of lamp oil, checking seals with thumbs the size of small hammers. The inspector looks at him and looks away — not fear; a kind of professional reassessment, as of a wall discovered to be structural.

“Your doorkeeper is ex-arena.”

“My doorkeeper is ex-everything Rome could charge admission for. He has killed no one on these premises, which is more than the Senate can say of its foreign policy, and he breaks up fights by standing up. The house recommends the technique to the committee.”

It is more than she usually gives an official, and she gives it deliberately, because a man who has been honest about his form deserves a sentence he can carry back like a souvenir. He almost smiles

— the same almost-smile the house will see again from the prefect's man in the spring, though neither of them knows it yet — and sits down to his tablets and his watered wine with the air of a soldier returning to a frontier he suspects of being quieter than Rome.

“There have been complaints,” he says at last. “Noise. Congregation. Men of senatorial rank seen leaving after the second watch.”

“Men of senatorial rank leave the Senate after dark too, in the winter. I believe the streets survive it.” She pours him watered wine herself, which is a courtesy and also a way of ending a sentence. “Record the complaint. Record also that the neighbours on either side are a fuller's workshop and a dealer in lamps, neither of whom you will find among the complainants, because I pay the fuller well and the lamp-seller's daughter was married from this house with a dowry I do not discuss. If the committee wants complainants, it will have to import them, like the marble in the emperor's forum. It can be done. Everything can be done. I merely note the cost of transport.”

He looks at her then, directly, with something that is not quite respect and not quite warning. “The proposal comes from a name that does not lose, madam.”

“All names lose,” Antonia says. “The trick is to lose at something that does not end you. Show him the kitchen, Diomedes. Let him see the new stove. Men who have seen a kitchen find it harder to describe a house as a den. A den does not usually have a pastry cook from Alexandria arguing about saffron.”

When he has gone — rod, clerk, and a report already composing itself in his head in the passive voice, that great laundry of Roman administration, in which things *are found* and *are noted* and nobody in particular has ever found or noted them — the house exhales in a way it would deny doing. Ammonius sends up, unasked, a plate of the almond cakes that are reserved for officials and emergencies. Eirene takes one and eats it standing, which in Eirene is a parade.

“Well,” she says. “We are a den with a pastry cook. It is entered in the record.”

Diomedes is already writing the visit into the second book, in the hand he keeps for facts that must survive fashion. “He asked about Daphne's manumission twice,” he says, without looking up. “Once for the form. Once —” the stylus pauses, a toll-gate “— for the person who will read the form and ask him why he asked once. Somebody gave him her name before he came, madam. Not the register. A name, carried separately, like a stone in a sling.”

Antonia is still for a moment in the small dining room, where the inspector's cup sits with a finger's width of watered wine unevaporated at the bottom. She picks it up herself; a slave appears out of the house's well-trained air and, reading her face, decides to be needed in the corridor instead. “Whose stone?”

“The aedile's office would say the committee's. The committee would say the clerk's error.” Diomedes blots a line with the edge of his thumb, an Alexandrian trick he has never explained and she has never asked him to, it being house policy to let competent men keep one mystery each. “I have noted the hour he asked, and the hour he asked again. If a name travels, madam, it leaves footprints in other people's paperwork. You taught me that. In Naples, I believe, over a landlord.”

“I teach a great deal over landlords. It is my university.” She sets the cup down in its ring — she notices herself doing it and thinks of another house, a shrine room, a wife's hands, and files the thought where she files all thoughts with that address: between quarters, unopened. “Daphne is to be told her name was carried. Not frightened. Told. In this house nobody is protected by being uninformed; I have seen the other system work and it ends in Baiae.”

Eirene, who has finished the cake, says, “She'll want to sing about it.”

“She can sing about it in Greek, for people who know.” Antonia moves to the window. The street below is doing its noon business — a water-seller, a pair of advocates sharing a joke at a client's expense, a child herding three geese with a seriousness the Senate might study — all of it entirely uninformed that it has been represented this morning, on

paper, as a neighbourhood suffering from congregation and noise. “Congregation,” she says aloud. “They have inspected a dining house and discovered dining. Lentulus must be beside himself with the quality of his intelligence.”

“Careful,” Eirene says, mildly. “That's almost a compliment to his organisation.”

“It is a compliment to his father.” The street, the geese, the advocates. “The old man could settle a province with a steward and a sealed tablet. The son sends a man with a rod to find a kitchen and is surprised by soup. Families decline, Eirene. It is the one inheritance tax nobody evades.”

Diomedes closes the book. “Shall I reply to the aediles' office today?”

“You shall reply on the third day, in the first hand, thanking them for their diligence and enclosing a copy of the tax receipts they already possess. Nothing discourages an office like being thanked with its own paperwork.” She turns from the window. The house is reassembling itself around her for the evening — she can hear the day shift handing over to the night one in a murmur of keys and menus — and her face, which has worn the inspection since the third hour like a good coat, puts it down somewhere the staff will not have to look at it. “And Diomedes. The next time a name arrives here carried separately, I want the name of the carrier. Buy it the way we buy thread.”

“By the piece,” Diomedes says, “and without informing their fathers,” and goes out to spend her money in the invisible denominations.

■

Lentulus hears the report in a room off the Basilica where the light falls in tall, dusty slabs and every conversation sounds as if it were already being transcribed by history. The aedile's man is apologetic in the way of officials who have found nothing and must make nothing sound like

diligence. Registrations in order. Tax paid. Lease valid. Women of legal age and status, each accounted for. No unregistered slaves found on the premises. The house is, on paper, a dining establishment of unusual cleanliness.

"On paper," Lentulus repeats.

"On paper, senator, half of Rome is a temple."

It is a good line and the man knows it and regrets it in the same breath. Lentulus lets it pass. He has the colder problem of having aimed a public instrument at a private target and struck, with great precision, her paperwork — which she will now certainly have framed by the sheer force of having survived him.

Postumus, who has attached himself to the meeting in the manner of a relative who considers proximity a form of counsel, says when they are alone, "You knew she'd be clean. She was always clean. Even when —" He stops, with the belated tact of a man who has drunk at too many tables where the past was served as a side dish.

"Even when," Lentulus says pleasantly, "is not a period of history the Senate recognises. What do the banks say?"

Postumus brightens. Money is a country where his accent is native. "Her money is not where you'd think. Some in property through freedmen, some in loans through a Greek at the Basilica — very respectable Greek, the kind other Greeks call Roman when they want to insult him. She lends like a senator and collects like a landlord." He hesitates. "There is a rumour she holds paper on half the young men who dine there. Debts of honour, settled into debts of record. Quietly."

"Paper on whom, exactly?"

"Exactly is expensive. Approximately is free. Approximately: everyone you would not want named in a committee." Postumus watches him. "Old friend. If this is policy, it is bad policy, because she is cleaner than the policy. If it is not policy, it is worse, because she will know the difference even if the Senate pretends not to."

Outside, the Forum crowd of the previous day has thinned into litigants and money-changers and the perpetual float of men waiting to

be noticed by other men. Lentulus stands a moment under the portico and does an unfamiliar thing: he considers what he is doing as someone else might witness it. A man of ancient family, a former consul, a candidate in all but announcement for the Syrian command that will precede the emperor's eastern war, devoting the first weeks of the year to the registrations of a dining house on the Caelian. There are explanations a hostile world could supply. There is the explanation he supplies himself at hours when supply is low: that the city is rotting at its pleasures, that young men of good family are mortgaging estates to freedwomen's bankers, that someone whose name still means something must be seen to mean it.

The explanations hold together like a speech. They have that in common with speeches: they work best aloud, to others.

He walks home instead of taking the chair, which his household will hear about as a philosophy. The streets between the Basilica and the Palatine are full of the dedication's second day: workmen dismantling barriers, priests' boys reliving processions with sticks, a stallholder repainting his sign to include the word *imperial* in a hand that gets less certain toward the expensive letters. A client of his father's time, now very old and carried by a grandson who is visibly charging the whole transaction to his inheritance, recognises Lentulus and raises a hand like a standard being unfurled for the last time. Lentulus stops. This is also the work. Names are exchanged; a grandson is blessed in the formula; an old man is assured, in public, at a volume that recruits witnesses, that the Cornelii remember.

It costs four minutes and the price of a small farm in the currency his wife manages. Walking on, Lentulus does the sum he has been refusing since the portico: the committee's true arithmetic. For the registry to be policy, it must cost his friends something and be seen to. For it to be revenge, it must cost one woman everything and be deniable. A measure cannot be both at the full rate; Rome, which runs two sets of books as a civilisation — Greek and Latin libraries facing each other across the emperor's courtyard, each convinced it is the original — will ask him, in

the baths, in the toilets, in the terrible clarity of other men's jokes, which book he is keeping. He has been telling himself the answer in committee language for a month. The language is holding together like a speech, and a speech, as his grandfather used to say while the masks were still being made of men he had known personally, is just a wall that has decided to be admired instead of climbed.

At the house the door slave takes his cloak and the day off him in the same motion. Servilia, from the garden room, calls — without raising her voice; the house is built so that she never has to — that the Acilii have sent fish, that his son is out, that his daughter has sung the Greek one, once, to the music master only, a distinction the girl has negotiated like a harbour due. Lentulus stands a moment in his own hall being reported to like a province. Everything is in order. That is the intelligence his committee has produced, on every front, all week: order, itemised, at other people's addresses.

■

The embroiderer comes again on the third day, because Antonia, having seen the hanging up in the great dining room, has sent word that the border wants another row of the small red flowers whose name she does not know, and that the house will pay for the thread separately. The girl — no, Antonia corrects herself, the young woman; she dislikes in herself the diminishing word she hears all day from men — arrives with her work-box and her father's permission written in her posture, shoulders squared against a rebuke for being in such a house at all.

“You may work in the courtyard,” Antonia says. “The light is better and Barbatus will frighten away anyone who thinks a woman sewing is a woman waiting to be spoken to.”

“My father says I am not to eat here.”

“Your father is protecting your reputation from my kitchen. Very well. You will not eat. You will, however, drink, because I will not have a needlewoman faint among my roses and give the aediles a second

report to write.”

A smile escapes the young woman and is retrieved, but not fast enough to be unseen. She has a narrow face, dark brows, hands that know their trade so thoroughly the needle seems to be remembering rather than deciding. Her name, entered by Diomedes in the day-book under Payments to Trades, is Vibia Prima. Nineteen. Daughter of a freedman fuller in Transtiberim and a wife who died two winters ago. Betrothed, Eirene has already discovered — Eirene can discover a betrothal through a closed door; it is her one vulgar talent — to a baker's son with a shop near the Trigarium and a mother who inspects Prima's hems as if they were character references.

Prima's day, when she has a commission on the right bank, begins before the vats are lit, in a room that smells of yesterday's work whatever she does about it. This is not a complaint. Prima's relationship to smell is professional and, in its way, loyal: fullers' earth is honest, stale urine is merely chemistry with a history, and a clean garment coming off the frames has a smell she would put, in any honest census of Rome's perfumes, above rose oil bought to impress other people's wives. She heats her father's honey drink before she washes, because his cough is worst at the day's cold hinge and because if she washes first he will get up to do it himself, out of a doctrine — learned across a marriage and now carried alone like a hod — that a man who lets a house wake around him in bed is being buried by instalments.

“You're a garrison of one,” she tells him.

“I'm a fuller,” Vibius says. “We rise so Rome can pretend it was always clean.”

He drinks. She combs her hair at the window where the light comes in off the yard — grey light, working light, nothing like the Caelian courtyard's bar of sun, and she catches herself making the comparison and is annoyed at her own treachery. The comparison is new. It has come with the commission. She has sewn for good houses before — a priest's widow on the Aventine whose hems Prima still dreams about, badly; a contractor's wife who paid in compliments and festival cakes —

but the Caelian house is the first place that has ever paid her in a way that made her father's face do that thing over the soup. *Itemised.* The mistress across the river writes Prima's work down the way the guild writes a master's: by the piece, the thread separate, the sum at the bottom with a line under it. Prima has been an entry in other people's books before, usually under her father's name, as *daughter, sewing*. Under her own name she is taller. She knows this is paperwork and she knows it is not only paperwork, and she is savage with herself, combing, for being the kind of girl — woman, the mistress would say; the mistress corrects words the way Prima corrects seams, in passing, without permission — who can be bought with bookkeeping.

Her betrothed's mother has no such doubts, only different ones. On the stairs of the insula, where she stations herself on market mornings with the tactical instinct of a customs post, she receives Prima's news of a third day's work on the Caelian with a stillness you could hang cloth on.

“Three days for a border.”

“Two hundred flowers, Mother Livia. I counted them to the mistress. She pays by the piece.”

“She pays.” The older woman's eyes go, as they always go, to Prima's hands, her hem, the place where a reputation would show wear if reputations were garments — and to Mother Livia, who has raised four sons on bread and inspection, they are exactly garments. “A house like that pays everyone at the door, so the street can see. It's what happens off the street that gets into the cloth.”

“Then I shall stay on the street side of the courtyard,” Prima says, “where the light is, with the doorkeeper, who frightens the customers for a living. He is very respectable, Mother Livia. He has killed people in the arena for the emperor's grandfather and now he checks lamp oil. Rome promotes.”

It earns her, after a moment in which the customs post considers a seizure, a snort that in another woman would be a laugh. “You read too much.”

“I read Titus' accounts when his sums won't. Tell him his yeast man's bill is wrong by eleven sesterces in the yeast man's favour, which is the direction bills are usually wrong in. It's in the second column. He doesn't check second columns because the first one is his.”

This is Prima's armour and she knows it: usefulness, laid on thick as fuller's earth. A reading bride is a defect; a bride who finds eleven sesterces in a second column is a dowry with eyes. She goes down the stairs, with her work-box clutched against her ribs, rehearsing the ferry money — two coins for the boat if the bridge crowd is bad, one if she walks by the island and the water is low — and by the time she reaches the river the morning has become the kind of Roman morning that makes foreigners write letters home: light on the water, gulls from the sea quarrelling over the offal boats, the hills of the right bank standing up out of woodsmoke with their temples and tenements indistinguishable at this distance, which is the city's best angle and it knows it.

She walks. Prima always walks when the choice is hers; the ferry is full of men making room in ways that require management, and she prefers to spend management on thread. The island bridge, with its temple and its hospital slaves being aired like bedding on the parapet; the cattle market smelling of the beginning of dinner; the long climb through streets that change their prices every hundred paces. She likes the climb. She likes — she has never said this, she files it under things a fuller's daughter need not say — arriving at the Caelian house slightly out of breath, as if at the top of a sentence. Inside, the porter gives her the small room off the courtyard and a stool with its back to the traffic, *by the mistress's instruction*, and Barbatus, who frightens customers for a living, moves his own stool six feet without being asked, so that his shadow falls between her and the dining rooms. She has a fuller father's understanding of what is being laundered here. Her reputation is being washed in advance, by experts, at a cost somebody is itemising as thread.

She sets the frame. She counts, chin tucked, mouth open on the number. The red flowers have a rhythm like a work-song and she goes into it the way the men in the vats go into the treading, not thinking, in the approved manner, at all — which is when, as every needlewoman and fuller and soldier knows, the thinking arrives that has been waiting its turn. Today it is her mother's voice, two years dead and clearer than the living: *count the stairs, so the stairs don't count you.* Ninety, in Baiae. Prima has seen the sea once, from Ostia, on a guild outing that cost her father a week's coughing; Baiae lives in her head as a staircase standing in blue light, with her mother on it, young, carrying linen, counting. She does not know why the mistress of this house went quiet — *the way rich women go quiet at a price*, she told her father, and he had held his blanket like a rail and not answered — when Prima passed on the stairs saying. Perhaps the mistress has been to Baiae. Rich women go to Baiae the way other people's linen goes to the fullers: regularly, and to be improved. Perhaps the mistress once had a laundress.

The needle goes in. The needle comes out. Somewhere beyond the courtyard a singer is practising, running a phrase up a staircase of notes and down again, counting, counting, and Prima — who does not eat in this house, whose father has protected her reputation from its kitchen, who will drink water in a moment from the mistress's own hand because the mistress will not have a needlewoman faint among her roses — feels, without any language for it that her street would accept, that she is being watched the way work is watched by someone who has done it. Not the customers' watching. A tradeswoman's. It straightens her back without her permission. She sews the next flower as if it were evidence.

Antonia watches her work a moment longer than supervision requires. There is a way the girl holds her head when she is counting stitches, chin tucked, mouth slightly open on the number, that plucks at something in Antonia which she files, with the swiftness of long practice, under the general sorrow of watching the young be young in a city that charges for it. She goes back to her accounts.

She does not notice — because she is a woman who notices prices, exits and the weather in a man's voice, and no one notices everything — the small, pale mark on the inside of Prima's left wrist, shaped, if a person were fanciful, like a half-closed eye. The needle goes in. The needle comes out. The red flowers multiply along the border, each one the same, each one, if you look closely, which Prima's future mother-in-law certainly will, very slightly alive with difference.

Chapter Three

Clients in the Morning

. . .

A great house in Rome begins the day by being besieged politely. From first light the atrium fills: clients in clean togas they cannot afford to clean often, freedmen with petitions folded to the size of embarrassment, a poet with an epic in a bucket, two cousins from Arpinum who believe the Cornelii owe their grandfather a magistracy. Servilia moves among the preparations like a quartermaster who has read the campaign plan and found it sentimental. Lentulus receives, remembers names, distinguishes the man who needs a loan from the man who needs the mention of a loan in front of witnesses, and keeps, beneath the surface of the morning, a steady count of what each greeting will cost and in what currency it can be repaid.

It is not cynicism. Or rather, he would say, it is not only cynicism. Patronage is the city's true aqueduct: favour flows downhill, obligation climbs back up, and everyone is wet. His father taught him to receive clients standing, so that no man could say the Cornelii sat while Rome asked. His father also taught him — not in words; in the disposition of estates, in marriages proposed over maps — that a family survives by converting land into loyalty and loyalty back into land before either currency fails.

The first client is the poet, because poets are always first, having the least to do after. He is called Quintus Valerius Soranus, after three men who would have paid to stop him, and he carries his epic in a bucket because the book-boxes are full — twelve books on the Dacian wars, in which the emperor appears, by the poet's own proud census, two hundred and forty times, and the Cornelii, by a creative interpretation of the campaign rolls, four. He does not want money, which is the first thing poets say in atria. He wants the work *heard by a person whose*

hearing signifies, which is money in a laurel wreath. Lentulus hears the proem standing, as he hears everything at this hour, and finds, to his own mild disgust, that it is not contemptible. The man can do a river crossing. Rivers are his metre's home address.

“The passage where the bridge goes over at night,” Lentulus says. “Cut the catalogue of timbers by half.”

Soranus clutches the bucket like a hostage. “The timbers are documentary.”

“So is a tax return. We do not recite them at dinner.” Lentulus takes, from the tray his steward holds at the correct angle of invisibility, a small purse that the household prepares each morning in three sizes — Servilia calls them *encouragement*, *dismissal*, and *danger* — and gives the poet the middle one. “Read the bridge, and only the bridge, at Acilius' next evening. I will see that you are invited. If Acilius' guests are still awake at the far bank, we will discuss the remaining eleven books.”

The poet bows so low the bucket tips. Somewhere in the arithmetic of patronage a bridge has just been funded, and a poet's winter, and a small lien placed on the memory of the Dacian wars, where the Cornelii now appear four times, by purchase. This is how history is made in Rome before it is carved. The carving comes later, when the embarrassing parts have been paid for and can be omitted respectably.

The second client is not one man but a delegation: three freedmen of a Cornelian grain depot at Ostia, come up to Rome with a lawsuit in one satchel and, in another, smoked fish for the household, which Servilia's steward accepts with the gravity due to tribute between nations. Their case is a warehouse boundary, a neighbour's wall, a measurement disputed to the width of a man's hand — matters on which, as Lentulus listens, some hundreds of people's dinners actually depend, though no epic will ever spend a river on them. He asks the one question their advocate has evidently forbidden them to answer — who owns the wall's other side — and watches them decide, in a three-way flicker of eyes, to trust the atrium instead.

“The Avidii,” says the eldest, in the voice of a man confessing weather. “The new depot. Since the autumn.”

Lentulus looks at the wax masks, who look back with three centuries of practice at receiving this kind of news before breakfast. His daughter's possible marriage has just acquired a party wall. Rome is a village with aqueducts; he has known it since he was twenty and it has never once been convenient.

“You will not sue,” he says. “You will survey — a surveyor of my choosing, paid from this house, so that his findings are a favour and not a missile — and the Avidii will be shown his rods at a dinner, not a tribunal. A hand's width, gentlemen, is a negotiating instrument. In court it becomes a principle, and principles eat warehouses.”

They bow over the solution, relieved in the way of men who came for a war and are being given a boundary stone and a hot breakfast. The steward moves them toward the kitchens. On their way out they pass the two cousins from Arpinum, standing in togas of a whiteness that argues long storage and short funds, rehearsing, without moving their lips, the case that the Cornelii owe their grandfather a magistracy. Lentulus can see the case's whole future from where he stands: ten minutes of genealogy, produced like a sword from a walking stick; his own reply, in the formula his father used — *the family's gratitude is a matter of record* — which is Latin for a door; and then Servilia, later, telling him the Arpinum cousins have a cousin of their own in the harbour dues office, and that gratitude ought therefore to be put on the record in a more spendable denomination. She will be right. She is the quartermaster of gratitude. He merely issues it at parades.

Between clients, in the breath the atrium takes, he is aware of the household performing the morning as his wife has scored it: the door slave admitting no one whose name the steward has not tasted first; the boy with the guest-towels; the clerk at the side table writing, in a book that is the family's true epic, who came, what they asked, what they were given, what it will cost when it comes back — and everything comes back; that is the aqueduct. Cornelia crosses the far end of the atrium on

her way to her lesson with her scroll held like something she is rescuing rather than carrying, and does not look at the clients, who must not be given a daughter to look at in business hours; the rule is Servilia's, older than the girl, part of the house's fortifications. Lentulus watches his daughter not look at his morning and feels, obscurely, audited.

A veteran is waiting too, further back, in the place men put themselves when they have been clients before and know the tariff of patience. He has Moesia in his face and one hand that the years since have taught to do the work of the other one. Lentulus served — *served* is the household word; his own, privately, is *attended* — with the man's legion in a winter he does not recount at dinners. He will keep the veteran last, because what the man needs is not a purse-size but a recommendation to a land commission, which takes the time it takes, and because the Arpinum cousins must be seen to be received before the veteran is *seen to matter more than they do*, which everyone in the atrium already knows and the order of the morning must conspire not to say. Patronage, he thinks, for the thousandth time, in the exact tone of a man reading his own inscription as someone else carves it: it is not a system for distributing help. It is a system for distributing the appearance of help in an order nobody can afford to dispute. His father would have called that a provincial sentiment too, and then received his clients in the same order, standing, for fifty years.

The man from the Campanian agent is third, and he is the morning's true weather. The harvest loans have been rolled over twice. The interest, compounded through a banker whose name Lentulus prefers not to write in his own hand, now stands against the olive groves above Capua and, behind a veil of legal Latin, against the house on the Palatine itself.

“How long?” Lentulus asks.

“The banker is patient, dominus.”

“Bankers are patient the way rivers are patient. I asked how long.”

“Until the autumn, certainly. Beyond the autumn he will want a payment that signifies intention.”

“A payment always signifies intention. That is its function.”

The agent bows over the blow and withdraws to be given breakfast by a household that feeds its creditors' messengers better than some families feed their sons, because hunger talks.

Servilia, when the atrium has thinned, says, “Cornelia has been asked to sing at the house of the Acilii. She will go, she will sing one song, she will not sing the Greek one. Her voice is an asset and I will not have it spent like loose change.” Cornelia, sixteen, stands in the doorway of her mother's room with a scroll crushed slightly in one hand, being discussed in the third person in the manner of daughters and provinces. She has learnt — Lentulus sees it and is, obscurely, both proud and sorry — not to let her face bid in an auction she is not permitted to enter.

“And the Avidii?” he asks.

“The Avidii have money from shipping and a son with all his teeth. Their name was made by a man who unloaded grain. In two generations it will be an old name, because their grandchildren will pay historians.” Servilia folds a cloth that does not need folding. “We need money that does not smell of the docks, Lentulus, and we need it without being seen to need it. That is the whole of my position. It has been the whole of my position since the Campanian accounts came home in November, and I notice it becomes no larger for being restated.”

Cornelia says, “May I go to my lesson, Mother?”

“You may. Do not let the music master touch your wrist to correct it. He corrects what does not require correction.”

When the girl has gone, Lentulus says, “You think I should take the Avidii.”

“I think you should know the price of refusing them. You have always known the price of everything except refusal. Refusal you treat as free, because your family has been able to afford it for three hundred years.” She looks toward the atrium, where a slave is sweeping the morning's footprints toward the street door in long, even strokes. “Three hundred years is not a sum of money, husband. It is only a story we tell the money.”

When she has gone, the atrium settles its morning accounts without her: clients to the street, breakfast to the clients who missed it standing, the clerk's book to the steward, the steward to the kitchens with the day's small change of favour itemised into meals. Lentulus dictates letters in his study with the windows open to the winter garden, where nothing is flowering and everything is being cut back by a gardener who conducts pruning as a branch of political theory. To the Campanian agent: patience, arrangements, the vintage invoked like a god with a good memory. To a fellow senator whose vote he needs on the harbour dues and whose son he has just, at ruinous expense of dignity, praised in the Senate toilets — the true committee rooms of Rome, where men stand in a row and tell each other the truth at a fixed distance — a letter of such warmth that his secretary, who is paid to believe dictation, raises an eyebrow he is not paid for.

"Read it back," Lentulus says.

The secretary reads. The warmth, read back, sounds like upholstery.

"Send it," Lentulus says. "Upholstery is what coalitions sit on."

From the far side of the garden comes Cornelia's lyre, and the music master's voice, and the particular silence where a correction by hand would go if this household permitted what half of Rome permits and calls tuition. The master is a Greek of forty with a reputation he keeps bandaged, and Servilia's instruction about the wrist has clearly reorganised his entire method into metaphor: *as if the string were a thread, domina; as if the hand were coming home from a journey*. Cornelia plays. She plays the figure correctly, and then — Lentulus hears it because a father who has sat through committees develops an ear for the inserted clause — she plays it again with something added, a turn of her own, small and unlicensed and unmistakably hers, and the master's voice, after a pause in which a career is weighed against an ear, says, "Again, domina. The second way."

Lentulus stands at his window with a letter about harbour dues going cold in the secretary's hand and listens to his daughter insert herself, note by note, into music older than the family. He thinks: this is what we

are selling to the Avidii, and the word *selling*, which Marcus used at a dinner table and was rebuked for, stands in his own mind unrebuked, in a locked room, at his usual rates. Not the girl — the form insists, and the form is a kind of truth. The name. The thing the name will do for a shipping family's grandchildren in rooms this girl will decorate with a voice her mother issues like a ration: one song, not the Greek. He thinks of the Greek at the Basilica, in whose quiet office this family's name is presently sitting in a file, being patient like a river. He thinks — the garden, the pruning, the note again, the second way — of the other file, in the cupboard under his grandfather's mask, where a different accounting of his name has been sitting for nine years being patient like something worse than a river. Like a debt in a currency bankers fear to touch.

"Dominus?" the secretary says.

"Nothing. A correction." Lentulus turns back to the letters. "In the letter to the agent. Where I say the family will make a payment signifying intention — strike *signifying intention*. Put: *the family will pay*. If we are to be hauled up our own aqueduct by our creditors, we may as well arrive with clean Latin."

The secretary, who has written *signifying intention* for this family for eleven years, strikes it with a stylus stroke so deep it goes through the wax to the wood. Outside, the gardener cuts something back to a knuckle and stands looking at it with the satisfaction of a man who believes, professionally, in return growth. The lyre plays the figure a third time. The second way. It is better. Everyone in earshot of the garden, including the truth, knows it is better.

■

Antonia's morning clients are not called clients. They are called the wine merchant wanting a longer credit, the mother of a girl in the Subura who has heard that Antonia pays for midwives without asking whose child it is, the ageing actor who once played kings and now plays, with great

dignity, a man asking for the loan of a dining room for his benefit recital. She receives them sitting, because a woman who stands to receive in her own house looks like staff. She receives them quickly, because slowness in others is a tax she declines to pay twice.

Daphne comes last, which is strategy, and not hers alone: Eirene has held her back until Antonia has eaten. Daphne is twenty-two, freed three years, with a voice that makes men believe they have finer feelings than their conduct supports. She is wearing, at an hour when no one is performing anything, a necklace of green stones that Antonia has not seen before.

“Sit down,” Antonia says. “Take it off first. I want to talk to you, not to it.”

Daphne takes it off with the languor she uses on stage when a heroine removes a crown. In her palm the stones look smaller. Most gifts do, Antonia reflects, when they come off the body and into the light of an office.

“He says they are emeralds.”

“He lies professionally or he lies as a hobby?”

“He is a senator's son. It may be both.”

“Marcus Lentulus,” Antonia says. It is not a question, because Diomedes keeps the door-book better than the Senate keeps its minutes.

Daphne, who is not a fool, stops arranging her face. “He hears me sing. He talks about his father the way men talk about weather in a country they mean to emigrate from. He has given me glass stones and a great deal of true information, and I think he believes the exchange was the other way round.”

“What information?”

“That the father means to press the committee. That there is talk of the Syrian appointment and that the father needs to be seen as a man who cleans stables. That the sister is to be sold — his word is married, but he is twenty and drunk on being the only honest man in his family — to shipping money. That the Cornelii owe—” she pauses “—everyone.”

Antonia is very still. In the courtyard someone laughs, a real laugh, the pastry cook's, and a dove answers from the roof tiles with its soft, stupid music. “You will give the necklace back,” she says.

“Antonia—”

“You will give it back with the message that you admired it too much to risk it among musicians. He will understand that he has been caught lying and forgiven beautifully, and he will be yours for another month and truthful for at least a week. Glass accepted is a price agreed, Daphne. I did not free you — I did not pay your former owner a sum I still resent remembering — so that a Lentulus could buy you again wholesale.”

“You say his name,” Daphne says quietly, “the way other people say a street they used to live in.”

“I say it the way I say the tax office. With respect for its power to inconvenience me.” Antonia stands, which ends it. But at the door she stops, because the girl — the young woman, the freedwoman with glass in her palm — is looking at the stones as if they might yet argue their case. “You want things that are real,” Antonia says, more gently. “So did I. The city will offer you a great many shining substitutes and call your refusal ingratitude. Refuse anyway. A real stone can be sold in a bad winter. Remember which of the two you are collecting.”

Daphne stays in the small room when Antonia has gone, with the glass stones cooling in her palm like a story cooling into evidence. She has been free for three years, and freedom, she is learning in instalments, is mostly the right to decide which instructions to be angry about. Antonia's instruction is good. That is what makes it galling. A bad order can be disobeyed with a clear conscience and a song; a good one must be followed in full view of one's own judgment, nodding.

Eirene comes in with the day's flowers for the small room — winter roses, forced and faintly resentful — and looks at the necklace the way she looks at everything expensive and unearned in this house: as a management problem with a clasp.

“He'll bring a real one next time,” Daphne says.

“He'll bring a worse lie and a better dinner story. They learn in that order, those boys; it is a family curriculum.” Eirene sets the flowers down and begins, out of thirty years of habit, to sort them by the life left in them. “I was given a necklace once by a man who owned the house I worked in, the street it stood in and, as the law then filed it, me. Real stones. Wonderful stones. I wore them at his table for two years and when he died his son's steward took them off my neck with a receipt. *Household property*, he said. He wasn't even unkind. Kindness wasn't in the inventory either.”

Daphne closes her hand over the glass. “Antonia never tells that story.”

“Antonia tells nobody's story, including Antonia's. It is why this house can charge what it charges.” Eirene holds a rose up to the light, finds it acceptable, forgives it. “Give the glass back beautifully, as instructed. Keep the information, as instructed. And when you are my age, Daphne, buy your own stones with money that has your name in a Greek's book, and let some senator's son explain to the room what they are. There is no music like it. I have heard Philomela. I know whereof I speak.”

■

That night the house fills in its ordinary, extraordinary way: a grain contractor celebrating a contract he cannot yet announce, two equestrians negotiating a partnership over courses designed to slow them down, an elderly advocate who comes for the music and stays, chastely and entirely, for the pleasure of being listened to by women who are paid to find the law interesting and have become, over the years, genuinely formidable on the subject of inheritance. Antonia moves between rooms as she always moves, present everywhere the way a key signature is present in music. She tastes the sauce for the dormice and sends it back. She settles, with four words and a hand on an elbow, a quarrel between cousins over a wager on the races. She notes,

without writing, that the grain contractor's partner drinks only water after the fish course, which means he is either ill, devout, or negotiating in earnest — and files it under all three.

Consider the fish. Ammonius does, at the length other men give to mistresses. It has come up from Ostia in wet straw on a mule that is now, by house policy, being fed in the yard at a standard the muleteer describes to the kitchen boy as *senatorial*. The grain contractor, whose unannounced triumph the evening exists to celebrate without announcing, is a man from Puteoli with a face like a harbour wall and manners he has had built for him by a succession of wives, each better born than the last. He knows fish the way bankers know weather. He tastes Ammonius' sauce — the sauce has been sent back once tonight already, by Antonia, with a message consisting of the word *again* — and closes his eyes.

"My ships," he says, "should carry this instead of grain."

"Your ships," says his partner, who drinks water after the fish course and is therefore, as Antonia has already filed, negotiating in earnest, "would arrive empty. The crews have votes too."

It gets the laugh — from the table, from the corner where Philomela is resting between songs with a cup she is not drinking, for the voice — and into the laugh's warmth the partner slides the actual evening: tonnage, winter sailings, a clause about spoilage that has clearly been the subject of a war in somebody's office. Antonia, passing with the unhurried visibility of a hostess who is also the management, hears the clause resolve itself between the fish and the boar, in the presence of witnesses too well fed to be bought cheaply later. This is the house's true menu. Men book her rooms the way they book notaries: so that agreements acquire flavour and cannot afterwards be said to have happened in an atmosphere of duress. She charges for the food. The peace of mind is itemised as music.

The elderly advocate — he is called Mamercus, he is seventy-one, he has outlived two emperors, three wives and the fashion for his best courtroom manner, which was irony before irony was taxed — holds his

usual court in the small room, and his court, as usual, is women. Tonight it is Daphne, between songs, and a widow of equestrian family who comes to the house, chaperoned by a freedwoman of ferocious respectability, to hear music her own household calls unsuitable for a mourning that has entered its fourth year and shows signs of being redecorated. Mamercus is explaining, with the patience of a man who has explained it in basilicas for money, why a will made in a fit of gratitude is the most dangerous document in Roman law.

"Gratitude," he says, "is an intoxicant. Worse. Wine wears off by morning and a man may plead it. Gratitude *improves* overnight, like your mistress's stock, and by the time the witnesses are called he believes he owes his life to a person who has merely returned his seal-ring from a dining-room floor." He looks sideways at Antonia, who is passing and has never, in eleven years, returned anything without first ensuring its owner fully experiences having lost it. "Present company professionally excepted."

"You lost a stylus here in November, Mamercus," Antonia says. "Shall I make a will about it?"

"You returned the stylus with a lecture on the price of ivory. I have left it to my grandson as a moral instrument."

The widow laughs — startles herself with it, checks the freedwoman, finds no tribunal there — and laughs again, properly. Antonia marks it. There is a tariff of grief in Rome, precisely observed by the women it is levied on and quoted back at them by everyone else, and part of what her house sells, unitemised anywhere, is a room where a respectable widow may discover at seventy — no, at fifty, the widow is fifty and has been filed by her family under furniture — that her laugh still works at its original specification. She will book again. She will bring, in time, a niece. Empires of Antonia's kind are not built on the appetites Rome confesses to in the baths. They are built on the ones it doesn't: to be listened to, to be well fed without owing a marriage for it, to sit in a room where the women are professionally not shocked and the men are contractually not owners, and hear a very old advocate explain

inheritance law like a love song.

In the great room the two equestrians have arrived, by way of Ammonius' boar, at the brink of their partnership, and are toasting it in a Falernian whose route to this table — a carter, a lesson, a cellar book — they will never know. One of them waylays Antonia by the serving door with the confidence of a man who believes charm should be volume-discounted.

“We want the big room in April,” he says. “For the signing feast. Forty covers. Can the house do forty?”

“The house has done sixty for men who sign bigger,” Antonia says. “April is three months away. Rome may fall, your partner may sober up, the price of boar—”

“Then it's booked?”

“It is *pencilled*,” she says, “which in this house means Diomedes has it in wax, and wax, young man, has carried the whole of Roman law for a thousand years. Come in February with a deposit and a list of who must not sit beside whom. That list is the feast. The food is what we serve while the list works.”

He laughs, delighted to be handled; men of his age and order pay extra for the sensation, which Antonia's day-book records without comment under *room hire, premium*. She moves on. The musicians change; Daphne rises to sing, and the room does the thing rooms do for her now, settling with a small, collective adjustment of cushions and standards. She sings a Greek air first, for form, and then a Roman street tune she has slowed down until it sounds like a hymn that has seen things, and the grain contractor — harbour wall, three wives, fleet impounded in a sauce — is seen by Philomela, and reported to the kitchen, to wipe his eyes with the back of his hand and immediately appoint the gesture to the pepper.

This is the second hour's approach. Antonia clocks it by the lamps: the boy has trimmed them once, will trim them again before the steward's hour; the second trimming is her signal to check the door-book and the street, because after it the evening belongs to whoever has

stayed, and staying late in her house is a category of person she likes to choose personally. She is at the door-book, with Barbatus' thumb blacking the margin where he has checked a seal, when Diomedes comes up the corridor with the evening's messages on a tray he uses for the purpose — a nice distinction, his, between paper and food, which he maintains the whole of Roman administration fails to. Bills, a booking from a Spaniard with silver interests, a note from a lady whose handwriting Diomedes has placed, correctly, before unfolding it. And underneath, where a man who keeps three books in three hands puts the item a day will be audited by: a folded sheet with no seal at all.

At the second hour of the night Diomedes brings her, among the ordinary messages, a folded note with no seal, in a hand she knows before she opens it the way one knows a step on a stair.

It says: *Withdraw the young men and I withdraw the committee. We need not meet to arrange what we both understand.*

There is no signature. Lentulus never learned that an unsigned note is still a signature if the handwriting is the one that taught you, at seventeen, how to shape the letter that begins your name.

Antonia holds it a moment over the lamp — not to burn it. She never burns paper that could be evidence or leverage or, on a night when the accounts are done and the house is loud with other people's appetites, company. She folds it once, precisely, and puts it in the box where she keeps the tax receipts, between the quarters.

“Tell the messenger,” she says to Diomedes, “that the house thanks his master for his interest in its guest list, and that the guest list, like the tax receipts, is filed quarterly.”

Diomedes, who has translated her meaning into survival for eleven years, bows and goes to find the exact tone in which a non-answer can be made to sound like a door closing in a well-built house.

Chapter Four

What the Baths Know

. . .

The baths at the eighth hour are Rome with its clothes off and its guard, paradoxically, up. Steam, oil, the slap of feet on wet mosaic, a ball game in the exercise yard conducted with the seriousness of a border dispute. Lentulus goes twice a week and never on the days his son goes, an arrangement both of them maintain without ever having made it. A man's friendships are audited in the baths. So are his enmities; the water carries everything.

Lentulus arrives with his own oil flask, his own strigils in a case his grandfather's campaign chest would recognise, and a slave, Onesimus, whose entire public personality is a talent for standing in the one spot in any room where a senator's conversation cannot be overheard by accident. Onesimus has served in this capacity for eleven years. He has heard, in that time, three treasons discussed as hypotheticals, one discussed as a menu, and enough provincial appointments traded over naked men exercising to staff, on paper, a second empire. He forgets professionally. It is understood in the household that when Onesimus is freed — the will is written, the sum named, Servilia has seen to it with her usual prospective kindness — he will forget his own manumission ceremony by the following morning, out of habit.

The exercise yard first: the ball game is at the stage where old friendships are being audited at speed. A former praetor with a knee like a rusty hinge is holding the centre by reputation alone, directing younger men with a general's economy: a chin here, a lifted eyebrow there, the whole art of command reduced to upholstery. Lentulus takes three rounds, no more; more would be a statement about Syria, less would be a statement about his shoulder, and the yard reads statements the way the tax office reads returns, professionally and without charity. He plays

well enough to be unremarkable, which in this company is a form of excellence no one will ever carve.

In the anointing room the news is hung up with the clothes. A letter from Athens is doing the rounds in summary — Hadrian has been archon, Hadrian has been initiated, Hadrian has opinions about a temple that has waited six hundred years for a roof and will now, the summary implies, be roofed by personality alone. A young attaché recently returned to Rome is retailing it all with the exhausted air of a man whose luggage contained, besides linen, the future.

“He spoke Greek to the masons,” the attaché says. “Not through a secretary. To them.”

“Barbarous,” says the former praetor, pleasantly, towelling a knee that predates the fashion. “An emperor-in-waiting who can talk to workmen will expect answers. There'll be an end to government.”

Nobody says *emperor-in-waiting* again. The phrase does a small, satisfied circuit of the room anyway, the way the pickpocket did the Forum crowd, feeling for attention to settle in. Onesimus, at the wall, forgets it in three languages. Lentulus, submitting to oil and the scraper, files it where he files all such futures: under *weather*, *eastern*, *approaching*. Trajan is not old as emperors go and is fit as a man can be who has spent his life being carried toward wars expressly to walk through them; but the succession in Rome is a bath-house topic the way rain is a farmer's, not because it is imminent but because everything planted waits on it. A Syrian command under Trajan is a career. The same command remembered under his successor is either a recommendation or a headstone, and a man calculating the one, in warm rooms, naked as an egg, does well to calculate the other.

The scraper finds the Moesia shoulder and the old injury sends up its small, familiar dispatch: *present, not urgent, keeping the minutes*. He got it falling from a horse that had been described to him by a quartermaster as steady, a word he no longer allows in documents. History, in other people's telling, has promoted the fall into a skirmish; a nephew once asked about the skirmish at dinner and Lentulus, to

Servilia's audible approval down the table, described the horse instead, at length, until the skirmish died of documentation. It remains his favourite of his own speeches. There are so few of them with a horse in that he is willing to sign.

“Your son was here at the sixth hour, dominus,” says the bath attendant, who is called Felix too — half the useful men in Rome are — and who retails the household's movements to the household as a kind of preventative medicine. “With young Avidius. They won at ball. There was a matter of a wager settled amicably, and the young master paid a debt *for* a friend which the friend had intended to settle by talking. The talk, if I may say so, was filed as insufficient.”

“Whose debt?”

“The friend's name was not in my hearing, dominus. The sum was in everyone's.”

Lentulus holds out his arm for the towel with the expression of a man receiving a committee report in a format he prefers to the Senate's. Marcus paying other men's debts: there is a future in that sentence in several denominations, and all of them will arrive at his atrium in the end, because that is what sons and aqueducts have in common in his life at forty-five — what is sent downhill comes home by the plumbing. He says, “If my son's generosity is to be a season, Felix, the house would like the weather early.”

“I shall keep the sky watched, dominus,” says Felix, and they go through into the heat in their order, senator, slave, oil, news, like a small procession at a dedication nobody has inscribed.

Acilius, who will be consul within the year if the emperor's favour holds, falls into step beside him in the warm room with the ease of a man who has rehearsed spontaneity. “Syria,” Acilius says, naming the whole conversation in advance so that they can both pretend to have wandered into it. “The emperor will want a governor in place before he moves east. A name that reassures the legions and does not frighten the Senate. Yours is spoken.”

“Names are spoken in baths the way steam is made. Abundantly and on purpose.”

“Yours is also spoken at dinner.” Acilius lowers himself into the water with a sigh that is half politics, the sound a man makes to suggest that what follows is reluctant. “There is one — untidiness. It is said your committee work looks personal. In a candidate for Syria, personal is a colour the emperor does not wear.”

“And who says it looks personal?”

“People who dine on the Caelian.” Acilius smiles with his eyes only, a trick of men who expect to be carved one day and are practising for the bust. “Old friend, I have eaten there. Half the men who will vote on your appointment have eaten there. The food is excellent and the discretion has been, until now, architectural. If you shake that house, things will fall out of it. Some of them will have names you need.”

The water is at Lentulus's ribs. Heat works on the old injury in his shoulder, the one from a horse in Moesia that history has since promoted into something more martial in other people's telling. He thinks of his father's voice on the subject of appetites: *A Cornelius may have them. He may not be had by them.* He thinks, unbidden and therefore with irritation, of a courtyard in a house that no longer stands, of a girl laughing with a stylus behind her ear like a flower, utterly unaware that a stylus behind the ear was, in his father's Rome, a flag planted on the wrong hill.

“I am not shaking a house,” he says. “I am proposing that houses which profit from the sons of senators be registered, taxed and inspected like any other trade that could burn a neighbourhood down. If that reads as personal, it is because Rome personalises everything except responsibility.”

“Then make it read as general,” Acilius says mildly. “Inspect ten houses. Inspect twenty. At present you have inspected one, at dawn, by committee. Rome can count, Lentulus. That is its least attractive quality.”

The cold room receives them like a verdict. Men go into the water with sounds they would not permit themselves in the Senate and come out of it looking, briefly, the age they were when the century was still negotiable. Acilius, who does everything in order, including spontaneity, waits until they are both in up to the waist and the attendants have withdrawn to the distance that Onesimus has arranged with a look — Onesimus and the Acilian equivalent having conducted, in five seconds of eye contact, the entire diplomatic history of their profession — before he finishes the conversation the warm room started.

"Hadrian writes that Athens is teaching him what Rome is for."

"Athens," Lentulus says, "has been teaching Romans what Rome is for for two hundred years. We keep enrolling. It saves thinking."

"He also asks — through Plotina's people, so it is a question with a return address — who in Rome can draft. Not speak. Draft. A man who can put a complicated thing in a sentence that walks. Your name came up in a context I chose not to improve."

The cold is doing its work on the shoulder: first outrage, then a deep, clean ache, then the body's reluctant agreement that it is still a going concern. Lentulus looks at the mosaic under the water, Neptune in pieces of coloured stone, his trident refracted into something pastoral. "I am flattered to be a context."

"You are being offered a chance to be useful to a future that has not yet had the courtesy to announce itself. It is the only kind of usefulness that compounds." Acilius ducks under (Once. Correctly. As if there were marks.), and comes up streaming. "Drop the single-house siege, Lentulus. Make it a registry, make it general, make it boring, and let Athens hear of a draftsman. Or keep the siege, and let Athens hear of a feud. Feuds are memoir. Drafts are government."

On the far side of the plunge, a gaunt equestrian who made money in the Spanish mines is telling the water about his kidneys, in detail, with dates. Two boys — not young enough to be charming, not old enough to be listened to — are conducting a drowning contest that the attendants will stop at the precise moment it becomes the kind of death that needs

paperwork. The ordinary empire, naked, wet, going about its real business of being a place. Lentulus watches it the way he watches the Forum from the portico: as a system that works best at everything except admitting what it is.

“When I was twenty-four,” he says, and stops, because the sentence has arrived without its paperwork and the cold room is not a locked one.

Acilius, who has known him since they were both young enough to be corrected by tutors, does the most senatorial thing available: he does not hear the beginning of the sentence. He hears the whole of its history, files it, and answers the part that can be answered in water. “When you were twenty-four, we all drafted badly. Some of us with juries, some with marriages.” He hauls himself out onto the edge and sits dripping, a future consul at the mercy of a towel. “I have a dinner Thursday. Plotina's freedwoman will be at it, which means the empress will know by Friday what was served, in both senses. Come. Bring Servilia. Leave the committee at home in a locked room; it's what they're for.”

“My wife,” Lentulus says, “says this family cannot feed pets.”

“Your wife,” Acilius says, “should be governing Syria. It would save everyone a great deal of ceremony, including the Syrians.” He stands; the towel arrives; the future resumes its clothes in the next room. “Thursday, Lentulus. And if your son is going to pay his friends' debts, tell him to do it before the vintage. Generosity in a young man reads as principle. After a bad harvest it reads as a system.”

He goes out with his people in their order. Lentulus stays in the water a count of fifty longer than comfort advises, because the cold is the one counsel in Rome that wants nothing from him, and because Onesimus, at the wall, has the face of a man who has forgotten three futures since the oil and will forget this one into the record too — all of it held, all of it sealed, like a tablet in a cupboard under a mask.

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Marcus hears about the conversation before his father's oil is dry, because the baths have a second plumbing system, made of slaves, and his dice creditors keep him plumbed in. He hears it in the version that will do the rounds by dinner: *Lentulus warned off the Caelian by Acilius. Syria in the balance. The woman has names.* He is twenty years old and the news strikes him not as danger but as proof — proof that the house on the Caelian, where the wine is honest and a freedwoman sings like a person addressing him rather than his pedigree, is the one true place in Rome where power admits what it is.

He goes there that night because going there has acquired, in the alchemy of prohibition, the flavour of a political position. Antonia sees him come in. She sees the friend he has brought, a young Avidius with shipping money and a laugh too loud for the room he is in, and she performs, in a single glance exchanged with Diomedes, the whole arithmetic of the evening: what the boy's presence costs his father, what it earns the house, what it risks for Daphne, who is — she hears it in the first phrase — singing better than she has sung all month, which is its own kind of risk.

"You should send me away," Marcus says to her in the interval, with the bravado of youth offering its hostess a sword to fall on. "My father would. In your place."

"I am not in his place," Antonia says. "That has been established by committee. Drink your wine slowly, Marcus. It is the only advice I give young men that they can follow without a tutor."

"He wants you closed."

"He wants to be seen wanting me closed. There is a difference, and the difference is where I live." She is aware, even as she says it, of the Avidius boy listening with the deep attention of new money at an old lesson. She pitches the next sentence for him too. "Your father and I disagree about the governance of this city. He believes it is governed from the Senate house. I believe it is governed wherever men tell the truth after the fish course. We are both, in our way, patriots."

Marcus laughs, delighted, disloyal, young. Across the room Daphne returns the necklace — Antonia watches the choreography, the little press of the palm, the sentence about musicians — and watches the boy receive his own lie back as a keepsake, and love the woman who returned it the way men love being forgiven beautifully: entirely, and for about a week, exactly as predicted.

Daphne sings the second set differently, and the room knows it before it knows why. The first set is always the house's: accomplished, priced, a demonstration that everyone's money is in the right building. The second set, on the nights it happens, is the singer's. Antonia, who could forbid it — she could forbid anything in these rooms; that is what ownership means when a woman has bought it in the currency she has — permits it on an economic principle she would not insult Daphne by explaining: a woman who never sings her own set will one day sing somebody else's, in somebody else's house, and take the room's heart with her as severance. Generosity, like honesty, is a long position. Eirene, who has heard this doctrine applied to rings, menus and one unforgettable negotiation with a lamp-seller over a daughter's dowry, refers to it in the kitchen as *the mistress's religion, second service*.

Tonight the second set is a song from the theatres that Daphne has slowed, the way she slows street tunes, until the comedy has drained out of it and the woman in the song — a slave girl in the original, getting the better of a master the audience has paid to see fooled — stands in the music with her trickery suddenly looking like the only arithmetic on offer. The room laughs in the wrong place, from habit, and stops. The grain men stop. The elderly advocate, who has heard this song in its fast version perhaps four hundred times since the last emperor but two, leans forward on his couch with a lawyer's outrage at new evidence.

Marcus does not laugh at all. Antonia, at the room's edge, watches a senator's son hear a comedy become a census and — count it, she tells herself, it may be the only honest minute of his education to date — watches him not reach for his cup to get out of it. Across the room young Avidius is less fortunate in his refuge: he laughs alone, a barge of

a laugh, discovers the harbour empty, and converts it, with the grace his family is buying at such expense, into a cough that fools nobody except, kindly, the girl pouring his wine, who files it under *new money, improving*.

After, Daphne comes down from the music the way divers come up: in stages, with the room's applause arriving around her like light through water. Marcus is on his feet, which Romans of his order are not, for performers, in dining rooms — a small constitutional crisis conducted in footwear. He sits down again without looking at anyone, as if standing had been something done to him by the building. Antonia makes a note in the third book, the one that lives behind her ribs: *the boy has a conscience in his ears. It will be educated out of him or it will educate him; either way, in this city, somebody will charge for the tuition.*

“Again?” says the advocate, to the room, organising opinion like a man with fifty years' practice at juries. “At the fast speed, this time, so that we may all recover our characters.”

Daphne looks at Antonia. It is the house's look: *your room, your call, my voice, my terms*. Antonia nods once — fast, then home, the voice is a capital asset — and the song goes round again at its theatre pace, bright as paint, and the room, restored to itself, laughs in all the right places with an energy that has relief in it, and money. Only Prima, in the linen room beyond the half-open door, sewing by lamplight a border for a house that measures doorways for officials and drinks songs at two speeds, keeps time with the slow version. She has never heard it before. She will find, in the morning, that she has stitched seven flowers to it after it ended, like a sentence continuing itself in a hand that has just learned new spelling.

Prima is there that night too, but not as guests are there. She has come after dark because the baker's mother, that inspector of hems, has kept her all day unpicking a sleeve, and the border of red flowers must be finished before the hanging is wanted for a banquet of Alexandrians. She works in the small room off the courtyard where the linen is kept, and through the half-open door she can hear the singing, and under the

singing the talk, and under the talk a quality she does not have a word for, though she will learn several before the year is out: ease. The ease of people who believe the room will hold them.

Barbatus brings her water without being asked, which for Barbatus is a speech. “Your father know you're here after dark?”

“My father knows I am finishing work for a house that pays on the day.” She bites off a thread. “He knows the name of the street. He chooses the rest of his knowledge the way we all do.”

Barbatus, who killed men in the arena for eleven years and has since developed strong views about the management of doorways, considers this. “You've a look of someone,” he says.

“So have you. It's called a face.”

He laughs, a sound that turns a head or two in the courtyard, and goes back to his door. But the remark stays with him, the way a song stays, trivial and exact. He has a look-of-someone feeling about the needlewoman, and Barbatus trusts his instincts in proportion to how little language they require.

Prima finishes the row as the music changes in the far rooms — a singer resting, instruments being argued with in low voices, the house taking the breath it takes between selves. Her eyes are dry from the lamp; her back, where the stool's edge has been conducting a four-hour negotiation, presents its invoice all at once. She rolls the work the way her mother taught her, face inward, so that whatever the world does to it in transit happens to the back of the flowers. Out of provinces of habit like this, her whole life is governed. A year ago she would not have had the thought; tonight, in a house where rules arrive with reasons attached and women correct each other's words in passing, she notices her own government and wonders — it is the second treacherous comparison of the week, and she lets this one stand, being tired — what a life would feel like in which the rules were *hers* in more denominations than cloth.

Eirene is waiting at the courtyard door with the lantern and a shawl that is not Prima's.

“It belongs to the house,” Eirene says, before the refusal can get itself itemised. “Houses own shawls the way harbours own rope. You'll bring it back with the spring work and Diomedes will enter it as thread. Everything here is entered as thread. I have been entered as thread myself, in difficult years.”

The street at night is another Rome, let out of its daytime filing. The watch goes past with its buckets and its air of a department that has seen every fire twice. A drunk is being walked home by two slaves with the tenderness of men carrying a sofa through a doorway in their employer's best room. Somewhere above the street a woman is singing a child down in a language Prima half knows from the vats — one of the river tongues, part Latin, part everywhere the river has been — and Eirene, carrying the lantern high the way she carries everything, as if it had a right to be seen with, says, “Your father will be awake.”

“He's awake when I'm out. It's his watch. He says the house makes noises a man should supervise.”

“Men say that about houses, money and daughters. It's their word for standing in a doorway.” Eirene steps around a puddle that holds the lamplight up to them like an offering. “Mine stood in doorways professionally — a porter, in the Subura, in the house where Antonia and I —” She stops. It is only the smallest check, a stitch counted twice, but Prima, whose trade is noticing the place where a pattern hesitates, notices. “— where we were girls,” Eirene finishes, at the same pace, like a woman stepping over the puddle she has just pointed out. “Count your blessings, Prima. Your doorways are honest.”

Prima nods under the borrowed shawl, not trusting the moment with a question. She has grown up in rooms where the past was present as furniture: things not sat on, a mother's saying about stairs used daily and never explained, an old woman at the vats who looks at her sometimes the way Mother Livia looks at a hem — as evidence being kept for a later inspection. She knows, the way you know weather from a roof you have lived under, that her life has a sealed room in it. She has always known. What she does not know is whether other people's lives don't, or

whether, as she is beginning, tonight, walking home beside a freedwoman with a lantern from a house that files kindness as thread, to suspect: it is only the poor who are expected to live in one room and call it honesty.

At the bridge, the river is doing its night work, carrying the city's lights away in pieces too small to invoice. Tibur stone, island temple, a barge going down unlit on the current's own authority. Eirene stops at the crossing by arrangement — *to the crossing*, the mistress said, and Prima, who thought it a measure of distance, understands at the lantern's turning that it is also a measure of neighbourhood: this far a Caelian lantern may escort a fuller's daughter without becoming a story; beyond this, the street is hers again, and stories, like debts, should be contracted at home.

“Thursday,” Eirene says, “for the border's end. Bring your appetite; the mistress has lost patience with your father's foreign policy about her kitchen and is filing lunch as a materials inspection. You may tell him the house inspects *you* with soup. It has the advantage of being true in every particular the guild would check.”

Prima goes down into Transtiberim in the dark she was raised in, which receives her without commentary. Her father is awake, as advertised, supervising the house's noises from the doorway with his honey cooling beside him. He looks at the shawl. He looks at the work-box. He does not ask the questions, because keeping, in his book, includes keeping a daughter's day unopened until she chooses a knife.

“Flowers done?” he says.

“Flowers nearly. Soup Thursday,” Prima says, hanging the borrowed shawl where the damp won't find it. “Filed as an inspection. You can't refuse an inspection, Father. It's the law of houses.”

Vibius regards her with the expression she will remember, later, when she has a whole archive of his expressions and no more being added to it. “Then inspect thoroughly, girl,” he says. “And tell the house from me: we know good work across the river. We can smell it through the vats.” He coughs, and drinks, and lets her heat the honey again

without either of them saying why it has gone cold.

At the door-book, later, Antonia does the night's other accounting, the kind Diomedes enters in the first hand because it must look boring to survive: who came, who paid, who signed, who was carried out by friends conducting themselves like pall-bearers at a rehearsal. Barbatus reads the street back to her in his door-keeper's Latin — watch passed twice, no trouble, a senator's chair took the wrong turning at the corner and righted itself without witnesses, the rain considering a return engagement. Young Avidius left on foot with the heir of the Cornelii, which Barbatus reports as he would report weather over a harbour his family now, in effect, has cargo in. "Walking," he adds, "at a talking pace. The young one with the laugh did most of it. The young master did the listening. I marked it as a first, mistress, in case there's a register."

"There is always a register," Antonia says. "That is the committee's whole theology."

She closes the book on a night that has made the house money, cost it nothing it cannot replace, and left her with the feeling — she distrusts feelings that arrive without invoices; they tend to be other people's, delivered to her address by mistake — of a seam she cannot see being stitched somewhere offstage, with good thread, at somebody else's prices. In the corridor the lamps are going down by sections, the theatre unlit from the front. Daphne's door has its red wool on it already: a voice is sleeping; knock and be billed. Philomela is somewhere being witty to the night staff for the professional pleasure of staying in practice. And in the small dining room Eirene is doing the last flowers, which means she has something to say that requires her hands to be otherwise employed when she says it.

■

Eirene is the one who says it. Later, much later, when the guests have gone and the money has been counted and the lamps are being trimmed down to their night setting, she says it in the tone of a woman putting a

cup exactly in the middle of a table. “The needlewoman. Prima. Have you looked at her, Antonia? Not at her work. At her.”

“I look at everyone. It is how this house survives.”

“You look at everyone the way a customs officer looks at cargo. Look at her the way you look at a mirror in bad light. Against your will.”

Antonia's hands, which are counting by touch — she can count coin in the dark, a skill from a life she does not narrate — do not stop. That they do not stop is information, and Eirene, who has known her since they were both somebody else's property in a house in the Subura where the stairs smelled of cabbage and ambition, receives it as such.

“She is a fuller's daughter from Transtiberim,” Antonia says. “She is betrothed to a baker. She sews a straight seam. Rome is full of girls — women — with dark brows, Eirene. It manufactures them. It is one of its industries.”

“Count her years.”

“I have counted everything in this house twice today.” The coins go on moving. “Do not make me count that.”

Eirene says nothing more. She puts the trimmed lamp down between them, where it burns with a small, upright flame, and the two women sit a while in the aftersound of the house — water somewhere, a latch, Barbatus telling the night porter a story with a long, dishonest preamble — while Antonia finishes the count and gets it wrong, and begins again, and gets it right, and writes the right number down in a hand that only shakes on the last figure, where no one who did not already know her would think to look.

Chapter Five

A Short History of Stairs

. . .

She does not tell it. That is the first thing to understand about Antonia and the past: it is not a story she withholds, the way other women withhold a lover's name for the pleasure of the withholding. It is more like a room in a house she owns, whose door she keeps locked not from shame but from housekeeping. What would be the use of opening it daily? The furniture does not change. And yet a house is shaped by its locked rooms. the people outside them learn to walk certain ways.

There was a house, though. Let the record — which is only her, at night, settling accounts the tax office will never audit — admit that much. A house on the Quirinal, old, cold in winter through some principle of its architecture, where her mother, freed too late to enjoy it and dead too soon to describe it, had been a hairdresser; where Antonia, born while her mother was still enslaved and therefore born, as the law so gracefully puts it, into her owner's property, grew up as an accessory to other women's mornings: holding the mirror, fetching the pins, learning, with the speed of a child who understands that knowledge is the one ration that cannot be short-weighted, to read from the letters left open on dressing tables.

The son of the house was seven years older and home between tutors. This is the locked room's main piece of furniture and she has stopped dusting it: Gnaeus at twenty-four, between a military tribunate and a marriage being negotiated like a border, discovering in his father's house a slave girl of seventeen who could read his Greek over his shoulder and correct, once — once was enough; the room still contains the sound of his laugh — his scansion of a line about a woman at a loom, waiting, which the poet calls faithful and the girl, before she could stop herself, called *unpaid*.

The Quirinal house ran, as such houses do, on a staff of small, complete governments. Philodorus the steward governed paper. A freedwoman called Lalage governed the women's side with a voice she could lay across a courtyard like a plank. Antonia's mother governed hair, which sounds like the least of the provinces and was, in a house receiving bridal embassies, something close to foreign affairs: a Cornelian daughter-in-law was being negotiated that year the way provinces are, in stages, with scouts, and every scout came through the dressing rooms first, where the women of the visiting houses sat under Antonia's mother's hands and talked, as women under hairdressers' hands have talked since hair, about the things their men believed were being settled elsewhere.

Antonia held the mirror for these sessions from the age of nine. A mirror held steady is an education you cannot confiscate. She learnt the Servilii's finances before she learnt the word for them, from a visiting aunt whose hair was being dressed for a dinner at which money was not to be mentioned. She learnt that the young Gnaeus was *difficult about the match*, this from Lalage retailing and her mother pricing, in the shorthand of women who run the rooms where matches are actually audited. She learnt the phrase *a settlement*, with its whole future curled inside it like a hair on a heated iron. And she learnt to read — this is the inheritance no will itemised — because letters left open on dressing tables are a library for a girl whose job is stillness, and because her mother, who could not read four words in a row, understood with the whole of her thwarted intelligence that letters were the one luggage a slave carries that no steward can search.

“Sound it,” her mother would say, at night, in the little room behind the women's corridor where the combs slept in oil, pointing at a laundry list Antonia had rescued from a basket. “Not loud. The house doesn't need to hear its linen counted twice.”

So her literacy arrived the way everything in her life would: quietly, out of other people's leavings, at the full rate of attention. Greek came later and worse — from a tutor's slave who copied texts in the library

and traded declensions for kitchen privileges, in the freemasonry of the unfree who are building weapons out of the household surplus. By fifteen she could follow a letter; by sixteen, an account; by seventeen, she knew which of the two a man was lying in, a distinction that has since capitalized a house on the Caelian.

It was the accounts, officially, that brought her to the young master's rooms. Gnaeus, home between tutors and tribunate, was supposed to be learning the estates; the estates, presented by Philodorus in rolls that smelled of oak galls and other people's weather, bored him in the particular way of clever young men who believe boredom is a form of judgment. He set the girl who brought his mother's messages to copying a rental roll because her hand was quicker than his secretary's and because — the locked room admits this much furniture — he liked the way she mocked nothing while seeing everything, a discipline no one had taught him and everyone in his family performed as sneering, which is different.

“You read over my shoulder,” he said once, not looking up from the Greek.

“The master reads aloud,” Antonia said. “The room is entitled.”

“The room is entitled to silence.”

“Then the room is owed arrears, dominus.” She said it to the rental roll. She was seventeen years old and her whole life was a staircase people carried things down; she did not know yet that a sentence like that, in a house like this, to a son like this, is a door being built by its own noise.

He laughed. It was the laugh, still. He began, after that, to leave texts where the room was entitled: a page of history open at a siege, a speech against a governor his father admired, the poem about the woman at the loom. He taught her the letters properly because teaching her the letters improperly had already happened, in the way his class does everything — by accident, then by system, then by claiming the system. He talked about the law’s categories the way young men talk about constellations: as if naming them were governing them. *Manumission* entered the

conversations, as money enters a bridal negotiation, warmly, vaguely, and without a date. She banked the teaching and discounted the talking, which is to say she was the only adult in the room, and the room, in the end, sent the bill for both of their educations to the usual address.

Her mother knew. Lalage knew. Philodorus, who governed paper, began to keep a kind of paper that is only kept in stewards' heads, in columns. There was a morning in the women's corridor when her mother, arranging another woman's hair for a betrothal visit, said — to the hair, to the air, to the government of stillness in which her daughter stood holding a mirror — "A house will forgive a son anything except being *seen* to need forgiveness. Remember which of the two of you a house can sell to restore its view."

Antonia remembered. She remembered it on stairs in Baiae with her whole body doing the work of memory. It is one of the sentences — there are perhaps six — that she has carried unspent through every currency Rome has offered her since, and it is the reason that, in her own house, twenty years later, no woman is ever asked to be invisible in the service of anybody's view. The rooms can be discreet. The women are registered. There is a difference, and the difference, as she once told a tax official who had not asked, is where she lives.

What happened after is not romance, whatever the poets who now eat at her tables would make of it for a fee. It was what happens in houses where one person's *no* is a legal nullity and the other person's *yes* is the weather. And it was — this is the part she has never found a filing place for, not in twenty years of excellent systems — also tenderness. He taught her letters properly, then accounts. He talked, in the manner of young men discovering principles, of manumission as if it were a gift he had personally invented. She believed the teaching and discounted the talking, which is to say she was the only adult in the room, and she was seventeen, and pregnant by the spring.

His father also kept accounts. The old Cornelius — another Gnaeus, they are all Gnaeus, it saves carving — settled the matter the way his class settled rain through a roof: by paying someone else to stand under

it. The marriage to Servilia was advanced by a year. Antonia was sold, on a morning when Gnaeus was at a muster on the Campus, to a dealer with a household to staff in Baiae; sold, specifically, *with her increase*, as the contract's Latin puts it, a phrase she read upside down on the dealer's tablet while standing very still with her hands folded, already practising, though she did not know it, for a life in which stillness would be her most expensive garment.

What she remembers of Baiae is stairs. Houses for pleasure are built down hillsides and serviced up them. She remembers the weight of water, the weight in her body changing its address month by month, a midwife with hennaed nails, and a morning — the locked room's floor is worn here, this is where her memory paces — when the child had come in the night and gone by the morning, *not strong*, said the midwife, *a girl, not strong*, and there was money in the midwife's sleeve that had not been there the day before, and Antonia, feverish, emptied, seventeen going on a hundred, did the arithmetic she had been taught by the son of the house and arrived, correctly, at the only conclusion that let her stand up and climb stairs again within the fortnight: that her daughter was dead, because the alternative arithmetic — sold on, given away, exposed on a hillside where the pious left unwanted arithmetic for the gods — did not permit standing up at all.

Baiae in the season is Rome with its guard down and its prices up: great houses terraced into the bay like an audience settling for a long performance, oyster beds in the shallows making their slow, litigious fortunes, and everywhere the water doing the thing water does to Romans who can afford it, which is persuade them they are simpler people than their tailors know. The house Antonia was sold to belonged to a dealer who supplied staff the way other men supply lamps: by the gross, with replacements. She was entered in his books as *girl, literate, with increase* — he kept books; she read herself in them one morning while delivering a tally to his office, upside down, the position in which Rome has allowed her to read most of the important sentences of her life — and she was put, for her literacy, not to the hardest carrying but to the

count of it, which in a pleasure house means counting other people's carrying and carrying enough yourself to keep the count honest.

She kept the laundry tally for ninety stairs. She kept the wine tally against a steward who watered by doctrine and confessed by arithmetic, his figures having a tell, like a gloss in a text: they improved toward festivals. She kept — this is the locked room's apprenticeship, the one her Caelian house would one day be built out of — a private tally besides, on a potsherd, in a hand she let nobody see. Days. Weeks by her body's calendar. The fee a midwife charged women who could pay not to be recorded, overheard in a kitchen and stored. The price, quoted by a dealer at dinner, of a healthy child sold young into a good house — *a good house*, the phrase sat at the dealer's table like a guest who has not been introduced to the dishes. She did sums on the sherd that no one had set her. All of them came out the same way: whatever happened in the winter, it would happen to a person with no column of her own, and the only column she would ever get was the one she taught herself to keep standing in.

The midwife's nails were hennaed. That is filed. What is also filed, and has been walked over in the locked room until the floor shines, is a conversation on the stairs two nights before, between the midwife and a man whose Latin had a Quirinal polish on it that Baiae money does not buy. Antonia heard half of it from a landing with a basket — half is the servant's portion everywhere; it is why servants' histories have the soundness of bridges and the completeness of ruins. The man's half contained the phrase *no record in this house*. The midwife's contained a sum, and then a sum improved, the way sums at dealers' tables improve toward festivals. Antonia was seventeen and vast as a harbour with the child and giddy on the stairs with the weight of the two of them, and she understood — the understanding arrived the way it would arrive all her life, first in the hands, carrying on carrying, while the mind took the stairs behind her — that the arrangements being made around her body were not medical.

She thought of saying it. To whom: that was the whole of the rest of the conversation, conducted with herself at the tally desk that night, in columns. To the dealer, who had bought her *with increase* and would sell the increase as a separate line, being a man who kept books? To the steward, Philodorus' southern colleague in the government of paper? To the young man on the Quirinal, whose laugh was by then a room she could no longer afford to stand in, who was being married that autumn to a settlement with good hair? A letter — she could write letters; letters were the luggage — a letter would be read by everyone whose hands it passed through, which is to say it would arrive as evidence in an inquiry she would not survive attending. She turned the potsherd over and wrote nothing. It is the only unwritten letter in the archive she keeps between her ribs, and its text, all these years, is still just the address.

What she did instead — the record should be allowed this, since Rome has so little paperwork on the virtues of seventeen-year-old slaves in winter — was work. She worked the stairs until the week her body informed the house otherwise, and she arranged, with a laundress from the town who had a sister across the river in Rome and a face like reliable weather, a thing that had no column: that if anything survived the winter with her name on it in any sense the gods inspect, the sister across the river would hear of it. It was not a plan. Plans require standing. It was a thread put through a needle in the dark, by a girl who had learned counting so the stairs would not count her, and who believed — believes; the tense is a locked room too — that a thread is what you hold while the rest of the house decides whether you were ever in it.

She stood up. That is the whole of the heroic part, and it took years. A steward in Baiae liked her head for figures more than her face, a rare ordering she blessed nightly; a widow in Naples freed her in a will, whether from affection or to spite a son-in-law Antonia never asked; freedom turned out to be a staircase too, only now she could charge for the climbing. Loans at interest to women the banks would not see. A share in a laundry. A dining room in Rome, then two, then the house on

the Caelian with the damp in the courtyard wall and the pastry cook arguing about saffron. Antonia Cassia is a name she assembled the way she assembled everything else: good materials, no one's permission.

She does not tell it. Eirene knows the shape of it, the way a person who shares a house knows where the locked room is without ever being shown. And if a needlewoman from Transtiberim holds her head, when counting, exactly the way — no. The count of coin is finished. The count of years she will do when she must, and she has decided, nightly for some days now, that she must not yet.

The Naples widow — let the record, which is hers at night and Rome's by daylight, give the woman her charges in full — was called Octavia Rufa, she was sixty, and she freed Antonia in her will for the stated reason, read out by a notary in a room full of relatives behaving like weather over someone else's harvest, that *this woman kept my books and my temper for four years, the second being the harder account*. The son-in-law challenged it. The son-in-law is one of the people the Caelian house now overcharges on principle whenever his agents book a room, a tax he has never identified across fifteen years of dinners. Antonia attended the hearing in a borrowed veil and watched a praetor's clerk read her freedom aloud in the tone men use for the minutes of other people's earthquakes. Then she walked out into Naples owning: one set of good clothes, one potsherd she no longer needed and could not throw away, a sum the will called a legacy and the son-in-law called an insult, and the knowledge — it sat on her like a cloak cut for somebody taller — that every paper in the world now had to go through her own hands before it could happen to her.

Freedom, she discovered that winter, is a staircase with a toll at every landing. A freedwoman of no family may keep books for widows, lend small sums, stand surety for women the banks will not see, and be cheated by exactly the same men on exactly the same terms as before, except that now the law will call her a party. It is not nothing, being a party. It is not what the young man's talk in the library promised, either, back when manumission was a gift he had personally invented. She kept

the widow's successor's books for a year, at a salary she negotiated standing up — the first thing in her life she had ever negotiated; the sensation, she told Eirene later, in another city, in another life, was like being allowed to be *late* — and she lent the legacy out in pieces so small a Greek banker laughed at the ledger: to a laundress for a mangle, to a midwife (unhennaed, competent, terrifying) for a room with a door, to a freedman baker whose ovens a landlord was converting into leverage. Every loan was written. Every repayment was witnessed. She charged interest she could defend to the women's faces and collected it with a memory they came, in time, to treat as a neighbourhood utility: *ask Antonia, she'll know what your husband signed*. It is a short walk, in Rome's sister cities, from being the woman who knows what the paper says to being the woman the paper is brought to before it is signed. Short, and uphill, and lit by other people's lamps.

Eirene arrived in the third year, out of the Subura, out of a house whose owner's death had distributed its staff like an estate — because they *were* the estate, in the older papers — with a freedom bought by a subscription among the laundry women and a scar of temper where her trust used to be itemised. They recognised each other in a Naples street the way people from sunken houses do: not with embraces, at first, but with information, traded at full value across a bakers' stall — who was dead, who was sold north, whose mother, whose stairs. The embrace came later, in lodgings, with the same economy. Eirene looked at Antonia's books, at the little loans marching like a border of red flowers, each the same, each slightly alive with difference, and said, “You're building a fuller’s shop for money. Takes it in dirty, gives it back clean, charges by the piece.”

“I'm building the thing that would have caught us,” Antonia said.

“Then it wants a bigger door,” Eirene said, “and a kitchen. In Rome. Nobody was ever caught in Naples except by the view.”

So: Rome, two tables, a lamp-seller's credit, a dining room over a fuller's that smelled, on wet days, of home. The rest the city knows in its baths version — *a freedwoman with a Greek banker and a pastry cook,*

who collects senators' secrets like other women collect jet — and the house version, which is Diomedes' three books and the truth filed between the quarters, is nobody's but hers. She has been asked, by men who think a life like hers is a menu they have paid to have explained, how she *rose*. She considers the word the way she considered a carter's amphora in a January yard. She did not rise. Rising is for bread and empires. She climbed, professionally, a staircase Rome built to be carried up by other people, counting as she went, and at some landing the toll-keepers began, one by one, to be her tenants. That is the whole miracle. It took twenty years. It is still, on the nights when the accounts are done and the house is loud with other people's appetites, the only story in the world she is certain she can tell in the order of the evening and not the order of the questions — because the questions, all of them, arrive from Baiae, and Baiae is a room she owns, whose door she keeps locked not from shame but from housekeeping.

■

Lentulus does not tell it either. His locked room is better built; architects cost money, and the Cornelii have always spent on structure. In his version, which he has not rehearsed aloud in twenty years and therefore believes to be unrehearsed, he came home from the muster to a father's study redolent of wax and finality and was told that the girl had been sold south, comfortably, *the matter concluded*, and that his marriage would be celebrated in the autumn, and that a man's youth is a province he governs badly and then, if he is fortunate in his family, is recalled from before the audit.

He asked one question. This is the worn floor in his room. He asked whether there had been a child. His father, who had governed provinces and understood the load-bearing capacity of a pause, said: “There is nothing living with a claim on this house.”

Lentulus was twenty-four. He took the sentence as an answer because he needed it to be one, and he has spent twenty years paying

interest on that act of interpretation — in the small hours, in the Senate when a debate touches the exposure of infants or the rights of freedwomen and he finds his own voice arriving before his judgment; in the particular ferocity, which his friends call principle and his wife calls by no name at all, with which he pursues the regulation of houses where other men's sons go to make Gnaeus's arithmetic and call it love.

He married Servilia in the autumn. She knew. He understood that she knew within the first month, from a sentence about Baiae dropped into a conversation about oysters with the precision of a stone into a well, to hear the depth. They have never spoken of it again. It is one of the load-bearing silences of the marriage, along with the Campanian debts and the fact — observed by both, acknowledged by neither — that Servilia would have made the better senator.

The marriage, as marriages of settlement go, was competently unhappy only in its first season and workable thereafter, which among their kind is the material other classes call a success story. Servilia brought land in two provinces, a mind that ran the Palatine house the way Antonia's runs the Caelian — by sections, lit from the back — and the knowledge she dropped into the conversation about oysters at exactly the depth a well requires to be sounded. Lentulus brought the name, the masks, the Moesia shoulder, and a locked room whose existence he announced, as men do, by walking around it for nineteen years. They became, in time, the thing neither of their families had itemised in the contracts: allies. Alliance is not the word the poets dine out on. It outlasts most of the words they do.

There were children in the order the contracts hoped for, which Rome calls Fortune and households call management. Marcus first, loud as a gate. A daughter between who lived nine days and is spoken of in this family, if at all, in the grammar people use for weather in previous consulships — Lentulus, holding the nine-day girl on the last morning with a competence that astonished the women, whose professional opinion of senators' hands was formed elsewhere, understood for the first time the true exchange rate of the sentence his father had sold him

at twenty-four: *nothing living with a claim on this house*. Nothing living was doing heavy work in that sentence, like a slave carrying water in a pleasure house. He paid the midwife — a Roman one, unhennaed, expensive — three times her fee and told the steward to record it as household linen. Servilia, coming off the childbed into a house performing a grief it was not certain it had budgeted for, looked at the accounts a month later and said nothing about the linen. It is one of perhaps six sentences of hers he has carried unspent. It had no words in it. That was the denomination.

Cornelia came three years later and stayed, with the air of a person who has reviewed the house and decided to improve it from inside, at the pace of music. By then Lentulus was on the ladder his name had built: quaestor's accounts audited like sieges, a praetorship, the consulship (suffect, the kind history pronounces with a footnote, which his father received with a toast to *the family's momentum*, as if they were a stone going downhill in good order). He governed nothing larger than his opinions in those years and governed them in public with distinction. The locked room furnished his speeches the way cellars furnish dinners: nothing was served from it directly; everything tasted of storage. When the Senate debated the exposure of infants on the hillsides — a practice every man in the chamber deplored in the manner of men deploring rain from inside good roofs — Lentulus heard his own voice arrive before his judgment, hot as a boy's, and watched the benches register *a Cornelius with a conscience*, a phrase that would follow him to the committee, to the baths, to a Greek banker's back room. When the freedwomen's tax was last revised he spoke for putting the collectors under the aediles instead of farming them out to private appetites, and carried it, and came home and drank one cup more than his rule and stood among the masks telling himself — the house has the record of it in the wear on one particular floor tile — that a man may settle a debt in general legislation if the currency is chosen well enough. His father would have agreed. That was the part that kept him standing there.

He saw Antonia twice in those years, before the Caelian house made seeing her a municipal question. Once in Naples, on business of an estate inspection: a woman at a banker's table in a widow's office, no longer carrying anything, signing with the hand he had — the locked room again; the laugh; the stylus — taught its letters, now filing a widow's loans with a competence that made the banker sit like a client. He was conducted past her room on other business. Neither of them was in a position to make it an event, and the city, which appreciates economy, recorded none: a senator looking at paperwork, a freedwoman being paperwork, a corridor functioning. The second time was Rome, the Subura, years later, rain: a dining room's doorway, lamplight, a woman sending a carter back into the street with an amphora in each hand and a sentence that had the whole street laughing with her and at nobody. He sat in his chair unrecognised behind wet leather and did not get out. He has since decided — committees are how his family thinks — that there was no decision to make, both times. A man's life arrives in the order of the evening, not the order of the questions. He did not, until the tablet, permit himself to itemise whose evening it had been.

His father died consul and honoured. The will, when it was read among the masks, contained the usual bequests and one unusual one: a sealed tablet for Gnaeus's eyes, which Lentulus, being his father's son in the matter of locked rooms, has kept sealed for nine years in the cupboard under his grandfather's mask. He tells himself it concerns the estates. He does not open it for the same reason Antonia does not count Prima's years: some arithmetic, once performed, must be acted on, and he has Syria in prospect, and a daughter to marry, and a committee proceeding against a house on the Caelian whose mistress taught him, though she would laugh to hear it, everything he knows about the difference between what a thing is called and what it is.

You tell yourself the tablet is about olive groves. You have always been good at telling yourself things in the tone of a committee, as if a minuted untruth were sturdier than a spoken one. The masks look down. Wax, smoke, paint. Every one of them a man who locked a room and

called the house honest.

Chapter Six

The Avidii at Dinner

. . .

To marry Cornelia well, it is first necessary to feed the people who might buy — the word the family uses is *ally with* — a large number of dinners at which nothing is proposed and everything is assessed. Lentulus dines the Avidii in the third week of the year. Servilia has chosen the menu as a general chooses ground: no dish that requires apology, no wine that suggests either desperation or the newer taste for novelty, and for the centre of the table a boar from the Cornelian woods, because a family that can serve its own boar is still, in the deepest Roman sense, a family that owns the story of its dinner.

Avidius the father is sixty, rich from grain fleets, freeborn son of a man who unloaded them, and possessed of the most dangerous quality in a negotiator: he is genuinely unembarrassed. His son, the young Avidius of the Caelian evenings, sits at the lowest couch and tries not to look at Cornelia with the expression he uses for singers. Cornelia, who has been dressed by her mother into a masterpiece of modesty with a neckline, performs the dinner the way she performs her music lessons, correctly and with an inner life entirely elsewhere, which her father, catching it, recognises as the Lentulus inheritance more truly than the name.

The seating has been worked out by Servilia on a tablet she will deny exists. A dinner of this kind is a map of a country being negotiated: who reclines where, in whose sightline, within reach of which conversation, is the constitution; the food is merely the government's daily business. Avidius the father is placed where the room's light flatters a man of sixty and where the boar, when it comes, will arrive at his left hand like an ally joining a flank. The son is placed low and opposite Cornelia, who is present because daughters being *assessed* must be visible as evidence and invisible as persons, a branch of optics Servilia has mastered on

behalf of a girl she is — though the tablet does not say so — also, in her way, protecting: from this couch Cornelia can see every face at the table and no face can study hers without seeming to. It is the best seat in the room. Nobody will ever tell the guests so.

Cornelia knows. Cornelia, who has been dressed into modesty with a neckline, understands her mother's seating the way she understands her music master's metaphors: as instructions encoded for a reader. From the protected couch she conducts her own assessment, in the hours' long, glazed traffic of being looked past, and her findings, had any committee thought to subpoena them, would have shortened several negotiations. Avidius the father eats like a man who has been hungry in fact and not in rhetoric, and respects a table accordingly. The son eats like a man being watched by a father who has been hungry. Her own father eats like a man making small, exact payments on an enormous loan of attention. Marcus eats like a man refuelling an argument. And her mother eats almost nothing, beautifully, the way generals visit frontiers: to be seen to have confidence in the supply lines.

The talk does its early circuits at the safe altitude: the dedication, the column scaffolding — “A war you can climb inside,” says a cousin of the house, one of the Arpinum line decanted into Rome dinners for ballast, “it's an end to reading, I call it. My books don't have stairs.” — the price of Spanish oil, a lawsuit about a warehouse wall at Ostia, which Servilia steers off the table and into the fish course with a sentence about boundaries being the true poetry of nations. Avidius laughs like a harbour — the sound of timber and money getting along — and Lentulus, who has been waiting for the Ostia wall to come up since a morning client gave it to him like a hot coal in a satchel, disposes of it into the same laugh with a proposal about surveyors over dinner rather than advocates over documents. It is his best moment of the evening. Avidius inclines his great head. Two old Romans have just agreed, between courses, that law is what you threaten and dinner is what you do.

Young Avidius, meanwhile, is being discovered by Cornelia to have a quality the betrothal market does not list because it cannot be faked at scale: he listens with his face. When the cousin from Arpinum tells the story about the augur and the chickens — a story this family has been deploying since before Cornelia was born, with marks on it like height lines on a doorpost — the young man laughs in the new places, the ones the story actually has, rather than the traditional ones. He asks her, across the low table, in the supervised gap between a toast and a sauce, whether she sings.

"I am sung about," Cornelia says, before she can file the sentence under *the Greek one*, "more than I sing. In this house my voice is issued. One song, at approved houses."

"My father issues my opinions on a similar system," he says. "One per dinner, not the nautical ones. He says a young man should be ballast." He considers the boar being carved with the concentration of a man watching a ship unloaded by a crew he respects. "I think ballast gets a poor report in this city. Ballast is why the cargo arrives."

It is not wit, exactly. Her brother does wit, beautifully, like a man juggling with his grandfather's glass. This is something her education has fewer words for: a young man making himself unremarkable at exactly the rate that lets a room relax around him, the way her mother's seating lets a girl see. Money from grain, her mother says, when the girl reports nothing that evening and is read anyway. A boy who can wince. There have been worse foundations.

The fish course arrives on a platter with its own escort, as fish does in this house, and with it the evening moves, as Servilia's tablet always intended, from reconnaissance to the first real exchange of fire, which in Roman dinners is called compliments. Avidius raises his cup the width of a wall at Ostia toward his host.

"Your committee does you credit," Avidius says over the fish, because new money always compliments old money on its morals; it costs nothing and it sounds like a subscription. "The city wants order. Order is good for shipping."

“Order is good for everything except conversation,” Lentulus says, and the table laughs on cue, and he hates the laugh a little, the purchased sound of it, though he has made the joke precisely to purchase it.

It is Marcus who breaks the evening, as water finds the crack in a jar. He has drunk exactly enough to mistake honesty for courage. “Father's order begins on the Caelian,” he says. “One house at a time. The committee has a short list.”

Silence, with cutlery. Servilia looks at her son the way an engineer looks at a bridge. Avidius the father, who built a fortune by hearing what a room costs, hears this room's price change and files it without moving his face at all. Young Avidius studies his hands. Cornelia — Lentulus sees it peripherally, the way one sees weather — stops being elsewhere. She is entirely, dangerously present.

“My son,” Lentulus says, “has the advocate's fault of stating a case before he has been briefed. The committee's list is the city's list. All unregistered establishments.”

“Of course,” Avidius says, warm, rich, unconvinced, already recalculating a dowry against a scandal surcharge in the privacy of a mind that has never once confused a dinner with a pleasure. “All Rome. Naturally.”

The guests leave in the order Servilia has arranged for their leaving, which is the order that makes it hardest to tell the evening went wrong: principals first, with embraces that have the warmth of treaties; the cousin from Arpinum next, sent off into the wet street rehearsing a version in which he said the thing about boundaries; finally the musicians, paid at the door by the steward in a transaction the household conducts, like all its transactions with art, as if money were slightly embarrassed to be seen working. In the corridor, while cloaks are being found and litters called, young Avidius finds himself beside Cornelia's music master — who has attended, unobtrusively, to tune and to be a reason the girl need not linger — and, in the manner of his family when it wishes to load cargo without a crane, engages the wrong man entirely on purpose.

“She sings the Greek songs?” he says. “The daughter.”

The master, who has survived nineteen houses by answering questions about daughters as if they were questions about weather in distant provinces, says, “The young lady's Greek is excellent.”

“Then somebody should hear it who can tell.” Avidius accepts his cloak from a slave and does the dockside thing again, the thing that has been getting him assessed kindly all evening: he thanks the slave by catching his eye, as men do who have been handed things by grandfathers who unloaded boats. “In my father's house we don't keep quality in the warehouse. It spoils the manifest.”

The music master reports this, later, in the course of being fed in the kitchen — musicians and ex-gladiators being the two professions Roman households feed after use without minuting — and Servilia hears it at third hand while her hair is being taken down, in the braid of voices through doors that constitutes her evening intelligence service. She revises the Avidii by another half degree, the way a banker revises a rate, and files the young man under a heading the family has not used since her own marriage negotiations: *possible, with supervision of a kind he may not require*.

Cornelia, in her room, with her hair also coming down, in hands not her mother's hairdresser's daughter's but a slave of her own age whose name is Tyche and who has opinions the household has not yet learnt to bill for, says, “He listens with his face.”

“That's ballast,” Tyche says, whose brother works the Ostia boats when there are boats. “My brother says the ship boys learn it or swim.”

“Marcus says I am being sold.” Cornelia says it to the mirror, which is bronze and dented and has heard the women of this house say worse to it for fifty years, usually while being got ready to be looked at. “He says it to be the only honest man in the family. It is his winter coat.”

“Are you, domina?”

“I am being *allied with*,” Cornelia says. “It is a better garment. Warmer, Marcus says, though somebody else keeps the key to the wardrobe.” She is quiet while the pins come out, each with its small

sound on the tray, like a count being taken of the day's true expenditure. “If I must be ballast, Tyche, I would like to know the waters.”

Tyche, who will be freed in Servilia's will and knows it and has therefore the freedom of the almost-free, which is the most dangerous dialect in any household, says, “Ask my brother about the waters, domina. Or —” the hands do not pause, the voice does the pausing for them “— ask at the house on the Caelian. The women there know all Rome's waters. They charge by the piece, I'm told, and the thread is separate.”

Cornelia laughs — once, unissued, a sound made entirely at her own rates — and then doesn't, because the laugh has shown her something in the bronze she is not ready to have seen before her father has finished being spoken to downstairs, in a room full of cooling food and servers moving like a tide going out.

Later, when the guests have gone, Servilia does not raise her voice. She has raised it perhaps four times in nineteen years of marriage; the household still tells the stories. She says, “Your son dines at that house and then discusses yours at my table. Your daughter has just learnt that her marriage is a transaction at which her brother may heckle. And Avidius has learnt that the Cornelii can be embarrassed at their own board, which he will presently charge us for. This is your committee's work, Lentulus. I hope the Senate applauds it as warmly.”

“The boy will be spoken to.”

“The boy is twenty. Being spoken to is your family's substitute for every other form of action.” She is removing her jewellery, piece by piece, into the hands of a slave who has heard everything in this room for a decade and will die having said none of it for money, because Servilia pays for silence prospectively, in kindness, which compounds better. “End it, or win it. Do not keep it. A kept quarrel is a pet, and this family cannot feed pets.”

“Then have the pet's keeper to dinner with an explanation,” Servilia says, in the tone of a woman closing a tablet, and goes out to do the household's night round — kitchen damped, doors witnessed, the day's

small treasons of waste and gossip corrected before they harden into systems. She does it on feet that make no announcement. Lentulus has sometimes thought his wife and the mistress of the Caelian are the two people in Rome who understand that authority is mostly the management of approach: no noise until she is in a room, then the room owes her an explanation. He does not say it. There are comparisons a man may think in his own house at night that would constitute, in daylight, a foreign policy.

Marcus is summoned to the study, where being spoken to has been conducted for three generations under a bust of the grandfather whose mask is in the atrium and whose opinions are therefore present twice, in case the room forgets whose walls these are. He comes in still in his dinner clothes, with the particular brightness of a young man who has been drinking just enough to have located his honesty and not yet enough to have lost the address.

“You discussed the committee at my table,” Lentulus says. “In front of the Avidii. In front of your sister.”

“I described the committee. As the baths describe it. As the aediles' own clerks describe it, Father, after the second cup, in establishments your committee is inspecting.” Marcus stands because the study only offers one chair to juniors and he is too angry, or too accurate, to take it. “If the description is a problem, the committee might try being something else.”

“The committee is a registry of—”

“One house,” Marcus says. “At dawn. With a rod.” He does a thing then that the room notices: he stops performing. The brightness goes out of him like a lamp being carried into another room, and what is left is twenty years old and tired in a way his education has no form for. “Cornelia looked at me when I said it as if I'd sold *her*, at the table, in front of the buyers. I keep thinking: that is the look this house teaches. I have been practising it in mirrors since I was twelve, I just didn't know the occasion.”

Lentulus looks at his son the way he looks at provincial reports he suspects of being true in the wrong direction. “Your sister,” he says, choosing the words as if they were good coin from a bad purse, “will marry where the family can honourably place her, with a settlement her mother will negotiate to the last clause, into a house whose money is newer than ours and whose son, by every report including his conduct at my table under provocation, is not a fool. If that is selling, then every farm my ancestors bought with a bride's dowry is a market stall, and the masks in the atrium are shop signs. We call it *alliance* because the word obliges both parties to behave as if the transaction were nobler than appetite. The obligation is real even if the word is upholstery. Most of Rome is."

It is a good speech. It has the columns: family, honour, the etymology of a euphemism audited like a harbour due. Marcus listens to it the way a man listens to weather in a country he means to emigrate from.

“And the house on the Caelian?” he says. “What word obliges us there? Because I dine there, Father — you know I dine there; Onesimus knows by professional forgetting, every bath attendant in Rome knows by retail — and the woman who runs it sends back my messengers with lessons in drinking slowly, and her singer returned a necklace this week because the stones were—” He catches himself, too late, as young men do; the sentence completes itself in his father's face.

“Glass,” Lentulus says. “You gave a woman glass and called them emeralds, and she returned them with a compliment, and now you are hers for a month and truthful for a week.” Marcus stares. Lentulus, who does not know he is quoting the mistress of the house word for word — who cannot know, unless the plumbing now runs in both directions and uphill, which in this city it generally does — finds he has produced the analysis out of whatever men of his experience produce such things: the archive behind the ribs. “It was done to your grandfather by a singer from Alexandria in the consulship of — it doesn't matter. The technique is older than the aqueducts. What matters, Marcus, is whether you

learned the price of the stones or the price of the lie. A Cornelius may pay either. He may not remain ignorant of the exchange rate."

"I learned she wouldn't be bought at my rate," Marcus says, quietly. "Which in this family makes her either a bad investment or—"

"Or kin to nobody we can afford." It comes out before Lentulus can file it. The room with the duplicated grandfather receives the sentence in the order of the evening, not the order of the questions, and Marcus — who is twenty, and who will remember this winter in a scroll-case for years — looks at his father with the first intimation that the locked rooms of this house are not a style of carpentry.

"Go to bed," Lentulus says, dismantling the moment with a father's authority, the cheapest tool in the house and the only one that always fits. "Not out. Not at dawn, not by the garden gate. Tomorrow you will call on the Avidii with a note in your mother's Latin apologising for your advocate's manner at dinner. You will not mention committees, emeralds, or honesty. Honesty, Marcus, is a long position. Take it from a house that has been short of it before."

Marcus goes to bed in the sense the house records: his room is occupied, his sandals are by the door, a slave has seen the lamp go down. Rome's great families run on such records; whole treasons have foundered on the sandals. He lies in the dark doing the arithmetic his tutors never set: the cost of a glass necklace, professionally returned; the cost of a sister's face at a dinner table; the exchange rate, currently quoted in his father's study, between a lie and its price. Somewhere below, the house does its night water sounds, the garden fountain conversations it has with itself when the clients have gone. He has grown up over this plumbing the way Prima grew up over the vats. Neither of them, tonight, can hear the similarity. Similarity is for people with a fourth set of books.

He thinks about Daphne's room at the house — not as men of his age are supposed to think about singers' rooms, which is the part he would least survive having minuted, but as a place with accounts in it. She showed him once, between songs, not to impress him but because he had

been holding forth about his family's papers like a man showing a wound, the little tablet she keeps: earnings, the Greek's receipts, a note of what her former owner's contract had cost to buy out, *paid*, in a hand that got steadier as the sum got older. “My first copy,” she said. “I cried over a balance sheet.” He had laughed, from the great height of twenty, at the available targets. Tonight the memory stands in his dark room like a person who has been shown in without being announced.

By the time the watch changes he has done what his family does with unwelcome arithmetic for three hundred years: he has decided to take it to a committee of one, at another address, where the lamps are better and the minutes are kept, as he has started to say at dinners, for the pleasure of the heckle, by women who count. The garden gate is not locked against the heir of the house; it is merely witnessed when he uses it, which is the Cornelian system in its entirety. The door slave, who is paid by Servilia prospectively and in kindness, says, “Young master,” in a tone that goes into no book, and Marcus, going out into the rain with his father's last sentence still spending itself in him — *honesty is a long position; take it from a house that has been short of it before* — thinks: I will just be rained on, at her door, in the back street, until somebody instructs me in manners. It is not a plan. At twenty, in this family, it is as close to a conscience as makes no difference.

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Marcus, spoken to, goes straight to the Caelian, because at twenty the shortest distance between a rebuke and its repetition is a straight line. The house is quieter tonight: rain, a thin Roman rain that makes the streets shine and keeps the merely curious at home. Daphne is not singing. She is sitting in the small dining room mending a torn strap on her costume — they all mend, Antonia insists on it, a house policy older than Daphne's freedom: no woman here is only ornamental, it rots the soul and the budget — and Prima is beside her, detained by the rain, showing her how to set a stitch so the tear will not remember itself.

Marcus, wet-shouldered, eloquent with grievance, tells the room about the dinner. He tells it well. He has his father's gift for a sentence and none of his father's instinct for an audience. Prima, listening, hears a senator's son describe his sister's marriage as a sale and his father's morals as a siege, and she thinks — with the practical clarity of a girl whose own betrothal contract was read aloud to her once, quickly, by a father who stumbled on the clause about her dowry of tools — that the rich are simply poor people whose transactions have better Latin.

“You shouldn't talk about your sister like that,” she says.

The room looks at her. Daphne's needle stops. Marcus, who is accustomed to being the most interesting thing in any room under senatorial rank, experiences the novel sensation of being corrected by the furniture, and — to his credit, or to Daphne's influence, or to the rain — he does not reach for rank.

“Why not? It's true.”

“Because she isn't here to tell it wrong herself.” Prima ties off the stitch. “My mother used to say a hem tells you how a garment was treated when no one was looking. So does a story.”

“My mother,” Marcus says, “says nothing at all, in several languages.” But he says it without the laugh he arrived with. He looks at Prima then, properly, the way the baths slaves say men look when a lane opens unexpectedly not before them but beside them. “Have I seen you? At the house of — no. At the fuller's. You're the fuller's girl who reads.”

“I am the fuller's daughter who sews,” Prima says. “Reading is what I do instead of sleeping. Like your drinking.”

“Reading,” Marcus says. “Instead of sleeping.” He has found the one dry cushion in the room by instinct and taken it by right of pedigree, and now he addresses Prima across Daphne's mending with the air of a man discovering a province where his coinage is not yet legal tender. “What does a fuller's daughter read? This is not baths talk. I'm asking.”

“Accounts,” Prima says, “that other people do wrong in the second column. Letters for the women in our street whose men are at Ostia with the fleets — reading them, writing back; that's most of reading, in my

street: other people's news, held steady." The phrase arrives in her mouth with a familiarity she can't invoice; painters of words would call it inheritance. "And a book my mother kept. Not a book. Leaves. Recipes. Counts. Names of women in Baiae with the stairs they worked and what the houses owed them when they died. She called it her *ledger*, though there was no money in it that ever got paid."

Daphne's needle stops. Daphne, who can hear a false note through a closed door and a true story through Vestals, says, "Your mother kept a ledger of the unpaid."

"She kept the stairs counted. So they wouldn't count us." Prima bites a thread. "When she died the guild women wanted to burn it with her — *her things*, they said. My father pottered about with the honey and said no, very quiet, the way he says things that are already in the accounts. It's in my work-box now, under the needles. It weighs nothing. That's how you can tell it's ours."

Marcus is looking at the work-box with an expression his tutors were paid to correct and didn't, the exact face Diomedes will see in the spring on a banker's clerk being shown a fourth set of books. "My family keeps the opposite kind," he says. "Everything paid, entered twice, three hundred years of it, and nobody can say where the money *is*. My sister is the money now. We're trading her for a harbour." He says it to the work-box, having learned in the last four minutes not to say it to the room. "I shouldn't talk about her like that. You told me. I'm — practising on the furniture."

"Practise on your father," Prima says, and then, because she is nineteen and has been correcting a senator's heir for an evening in a house her father has forbidden her to eat in, she hears her own audacity arrive like a dropped tray and has to decide, fast, whether to pick it up.

It is Daphne who picks it up, with a singer's timing, threading a needle by a light she seems to be personally on terms with. "Fathers," she says, "are the advanced classes. Furniture first. Then brothers. There will be examinations." She holds the strap up: the tear is a rumour now, a place where light changes its mind. "My father sold my contract to a

touring company when I was fourteen, against a debt with the word *honour* in it. The first thing Antonia did when this house bought me out was give me my own copy of the accounts, every quarter, to keep. I cried over a balance sheet. Singers are not supposed to. It was that or the fish course, she said; the house has a policy about doing both at once."

"Everybody in this house has a policy," Marcus says. "It's like the Senate, with food."

"It's like the Senate," Daphne says, "with the women counting." It gets the room's laugh — Prima's too, unwilling, unfiled — and into it Barbatus puts his head round the door with a dry cloak over his arm and the expression of a man appointed by the weather.

"Young master. Rain's easing. Street's deciding." He looks at the sewing, the heir, the general constitutional position. "Mistress is doing the late round. She does it on feet like a tax audit. No noise until she's in a room, then the room owes her an explanation."

"I was just—" Marcus begins, and gets up, and discovers, standing, that he has been in the one dry cushion and Prima's stool has been taking a drip from somewhere in the old ceiling with the patience of a province. He looks at the damp flower-dark stain being made, stitch by stitch, irrelevant by her shoulder. "Your seat is wet. All this time. You might have said."

"I might have been offered," Prima says, to her needle, at her usual rates, "the dry one."

It is that sentence — its cadence, filed flat as a coin on a counter — that Antonia, doing her late round on feet like a tax audit, hears from the corridor with the towels for a different room entirely over one arm.

Antonia, coming in at that moment with dry towels for a guest who is not expected to be in her house at all during a committee investigation, hears her own cadence come out of a stranger's mouth — the dry, level understatement she has spent twenty years believing she invented out of necessity in Baiae, on stairs, under water jars. She stands in the doorway with the towels on her arm and the whole house, the rain, the lamps, performing their little conspiracy of ordinariness around her, and she

thinks: *No. Not yet. I have a house to lose first. One catastrophe in its proper order.*

"Marcus Lentulus," she says, "your cloak is dripping on a mosaic older than your family's debts. Barbatus will lend you a dry one and the use of the back street, and if you love your sister as much as you love talking about her, you will be home before your absence becomes a second course. Prima, the rain is easing. Eirene will walk you to the crossing with a lantern. And Daphne —" she looks at the mended strap, the stitch that will not remember itself "— good. That is how all repairs should look. As if nothing were ever torn. We are none of us required to believe it."

Chapter Seven

Paper

. . .

Diomedes keeps three sets of books in three different hands, none of them his own. It is not dishonesty; it is calligraphy in the service of survival. There is the book for the tax office, upright and dull. There is the book for the house, in which the pastry cook's saffron and the enlargement of the kitchen stove stand in their true relations. And there is the book — tablets, actually, wax renewed each quarter so that some kinds of history melt as a matter of policy — in which Antonia's money goes out into Rome in the evening clothes of other men's names and comes home in the morning with interest.

“You hold paper,” Diomedes says, on a grey morning when the damp has come through the courtyard wall in the shape, Eirene says, of Spain, “on the agent of an estate in Campania. It came to us through the Greek at the Basilica. It is good paper. Land, olives, a family's good name standing behind it like a guarantor at a wedding.”

Antonia is dressing her hair, which she still does herself on principle, another relic: a hairdresser's daughter does not sit idle in that particular chair for any woman living. “Whose good name?”

Diomedes, who can usually deliver any sentence as if it were a weather report, looks at the tablet as if it might revise itself. “The Cornelii Lentuli.”

The pins go in. One, two. Her hands do not ask her permission. “How much of it?”

“Enough that if we called it in the autumn, the olives would be ours by spring. We will not call it. The Greek advises holding. The family will find money — a marriage, an appointment. Families like that always find money eventually; it is lying around in their past like furniture.”

“And if the family does not find money? If the appointment — let us say a province, let us say the east — goes to another name because this name has become, through its own committee work, untidy?”

“Then the paper becomes land. Or it becomes an embarrassment we can sell to someone who collects embarrassments.” Diomedes closes the tablet. “I am telling you because you taught me to tell you everything with a face on it. Money without a face I manage. This has a face.”

Antonia looks at herself in the bronze mirror: a woman of thirty-eight with her hair going up correctly and a creditor's knowledge arriving, as the best weapons do, by post, unrequested, already paid for. For twenty years she has imagined — on stairs, in bad winters, in the years when the dining rooms were two tables and a debt to a lamp-seller — the instrument of revenge as something she would have to forge: a letter, a witness, a scene in a basilica with her voice carrying like a trumpet. Rome, being Rome, has delivered it instead as an investment. Lentulus is, through agents and Greeks and the sweet anonymity of paper, in debt to Antonia Cassia. His olives ripen toward her autumn. His son drinks in her house. His committee inspects her drains. The city has tied them together with its favourite knot, the one that looks like business and tightens like fate.

“Hold it,” she says. “Say nothing to the Greek. And Diomedes—”

“Madam.”

“Find out what a fuller in Transtiberim named Vibius paid for his freedom, and when, and whether his household, nineteen or twenty years ago, received — a consideration. From Baiae. Discreetly is not the word. Find out as if you were buying thread.”

Diomedes is still for exactly one breath. He has kept her books for eleven years. He knows which questions have faces on them. “Thread,” he says, and writes nothing down, which in his system is the most serious form of record.

■

In the Basilica Julia, where the money-changers have set up their tables in the same relation to the law courts that remoras bear to sharks, Lentulus instructs his own agent in the music of delay. The banker — the same Greek, though Lentulus does not know the Greek's other client, because the Greek's whole fortune rests on no client knowing any other — is to be assured of the Syrian appointment as if it were a fact slightly too delicate for daylight. The Avidian negotiation is to be mentioned as all but concluded. A payment signifying intention will be made at the vintage. The agent, who has carried this family's intentions downhill for a decade, bows under the weight of them and goes to perform confidence in Greek.

Walking home through the Forum of Caesar, Lentulus is overtaken by the emperor's works traffic: stone for the great column, blocks groaning on rollers, each drum already carved inside with its stair. A foreman tells the senator, unasked — the city tells senators things unasked; it is a tax on the broad stripe — that when it rises a man will be able to climb inside the war and come out on top of it. Lentulus stands a moment watching other men's history inch past on rollers. He thinks of his own name, spiral-cut somewhere between offices and olives, readable only from a distance no living Cornelius will ever stand at.

At home, Servilia has a letter from her brother about Cornelia and a face like a prepared speech. “The Avidii have named a figure.”

“And?”

“It is a figure that pays the Greek and re-ropes the Palatine roof and allows your son to be twenty for two more years without consequences. In exchange they ask that the wedding be before the vintage, and that you speak for the father's petition about the harbour dues, and — this is the interesting clause, Lentulus, attend to it — that this family not be *in the mouths of the city* between now and the ceremony. Avidius used those words. He has bought his way out of the docks. He will not buy his way into a farce.”

“So my committee must conclude.”

“Your committee must conclude, your son must be invisible, and you must be a wall. Not a window.” She hands him her brother's letter like a verdict she has already appealed in private. “I do not say take them. I say this is the price of refusing them, itemised. You may now perform the Cornelian tradition of refusing at length and in excellent Latin, and in the autumn the Greek will perform the Greek tradition of owning our olives.”

He reads the letter. The figures are what figures are: an argument that has stopped pretending to be anything else. Somewhere in the house Cornelia is at her lesson; he can hear the lyre being corrected, note by note, by a man forbidden to touch her wrist. The sound comes through the walls the way light comes through shutters, in stripes. He thinks of the sealed tablet under his grandfather's mask, and of the possibility — he has never permitted it a whole thought; it arrives in stripes too — that what his father sealed was not about land at all, and that a man can inherit a debt that does not appear in any Greek's ledger because it is denominated in a currency bankers fear to touch.

“Tell your brother,” he says, “that we are honoured, and that I will give Avidius my answer after the committee reports.”

“When does the committee report?”

“The committee,” Lentulus says, with the exhausted accuracy of a man reading his own inscription, “reports when I tell it to. That has become, I gather, the problem.”

Chapter Eight

The Alexandrians

. . .

The banquet of Alexandrians has been booked since December, and like all Antonia's profitable evenings it rests on a lattice of small, unglamorous decisions: who is placed where the kitchen noise reaches least, which singer does Greek without making the Romans feel examined, what to serve men from Egypt who consider Roman cooking a promising provincial attempt. The great dining room has its new hanging, Prima's red flowers marching the border like a well-drilled cohort, and the lamps have been filled by a boy who has been threatened, kindly and specifically, about the consequences of a smoky wick.

The preparations began, as Ammonius insists all true history begins, with an insult delivered by a supplier. The Alexandrians' agent sent word at dawn that his principals preferred their fish *in the Egyptian manner*, a phrase that arrived in the kitchen like a declaration of war from a country Ammonius left thirty years ago and has been improving in exile ever since. He read the message twice, aloud, in the accents of a man defusing a siege engine.

“Egyptian manner,” he said to the kitchen at large. “I am an Egyptian. The manner is at home. Send back: the fish will be in the manner of this house, which has the advantage that this house is where they are eating it.”

“Send back also,” Antonia said, tasting the morning stock, “that the house has acquired, at some trouble, the little salted fish from the lake boats they praise in their letters home, and will serve it before the courses, without announcing it, so that they can discover home like a compliment and not like a curriculum.”

Ammonius bowed to the stockpot. Statecraft had occurred. This is the part of her empire nobody carves: a cook's honour managed at dawn so that a fleet contract can be managed at the third course. Rome is the mistress of the known world, says the inscription programme, and the known world, in Antonia's experience, is a set of small governances conducted over fish by people the inscriptions will not name.

By the sixth hour Diomedes has the seating in wax, and wax, as she told a young equestrian in another context, has carried Roman law for a thousand years. The head of the Alexandrian syndicate — Serapion, sixty, with a beard his Roman partners regard as a philosophy and he regards as a face — must not sit within negotiating distance of the tax farmer who foreclosed, two winters ago, on a cousin's warehouse in Ostia. The foreclosing tax farmer, Felix by name (the useful men again; it is a guild), must sit where he can see Serapion being civilised by other people's manners, because a man who watches his enemy fed at Antonia's prices tends to recalculate empires. The senator's nephew, who is decorative, connected, and — Diomedes has it in the second book, in a column headed in all but name *cardiovascular* — under doctor's orders that he treats as literature, is to be placed nearest the musicians and furthest from the undiluted wine, a geography Antonia designs without anyone's permission, out of a principle her house does not advertise: she does not let men kill themselves expensively in her rooms if the seating can help it. Free will is a guest's own affair. Geography is hers.

Prima's hanging went up at noon. She came herself to hang it, which is not in the commission and which Antonia permitted as she permits Daphne's second set: on principle, at a price, with the corners watched. Barbatus held the ladder. Prima, at the top of it among the red flowers, held pins in her mouth and directed, through them, a staff of serving boys with the unconscious authority of a girl whose whole life has been work nobody applauds. The boys obeyed her the way the kitchen obeys Ammonius: instantly, and with commentary reserved for later.

“Left,” Prima said, round the pins. “Your left. The one the goddess keeps her thumb on.” She caught Antonia watching from the doorway with a tradeswoman's gaze and did not startle, which Antonia noted. Girls who startle at being watched by power have been taught that the watching is the point. Prima has been taught that the work is. The hanging settled; the border marched; the room acquired, as rooms in this house do by design, the air of having been inevitable since Romulus.

“You'll spoil the effect standing there,” Eirene said, arriving with lamp oil on her hands and the day's intelligence in her face. “The room is supposed to look like nobody made it.”

“The room is supposed to look like *Rome*,” Antonia said. “Which is the same instruction. Let them sit down inside the work of women from three provinces and call it the natural order. We will charge the natural order by the course.”

The guests arrive as Alexandrians abroad always arrive: punctually, in numbers, with their own weather around them. There are interpreters who are not needed and secretaries who are, a physician travelling with Serapion who looks at the dining room the way Diomedes looks at accounts — professionally, for the places where trouble files itself — and a young man, Serapion's nephew and heir in every sense except the will, whose Latin is better than the Romans' Greek and whose manners, consequently, must do twice the work. He bows to Antonia low enough to honour the house and not low enough to insult his uncle. She returns the exact exchange rate.

“Your uncle's health,” she says. “His letter said the sea.”

“His letter says the sea every year, madam. It is his way of informing the sea that the arrangement continues.” The young man — Heron is his name; she files it with a harbour's usefulness — looks at the hanging the way his uncle will shortly look at the fish: as evidence. “The border is local work?”

“Transtiberim. The best light in Rome, and the women who sew in it can count.” She watches him take that in: a Roman hostess praising the far bank to an Alexandrian, both of them provincials in the capital's

filing system, conducting diplomacy at the level where it actually happens. “Counting is underrated as a decorative art, Heron. Empires run on it and call the runners clerks.”

By the time the salted fish goes round — unannounced, discovered, received with the small, startled sound men make when a city they are visiting pronounces their childhood correctly — the room is hers in the way she likes rooms to be: not awed, not hers at all to look at, simply functioning at a temperature where agreement becomes possible. Serapion eats two of the little fish and does something with his face his beard was installed to prevent. “The lake at Canopus,” he says to nobody, and then, recovering the harbour wall of himself, to Avidius across the table: “Your hostess smuggles, Avidius.”

“Quality,” Avidius says, in the voice of a man reading his own best sentence back to himself, “is the only bribe that keeps giving evidence.” And looks at Antonia, and she at him, customs officer to cargo, while the courses begin to move like a fleet in line ahead.

The guests are merchants of the grain fleet and their Roman partners, and among the partners, inevitable as a harbour due, is Avidius the father. He eats in Antonia's house the way he buys cargo space, with an evaluator's love. “Your cook has improved the fish,” he tells her, which from Avidius is a love letter. “Last year it was ambition. This year it is fish.”

“I shall tell him. He will pretend to be insulted and raise his price.”

“You will pay it. Quality is the only bribe that keeps giving evidence in your favour.” He looks around the room; at the Senator's nephew holding a conversation with the singer Philomela about metre, at two tax farmers burying a partnership in the third course and resurrecting it by the fifth. “I am to marry my son into the Cornelii,” he says, in the tone of a man discussing the weather at sea. “If the Lentulus does not drown the match first, wrestling with your paperwork. Tell me, Antonia — you may; everyone else here is paid not to — will he?”

“He will do what his family has always done. He will discover, at the last moment, a principle that coincides with solvency.”

Avidius laughs, the deep harbour laugh. “You know him.”

“I know the type. Rome has a mould.” She moves to go, because a hostess who lingers is a hostess auditioning, but Avidius, who has spent forty years reading the moment cargo shifts, shifts his couch-weight almost imperceptibly into her path.

“Between ourselves,” he says. “I have made my money not frightening. I unloaded grain, my son unloads nothing heavier than a lyre, my grandson will unload provinces. It requires that nothing with my name on it be laughed at in the baths. If your house and his committee are going to make my family's wedding into a mime, I would rather buy a different old name. There are several for sale, though they call the shop something else.”

“Then tell him so.”

“I have. In a letter about figures. Men of his mould only read figures. It is their poetry.” Avidius takes an olive. “You hold paper, I am told, in several directions at once. It is a talent. Paper is the only freedman who never forgets his place, because his place is wherever you file him.”

She looks at him then, really looks, the customs officer at the cargo, and Avidius — who respects competence the way priests respect omens — inclines his head the smallest degree a rich man can manage without spraining anything. Nothing has been said. Everything has been invoiced.

Philomela sings after the second course, Greek first, as commissioned — a drinking song from Lesbos that has survived three centuries of symposia by being about exactly what is happening in the room, viz. men making treaties with their cups raised. She sings it straight, without the vocal embroidery Romans pay extra for and Greeks apologise for, and Serapion beats time once on the table edge with a knuckle, a harbour signal of approval, and then remembers his beard and stops.

It is in the pause — musicians retuning, plates moving like weather systems, the wine doing the slow work wine does on geography, softening the borders Antonia drew in wax at the sixth hour — that the

senator's nephew gets Philomela into the conversation about metre. He is called Gaius Calpurnius; he is thirty; he has, besides the heart reported to his wife and the doctor's literature, a love of verse that his family treats as a minor and picturesque disease, like an allergy to shellfish. He writes elegiacs. Rome is full of this condition. He wants to know whether Philomela finds the hexameter *breathable*, a word he has brought to the dinner like a new knife.

"Everything is breathable," Philomela says, "if the singer is allowed to breathe. Your poets write for the eye now, Gaius Calpurnius. The eye doesn't have lungs. It is why their epics need buckets."

This goes through the room's musically literate like a wire through cheese. Somewhere a poet of Antonia's acquaintance — present tonight as garnish; she hires them by the evening in the slack season, for conversation, at rates that would make the door-book blush — decides to have heard it as a compliment to the bucket and drinks. Calpurnius laughs, genuinely, a big, unguarded sound that reorganises his face into the one his wife presumably married. He is enjoying himself. This is the fact about the evening the versions will later drop, the way versions drop ballast: the man was happy, in a room full of people exercising their best professional selves, arguing about breathing with a singer from Corinth who treated his hobby like a trade.

"You should set something of mine," he says. "A short thing. For a real voice. My uncle says it would be founding a dynasty in the wrong art."

"Bring the short thing to the house on a morning," Philomela says, "and I will tell you if it breathes. Singers are the customs officers of poetry, Gaius Calpurnius. Most of it is smuggled. The rest is ballast."

Across the room the tax farmers are on their fifth course and their second partnership. The first one died over the fish (a spoilage clause; Felix the tax farmer believes in writing spoilage down until it confesses; his partner, a lean man from Brundisium with a smile like a contract's fine print, believes spoilage, like gratitude, is improved by leaving it unminuted). Now Heron joins them with the fleet's winter figures in his

head and no paper anywhere about his person — Alexandrian style, which Diomedes, observing from the serving door with a colleague's respect, describes later as *carrying the books behind the eyes, like madam* — and the partnership resurrects itself between the boar and the little cakes, in language so approximate that only the men who will profit by it understand a word, which in Rome is the definition of a binding agreement.

Antonia, doing her circuit, hears Serapion tell Avidius a story about a harbour tax in Alexandria and a priest of Serapis who attempted to collect it twice, once for the city and once for the god, on the grounds that the god's share had been omitted since the Ptolemies. It is a story with a long, dishonest preamble, and Avidius is enjoying it the way harbour men enjoy weather they are not currently in. The story's architecture requires — Serapion is an artist; the beard is a curtain, and it rises — that the priest produce from the temple archives a receipt, forged by his grandfather, witnessed by a crocodile. The room starts to gather the way rooms gather around warmth. The musicians have stopped tuning. Even Ammonius, presenting in person a sauce he has rebuilt from a first version Antonia returned with the single word *again*, pauses in the doorway with the dish like an offering left too long at a shrine, unwilling to break the story's surface.

“And the collector,” Serapion says, arriving at the part he has clearly been sailing toward since the fish, “examines the receipt. He examines the witness. The witness —” the beard performs a small, grave undulation, “— examines *him*.”

The laugh goes up where he put it: Apicius would have timed a sauce by it. Avidius laughs like a harbour in a gale. The tax farmers laugh in their newly resurrected partnership, at the same rate, as a clause. And Gaius Calpurnius, who has been waiting all evening, it appears, for a story in which the paperwork is witnessed by a crocodile — a man who writes elegiacs about breath, whose doctor has written literature about his heart, whose wife two streets away is at that moment telling her sister that these Alexandrian dinners run late and his colour has been

better at home all week — Gaius Calpurnius laughs last and longest, with his whole unguarded face, in the interval between courses, while Philomela beside his couch is still smiling, and Antonia at the far end of the room is turning toward the sound with the expression of a woman whose seating geography has done everything it can.

The fleet comes up with the boar, as it was always going to. All evening the grain ships of Alexandria have been sailing in the room's ballast — tonnage under the talk of fish, winter weather under the music — and with the third course Serapion brings them formally to anchor.

“The prefect of Egypt will want the sailings early this year,” he says, in the tone of a man discussing the weather at sea, which in his family *is* the weather at sea. “There is talk in the Canopic quarter of stores for an eastern movement. Grain follows talk the way gulls follow offal. It does not ask the talk's credentials.”

“Eastern movement,” Avidius says, tasting the phrase the way he tasted Ammonius' rebuilt sauce: carefully, and with the intention of having it again at his own prices. “The emperor's east is a rumour with a staff.”

“Most staffs begin as rumours. It is how they avoid the winter sailings.” Heron, who has the figures behind his eyes, lays them out on the table between the cups without paper: hulls available, hulls promised, the harbour dues at Ostia sitting in the middle of the numbers like a reef everyone at the table has hit in a different season. Antonia, on her circuit, hears the reef get its name — the same dues her landlord's agent, her husband-that-never-was, her whole triangle of paper and committee, have lately been navigating — and hears Avidius say, with the mildness of a man reading figures, which are his poetry, “A senator of my acquaintance will speak to the dues this year. Family reasons.”

The room does not pause. Rooms in her house are trained. But Diomedes, at the serving door, makes a note in the darkness behind his eyes to match Heron's, and Antonia files Avidius' sentence where she files all sentences that arrive with their price already worked out: between the quarters. A wedding for a harbour due. A committee

concluded for a wedding. Paper in several directions at once. She has seldom been prouder of the seating: Serapion on one flank, the tax farmer watching his enemy civilised, the senator's nephew breathing hexameters by the musicians, and in the middle distance her own hostess's body, circulating like good coin, while the empire's breakfast next winter is arranged over boar.

“Your boar is from Hispania,” Serapion says to her, as she passes. It is not a question. In Alexandria men identify pork the way Romans identify accents: as intelligence.

“From a man outside Tarraco who owes the Greek at the Basilica an apology and expresses it quarterly in meat. Quality is the only apology that keeps giving evidence.”

Avidius laughs before he can file it. “She steals, Serapion. In front of witnesses. It is why the house is full.”

“I recycle,” Antonia says. “In this city everything has been somewhere else first. That is the dedication we're all performing.”

She says it lightly, for the table, and moves on; but Serapion's eyes follow her the length of the room with the expression of a customs officer who has just watched cargo volunteer its own manifest. Later — much later, in the baths version, where the evening will be misfiled under a death like a letter under a stone — men will remember the food and the singing and the terrible minute in the interval. Nobody will remember that the winter fleet was priced over the boar, and the harbour dues traded for a wedding, and a widow-maker of a story loaded by a bearded man from the Canopic quarter, all in the same twenty minutes, in a room hung with two hundred red flowers sewn by a girl across the river whose name the register will now never spell. That is not because the minute swallowed the evening. It is because the evening, like all Antonia's profitable ones, was a lattice of small, unglamorous decisions, and Rome has never known how to invoice a lattice. It can only carve the part that falls down.

■

It is the senator's nephew who dies. Later there will be versions — the house will accumulate versions the way the Tiber accumulates offerings — but the version Antonia keeps, the housekeeping version, is this: a man of thirty, overweight, over-wined, with a heart his physician had already described to his wife in the words physicians use for a roof in a bad street, laughing at a story in the interval between courses; a choke that was not a choke; Philomela, who has presence of mind the way other singers have jewellery, getting him upright and calling for the physician who lives two streets away and dines, on Antonia's standing arrangement, with one ear open; the physician arriving fast and working competently and the man's colour deciding, as colour does, to leave anyway, all of it over in less time than the kitchen needs to ruin a sauce.

A death in a house like hers is not a tragedy first. It is a legal shape first, and a rumour immediately after, and a tragedy — for a wife two streets away is receiving the news from Barbatus, who has taken off his door-keeper's face and put on the human one he keeps for such errands — in its proper place, which is everywhere and therefore nowhere the aediles can measure.

Antonia does the things. She has rehearsed the things the way ships rehearse fire. The room is cleared without panic. The other guests are given cloaks and discretion and the back street in ones and twos, with the bill forgotten by policy and remembered by gratitude. The body is laid in the small courtyard room, decently, with a coin and clean linen, and no one, *no one*, is permitted to say the word poison within the walls, because words are seeds and this house will not garden its own ruin. Diomedes writes the evening down while it is still warm: who was present, what was served, the hour, the physician's name, the sequence, in the upright dull hand of the tax book, because truth, to survive in Rome, must learn to look boring on paper.

Avidius is among the last to leave. At the door he says, “You run a tight ship in a storm.”

“It was not a storm. It was a man laughing, with a bad heart, in a city that feeds men like him for thirty years and then blames the room he

dies in."

"All the same." He puts on his cloak. "The Lentulus committee will not call it that. Mind your paperwork, Antonia. And mind who profited from a death in your house this quarter. Sometimes a thing is an accident with excellent timing, and sometimes—" he shrugs, a harbourman's shrug, philosophical and entirely sincere "—sometimes the timing is the accident's employer."

Barbatus goes to the widow the way he once went into arenas: without anything in his hands. It is a policy he and Antonia arrived at years ago, after a death in another house, in the two-table years — a drowned boatman, fished out by the house's people on a winter morning, with the news to be carried to a wife in a street off the cattle market. Hands empty, face his own, the facts in the order of the evening. The widow of Gaius Calpurnius keeps him standing — senators' families keep everyone standing; it is a kind of architecture — and asks the questions wives of her order are not supposed to know how to ask, in the order her grief supplies rather than her rank: did he suffer, was he alone, who held him, what had he eaten, had he laughed. Barbatus answers them all, including the one inside the others, which he has heard before in other houses and other registers, *was he with a woman*, without the words ever being put into the street between them.

"A room of witnesses, domina. Twenty men and the musicians. The singer had his shoulders. There wasn't time to be alone. That's the house's word and it'll be the physician's, in better Latin."

She looks at the big freedman doorkeeper delivering better Latin's advance guard in her hall at midnight, and what her face does then Barbatus will report to the night porter, much later, as a fight only in the technical sense: something taken on the chin, absorbed, no falling. "He would have liked the witnesses," she says, and cries, after, with the efficiency of a person opening shutters, while her household deploys around her and her sister starts, already, the list that Rome starts: the uncle to be told first, the will, the mourning that must not look bought. Barbatus withdraws backwards a pace, the way men leave shrines, and

is given at the door — by a steward in a panic of good management — a purse for his trouble, which he refuses with a formula Antonia taught him for these errands: *the house doesn't charge for the carrying, dominus; only for the dinners.*

In the small courtyard room, meanwhile, the physician writes. He is Antonia's tableware physician — Nikias, Greek, fifty, with a practice built out of rich men's dinners and poor women's childbeds, which he maintains in that order *so that the first pays for the second and neither knows it is being governed*, a man after Diomedes' own heart — and he writes the evening in the order of the evening before anyone in this story will coin the phrase: the hour, the course, the laughter, the colour going like a tide going out where a child has dug a channel, the measures taken, the measures irrelevant. He signs it. He seals it in front of Diomedes and the Alexandrians' travelling physician, who had been at the table with his own counsel's eye on the room and who now adds, unasked and at cost of some professional weather across his face, a second signature to the Greek copy.

“Two physicians,” Nikias says to Antonia, in the corridor, washing his hands in a basin a boy holds as if it were evidence, “agreeing in writing. It happens in Rome perhaps once a reign. Frame the phenomenon.”

“You'll deposit it at dawn.”

“I shall deposit it at dawn, buy fish, and tell three dinners tonight's story with the names filed off, so that by noon the truth has a head start in a false beard. It is the immunisation we have.” He dries his hands on a cloth of Prima's work without knowing it — everything in this house is somebody's work, being used as itself — and looks at her with the directness men of his trade are licensed for. “It was his heart, Antonia. It was his heart last year and it would have been his heart at a temple feast, with the omens excellent and the priests all looking the other way. Your seating did what seating can.”

“Seating,” she says, “is not among the causes the committee will list.”

“No,” Nikias says. “For that you have paper, and witnesses, and a singer who held his shoulders instead of the note. Hold your paper the way you hold everything, madam: quarterly, and in more hands than yours.”

The Alexandrians are the last to go besides Avidius. Serapion at the door stops and looks back at the emptied dining room — couches stripped, the hanging's red border marching over a field suddenly gone quiet, serving boys moving like a tide going out — and does the thing his Roman partners will retell at baths until it becomes, like all their truths, a kind of cargo. He takes off a ring. Not an heirloom: a working ring, harbour gold, worn smooth. “For the singer,” he says, “who held the man. Not payment. In Alexandria we have a word for money that is not payment and it takes a philosopher to spend it. Give it to her with my house's name filed off.”

Antonia puts it — she does not entrust it to the night's confusion of trays — in the box in Diomedes' office, *Guests' Property, Forgotten*, on top of the evening's other arrested tides: a cloak clasp, a Greek secretary's stylus, someone's luck-piece on a cord. The box is getting to be a museum of the city's lowered guard. Tomorrow claimants will come at dusk in panics of discretion. The ring will wait a day, by her decision, so that when Philomela receives it the giving has cooled into record, and no one, in any inquiry anyone is composing, can file it under the price of a woman's statement.

Philomela is in the musicians' room with her lyre across her knees like a child she is not holding for comfort. “He asked if the hexameter breathes,” she says, to Antonia, to the room, to the colleague tuning in the corner who knows better than to be in this conversation. “I should have given him a duller answer.”

“You gave him the true one. It is the house speciality. We charge by the course.” Antonia sits — in this room, at this hour, sitting is a message the staff read correctly: the emergency is over; the night is now merely terrible — and puts her hands flat on her own knees the way she tests walls. “Tomorrow men will ask you questions in an order designed

to make the evening into other evenings. Tell it as it happened. The fish, the metre, the story, the laugh. In that order. If a question arrives from the wrong end, walk it back to the fish."

"Is that a technique?"

"It is a life," Antonia says. "The technique is just its paperwork." She rises; the room reassembles; somewhere a boy is crying in the kitchen because death has been in the building and he is eleven and his mother apprenticed him for arithmetic, and Ammonius is finding out loud, in Alexandrian Greek of the first quality, whether pastry is spoken anywhere in the theology of the moment.

She stands in the doorway after he has gone, in the smell of lamp oil and cooling food, and listens to her house performing its grief procedures: low voices, water, linen. Eirene comes to stand beside her without touching her, which is how they touch.

Diomedes finishes the evening's writing in the small hours, in a house that has gone the particular quiet of buildings where somebody has died between courses. He enters the Alexandrians' booking as fulfilled, the wine as served, the staff as paid for a short night at the long rate, because Antonia, in the corridor an hour ago, said *full rate* in the tone of a woman settling with the gods in a currency she controls. He enters the ring, temporarily, under guests' property, forgotten, which is not yet true, and will be by morning, and is the truest description of most things entrusted to paper. Then, in the second book, in the hand for facts that must survive fashion, he writes the name of Gaius Calpurnius, the hour, and — after a pause during which the stylus does not move, a toll-gate in the night — the words *died laughing*, which no tax office requires and no committee will know how to file.

"Second catastrophe," Antonia says. "In its proper order."

"What was the first?"

"I am not counting those yet either."

Chapter Nine

An Inquiry

. . .

A death in a dining house belongs, by the city's old and flexible anatomy, to several jurisdictions at once, which means it belongs to whoever moves first with the best Latin. By the second hour of the morning the dead man's uncle the senator has written to the urban prefect; by the third, Antonia's physician has deposited, at her instruction, a sealed account with a notary she has paid for years precisely against the day someone's heart would table a motion. By noon the baths have decided that the man was poisoned by a rival for a singer's favours, cuckolded by a tax farmer and carried out singing, three deaths, all false, all immortal. Rome does not mind an inquiry. Rome minds having nothing to say while it proceeds.

Lentulus receives the news at his clients' hour, in the mouth of a freedman who brings petitions and relishes disaster the way pastry cooks relish saffron: professionally, and more than he admits. He dismisses the man mid-flourish. He stands in his own atrium among the masks with the information arranging itself in him like troops: his committee, her house, a corpse, the city's tongue. He is aware — he will be able to date the awareness later, to this minute, to the quality of light through the compluvium — of a feeling he cannot at first name because it has arrived wearing the wrong uniform. It is not satisfaction. It has the shape of its opposite, hurrying.

Servilia, who has also heard — Servilia hears everything at the speed other people take to decide whether to repeat it — says from the doorway, “Do not go there.”

“I have no intention of going there.”

“You have every intention of being the man Rome watches not going there. It amounts.” She comes into the room. “If you press this now, you

will look like a creditor applauding a fire. If you defend her, you will look like—" She stops, not for want of the word.

"Like a man who inspects a house at dawn and eulogises it by noon."

"Like its patron," Servilia says, with surgical calm. "The Avidii will read it. The emperor's secretaries will read it. Your daughter, Lentulus, will read it, in the faces at dinner for the rest of her unmarried life."

"So I am to let the prefect's men establish whether a man died of his heart or of her fish, and my committee is to master the antiquarian skill of silence."

"You are to let the truth be established by men who do not love or hate in that street. It is a short list. The physician is on it, I understand, because *she* had the foresight to employ him before she needed him. There is a lesson in that for families who arrange their credit after the vintage."

She goes. The masks remain. Lentulus looks up at his grandfather — Gnaeus, naturally, the dented-mirror Gnaeus, under whose cupboard a sealed tablet has been ripening for nine years — and has the clearest thought of his morning, the kind a man buries standing up: *If I open it, it is because a man has died at her table. Everything in this family requires a death to become sayable.*

He does not open it. He sends, instead, an unsigned note by a slave who is not his usual messenger, which is the most signature-like act available to a Cornelius: *Keep the physician's account sealed until the prefect asks. Answer in the order of the evening, not the order of the questions.*

It is good advice. It is also, and he knows it before the slave has left the street, the first unpaid thing he has done for Antonia Cassia in twenty-one years, and it sits in him for the rest of the day like a coin swallowed in childhood: unnoticed by the world, impossible to forget the swallowing of.

■

The prefect's men are correct, which Antonia prefers; malice she can price, correctness she can plan around. They view the dining room. They view the kitchen, where the pastry cook, misunderstanding the visit in a way she chooses to believe is genuine, offers them almond cakes of a quality that will enter the record nowhere and influence it everywhere. They take the physician's account. They take Philomela's statement, and Philomela — who has sung for these men's superiors and remembers the programme — gives it in the order of the evening, as a certain unsigned advice has suggested, though Antonia would saw her own lyre in half before admitting that the order was not her own idea an hour before the note arrived.

"You keep a physician on retainer," the senior man says.

"I keep a house full of rich men eating dormice in a heat they complain of and pay extra to sit in. A physician on retainer is not foresight. It is tableware."

"And the dead man owed you money."

"Diomedes." The tablet comes, the upright hand, the small sum, a dinner in December and a loan against a racehorse, stamped, witnessed, uninteresting as prayer. "He owed me less than his uncle spends on mourning. If I poisoned debtors of this size, officer, Rome would need a second Tiber."

The man almost smiles, files the smile under conduct unbecoming, and closes the tablet. At the door, with the correctness that has carried them both through the day like a shared umbrella, he says, "The prefect will find a death by misadventure, madam, if misadventure is what the account supports. The prefect is not influenced by committees."

"Tell the prefect the house appreciates inhabiting the same city as his principles."

When they have gone, Eirene says, "The note helped."

"The physician helped. The cakes helped. Notes are just handwriting that has been for a walk." Antonia puts the note in the box with the tax receipts, beside its predecessor, between the quarters: a small, growing archive of a language neither of them writes in anymore and both of

them still read fluently. “Barbatus said the widow asked for me.”

“She asked whether he suffered and whether he was — alone with anyone, at the end. Barbatus said he died laughing at a story about a tax farmer, in a room full of witnesses, with a singer holding his shoulders. She said, 'He would have liked the witnesses.' Then she cried, he said, like a person opening shutters.”

“Send her the December bill,” Antonia says. “Marked settled. And flowers that cost less than the bill, so it doesn't look like arithmetic.”

Eirene goes to arrange the flowers that are not arithmetic. Antonia sits a moment in the emptied dining room under the hanging with the red border, listening to her house's heart resume its ordinary rhythm, and allows herself — the room is empty, the accounts are straight, a man is dead who died laughing and there are worse inscriptions — one unfiled thought, arrived in a familiar hand: *In the order of the evening, not the order of the questions.* It is how you tell any story if the telling is to save you. It is how she has never yet told hers.

Chapter Ten

Transtiberim

. . .

Diomedes goes to Transtiberim to buy thread. He buys, in the course of a slow and scented morning among the fullers' vats — urine and earth and the clean, assertive smell of other people's garments being forgiven — a great deal of thread. He buys red, which the house does not need, and undyed linen thread, which it does, and he buys, with the unhurried negligence of a man spending someone else's money on someone else's errand, the following: that Vibius the fuller was freed twenty-two years ago by a master in the tanning trade; that his wife, dead two winters, was a Baiae woman, a laundress, who came to Rome in the household of a dealer; that the couple, childless through the first years of their freedom, took in a child in the winter of the year the old emperor died — a girl, days old, brought by a midwife whose nails, an old woman at the vat remembers unprompted and then wishes she hadn't, were hennaed; that money came with the child, not much, regularly, for some years, then stopped, as money does when the hand that sends it dies or decides the account is closed; that the girl was raised as born to them — “and whose business is it, Greek?” says the old woman, suddenly, with the fuller's wife's whole defensive city in her voice — “she was fed, she was taught, she's betrothed to a baker with a mother like a customs office, she is *theirs* in every way the gods inspect—” and Diomedes, who has what he came for and more than he wants, buys thread from the old woman at her price, which is also a way of saying: this conversation is a transaction; I was never an inquiry.

He walks home across the island bridge slowly, a freedman in early middle age carrying thread and an undetonated century. He has served Antonia eleven years. He knows her books' three handwritings, her policy on glass jewellery, the exact depth of the silence she keeps about

Baiae; he has never, in eleven years, seen her face do what he is now obliged to walk toward and cause. He composes, as all good secretaries compose, the order of the evening. He decides against the order of the questions. She taught him that herself, years ago, over a disputed invoice: *Tell me what happened, Diomedes. I will supply the cross-examination internally, at my usual rates.*

She listens with a stylus in her hand. She does not write. At the hennaed nails the stylus stops its small, unconscious turning, and at the money stopping it resumes, and these are the only two entries her body makes in the record.

"The year," she says.

"The winter the old emperor died."

"Nineteen years." She counts it aloud at last, in the counting voice, the coins-in-the-dark voice. "Nineteen. The midwife said — not strong. A girl, not strong." The stylus turns. "Who sent the money?"

"The vats do not know. It came through the dealer's people at first. Then through a steward. A Quirinal household steward, the old woman thinks, before she decided she thought nothing."

"A steward." Antonia looks toward the courtyard, where the damp spot has dried in the week's sun to the faintest map of Spain. "My mother's master's steward was called Philodorus. He had a way of settling things at a distance and charging the house for the mileage. He died — Eirene heard it from a laundress — nine years ago. The same winter as old Gnaeus Cornelius." She sets the stylus down in exact alignment with the edge of the tablet, an act of government over the only province presently obeying her. "So the money stopped when the men who were paying to forget had both finished dying."

Diomedes says nothing. It is the most expensive service he renders her, and he renders it now at the full rate.

"I will not have her told by a vat," Antonia says at last. "Not by a Greek buying thread, not by a committee, not by the baths. If there is a telling, it will be in this order: I will be certain; she will be told by someone she already trusts with a needle; and no one — Diomedes,

write this in whichever book governs the end of the world — no one will use her, meanwhile, as an instrument against any living Cornelius. She is not paper. I have paper for that."

"Thread," Diomedes says, and bows, and goes to put eleven years of discretion around a morning's purchases like linen around glass.

■

Prima knows nothing of any of this, which is the last night of not-knowing she will ever sleep in whole, though she has no way to mark it. Her day is fully occupied by the ordinary treacheries: the baker's mother, who has discovered that Prima reads and is consulting her own mother-in-law scars about whether reading in a wife is a dowry or a defect; her father Vibius, whose cough has taken up residence for the winter and is redecorating; the hanging's second border, complete now, paid on the day — with a sum for thread, itemised, which made her father look at her over his soup with the expression of a man who has always known his daughter was worth more than the world agreed and is experiencing vindication as a kind of grief.

"Eat at the house?" he asks.

"Never. As instructed." She pushes his cup toward him; the cough medicine is mostly honey and authority. "The mistress asked after my mother's town. Baiae. I said she talked about stairs. The mistress went quiet the way rich women go quiet at a price."

Vibius looks into his cup for a long time. He is a man who has carried other people's garments through urine and fuller's earth and out the other side clean, and he believes, in his bones, that most things can be got washable if you do not rush the soak. "Your mother," he says, "talked about stairs because in Baiae she worked for a house with ninety of them and a mistress who timed her. She said a person should count stairs so the stairs don't count them." He coughs. "She was the countingest woman I ever knew, your mother. Counting and keeping. Keeping especially."

“Keeping what?”

“Us,” Vibius says, and drinks, and is discovered by his daughter, watching him, to be looking at her with the full apparatus of his love arranged on his face like tools on a bench, which frightens her more than any hem-inspection, because her father is a man who keeps his feelings the way he keeps his accounts: accurately, and at the back.

That night she dreams — she will remember this later, and disbelieve the remembering, and be right both times — of a courtyard with roses and a woman counting coins in the dark, getting it wrong, beginning again. She wakes before the count comes right. The winter light is at the shutter. Her father's cough is counting itself in the next room. She gets up to heat the honey, an ordinary daughter in Transtiberim, last morning of the world as filed, and puts a pot on a small fire with the competence of women in her family going back, though she could not name them, through laundries and dressing rooms, through ninety stairs in Baiae and a mirror held steady at seventeen, all the way down the long female ledger of Romans who kept other people's houses standing and called it, because the language offered nothing better, nothing at all.

Chapter Eleven

The Sealed Tablet

. . .

He opens it on a night of rain because the rain keeps the clients away and leaves the atrium to the masks, and because a man does everything eventually for a reason he would strike from the record. He tells the household he is reviewing the estate papers. He is, in the largest sense his family permits the word: the estate is the past; the papers are its rent book.

The cupboard under his grandfather's mask sticks, as it always sticks in winter. The tablet is where he left it nine years ago, in the scroll-case whose leather has gone the colour of everything in this house that is not wax or wool. His father's seal: the cornel-wood sprig, the old joke of the Cornelii, a family that turned a tree into three centuries of magistracies. He breaks it with his thumb the way you break the skin on cooling milk, hating the delicacy, wanting the violence minuted somewhere.

His father's hand had been a public instrument even in private: large, exact, unhurried by death, which was already in the room when he wrote this — Lentulus can see it at the ends of lines, where the letters gather themselves like men deciding not to run.

Gnaeus to Gnaeus. You will open this late. We are a family that opens things late and calls it dignity. Attend.

The girl from Baiae did not die there. The child — a daughter — lived. I paid the midwife to say otherwise and the steward to place her where the Cornelii would never have to spell her name. A freed couple across the river, fullers, decent people in the way that matters, which is to say they were paid and then, to their credit, continued after the paying stopped being their reason. I had the payments put through Philodorus so that you could truthfully say you knew nothing. You asked me once if there was a child. I said there was nothing living with a claim

on this house. It was the truest sentence available that preserved the house, and I offer you now the observation, too late to be useful to me, that a lifetime of such sentences will preserve a house the way brine preserves meat.

The rain. The compluvium dripping into its basin in the old rhythm, the one that measured his childhood lessons. He reads on, because stopping has never yet been a policy of his family's that survived contact with a document.

I do not write this to be forgiven; your forgiveness would be worth what mine was, a generation too late and addressed to the wrong person. The person wronged is not you. The girl was sold on your muster morning with her increase, as the contract said. I wrote those words too. If you have lived as I surmise you have lived — quietly with it, like a stone in the shoe of a marching man — then you may draw what comfort there is in knowing the girl Antonia lives and prospers in Rome under a name she credits to herself, which is more than I can say for the name I left you. The daughter, if she lives, is called by whatever name decency gave her. I never asked it. There are questions a man of my sort does not ask in case the answer turns out to have a face.

Do nothing dramatic. Drama is a tax the rich impose on the poor to pay for their remorse. If the matter ever stands where this family can settle it at a price that is not the girl's life a second time, settle it. A Cornelius pays his debts. We merely prefer, historically, to choose the currency. Choose better.

Lentulus sits with the tablet open until the lamp needs trimming and no slave comes, because Servilia has instructed the household, with the tactical sense that has kept this marriage upright for nineteen years, that the master reviewing estate papers is not to be improved upon by attendance.

A daughter. Called by whatever name decency gave her. He does the arithmetic that Antonia, across the city, in a house with damp in one wall, has done in exactly the same hour of the same winter: nineteen. A person of nineteen, across the river, in a fuller's household, walking

about Rome in a body half-made of the Quirinal and half of a mirror-girl's, unknown to herself as either, while her father's committee inspects her mother's drains and her half-brother drinks Falernian downstairs from the accounts room where her existence has just been itemised as thread.

He has, until tonight, been able to tell himself that his quarrel with Antonia Cassia is about Rome. It is a story with columns: public morals, young men's debts, Syria. The tablet does not contradict the columns. It simply shows him the ground they stand on, and the ground is a muster morning and a contract phrase and a question asked once by a young man who accepted a statesman's sentence as an answer because the alternative would have cost him his inheritance of himself.

He closes the tablet. He does not reseal it; a Cornelius does not pretend with wax. He puts it back in the scroll-case, under the mask, in the sticking cupboard, and stands a while in the company of the ancestors, who look down with their smoke-dark patience, every one of them a man who chose his currency.

“Choose better,” he says aloud, to no one, and the atrium, being Roman, keeps the remark in the family.

■

Servilia is awake when he comes to bed. She lies in the posture of sleep that she maintains, like the household order, for the benefit of anyone conducting inspections, and says, without opening her eyes, “The estate papers.”

“Yes.”

“Olives?”

“Not olives.” It is the most intimate sentence they have exchanged in some years. The rain goes on sending its small messengers down through the compluvium of the old house into the basin that has received them for three centuries, and somewhere below, a slave who has not been told to stay away from the whole house, only from one room of it,

is damping the kitchen fire for the night, banking it — keeping it, the way the poor keep everything: alive under ash, against the morning, at a price that appears in no one's ledger because it has always been paid.

Servilia says, “Then we will need to be more careful than your father was.”

He looks at her. She has still not opened her eyes. “How long have you—”

“Since the oysters,” she says. “Nineteen years. Sleep, Lentulus. Tomorrow you have a committee. Committees are how this family thinks. God knows it isn't how it acts.”

Chapter Twelve

Negotiations

. . .

They meet at last because Rome, which has been conducting their correspondence through clerks and committees and unsigned walks across the city, finally requires a room. The room is neutral the way a knife is neutral between hands: the back office of the Greek banker at the Basilica, smelling of cedar and other people's solvency, with two chairs and a brazier and a slave who withdraws after the watered wine with the deafness that is his employer's true product.

Antonia arrives first, because in another's office the first arrival owns the silence. Lentulus arrives with rain still in the weave of his cloak, and stands — she remembers this, her body remembers it before she can file it — taking the room the way he used to take a page of Greek, top to bottom, before allowing himself the beginning.

“You sent for me,” he says.

“The Greek sent for us. He has a talent for rooms.” She does not stand. A woman who owns the silence does not surrender the chair. “Your committee has cost me three bookings and gained me a prefect's compliment on my paperwork. I call that, overall, an expensive compliment. I have come to close the account.”

“I did not arrange the man's death to close anything.”

“I know.” She looks at him. “That is how I know it was his heart. If you had arranged it, Lentulus, it would have worked.”

It is the first joke either of them has made to the other in twenty-one years, and it lands between them like a cup set down too hard on glass. Something in his face — she watches it the way she watches a guest's face at the fish course, for the truth under the arrangement, chooses not to pursue it. Business. They are good at business. It is the language Rome taught them both, in different schools with the same fees.

“The committee reports in ten days,” he says. “It will recommend a general registry and quarterly inspection. General, Antonia. Twenty houses. Yours first on the list only by alphabet, which in Latin is mercifully early for nobody.”

“Acilius has been bathing you.”

“Acilius has been right. It happens, even to consuls.” He sits. The chairs are Greek, too low for the dignity of a senator, and he conquers this by ignoring it, a technique his family has applied to provinces. “In return, I ask the house to be — discreet — about young men of senatorial family until the vintage. My daughter's marriage is in negotiation. You know this. Your singer could probably recite the dowry figures.”

“Daphne sings, Lentulus. It is your son who recites.”

A beat. The brazier ticks. Somewhere beyond the cedar door the Greek's fortune goes on being made out of exactly this: two Romans reaching the part they came for by the road they can both describe as the long way round.

“I have a further matter,” Antonia says, in the voice she uses for menus and mercy, “of paper. The Greek will confirm the position if you require it in his hand rather than mine. Loans against Campanian land, rolled twice, now lodged — having passed through the hands of persons who prefer not to hold a senator's vintage in their own cellar — with an investor who files quarterly.” She watches the understanding arrive. It arrives the way age has arrived at his temples: visibly, if you know the face. “I am not calling it in. I am telling you it exists because a weapon a man does not know about is only an asset, and I did not come here to be merely rich at you.”

“How much of it?”

“Enough.” She folds her hands. “I learned that word from men who lend. I find it improves with use.”

“You want the committee buried.”

“I want what you have already offered because Acilius explained the steam to you. A general registry, paid quarterly, like the tax, like the

licence, like everything else in my life that Rome condemns and invoices." She stands, and the room rearranges itself around the single fact of her standing, as rooms have done for her since Baiae. "I have paid this city for twenty years to be let alone in a house I built out of stairs. I will go on paying. It is my civic religion. But I will not be taxed in shame as well as coin because a Cornelius needs Syria to look like cleanliness. We are finished. Unless—"

"Unless," he says.

She has rehearsed this too, the way she rehearses fire procedures and banquet seating: knowing the exact door she must not open under smoke. She looks at him — forty-five, grey-templed, shoulder that aches in warm water, hands that once set a stylus behind an ear as if it were a — no: that is the smoke. Follow the drill. "Unless there is any matter between our houses that your committee has not minuted. In which case the Greek has other rooms, and better wine than this, and we are both too old for the back street."

He is very still. The brazier ticks again, an insect noise, an accounting. "There is a sealed matter," Lentulus says, "that I have recently unsealed."

"Then we will need the other room," Antonia says. And is surprised — she logs it with Diomedes precision, beneath the ribs, where the house's third set of books has always been kept — that her voice does not shake on any figure at all.

■

The Greek's other room has a window, which is how she knows it is for the expensive truths. The Forum below goes about its immortal afternoon: litigants, changers, the column-drums inching on their rollers toward a war already won and not yet tall enough to read. Lentulus stands at the window because the sentence he is carrying has no chair designed for it in any room he owns.

“My father left a tablet,” he says. “I opened it last night. Nine years late. We are a family that opens things late and calls it dignity — those are his words; I am reduced to quoting him, which he would count as the estate settling itself.”

Antonia waits. Waiting is a skill she has, like counting in darkness. She can do it with her whole body arranged to look as if she were doing something else.

“The child lived.”

The room does not change. That is the thing she will remember: the drums on their rollers, the ticking brazier, a money-changer's laugh arriving whole through cedar and glass. The world declining to fall down over the oldest news in it.

“I know,” she says.

She watches it cross him — that she knows, that she arrived at the most expensive truth in Rome ahead of its legal owner, through thread — and what crosses him, under the statesmanship, is a young man of twenty-four being corrected on his scansion by a girl with a stylus behind her ear. *Unpaid*, she had said of the faithful woman at the loom. He had laughed. It had been the laugh that did everything, in the locked room, on the stairs.

“Across the river,” he says. “A fuller's household.”

“Vibia Prima. Nineteen. She sews for my house. She is betrothed to a baker and corrects your son's manners. She counts stitches with her mouth open.” Antonia's hands find each other and are correctly folded before she has decided anything. “She does not know. She will be told by me, when I judge it, in the order of the evening — you may invoice me for the phrase; it was good advice — and not as a weapon in a committee war or a dowry negotiation or a governor's application. She is not paper, Lentulus. She is the one thing in Rome I did not build, and I will not have the Cornelii spending her.”

“My father spent her. In advance, at a discount.” He turns from the window. “I am not here to reclaim her, Antonia. A nineteen-year-old with a trade and a betrothal is not property to be refiled because two

people have finally audited their twenties. I am here to tell you that I know, a day after knowing, and that my wife—" his mouth makes the small, wry shape that in the Senate precedes a concession "—has known since the oysters, apparently, and we will settle money on the household in a form that cannot be traced to the Palatine. Not charity. A debt. My father was precise about the currency, at the end."

"The fuller is dying," Antonia says. "Slowly, of the cough they all get, drinking their trade. Settle it as a widow's portion for a wife already dead and he will refuse it. Settle it as Prima's dowry, enlarged — tools, and a share in the bakehouse, paid through the fullers' guild as a bequest from a Baiae mistress her mother served — and the baker's mother will inspect it like a hem and find it respectable. I have thought about this, Lentulus. I have had, by my count, rather longer with the information than you."

"By how long?"

"Four days." She lets the smallest warmth into it, the way a lamp is let into a room. "I count faster. It is my civic religion."

Below, the drums have stopped for the day; a foreman's shout, the long creak of history parking itself. The two of them stand in a banker's back room between a dead father's Latin and a living daughter's needle, each in possession of the other's ruin in its most portable form — his olives in her book, his name in her locked room, her past in his cupboard — and what they make there, without touching, without the back street or the brazier or any of the instruments their younger selves mistook for fate, is the first entry in a ledger neither of them will ever show the tax office: an agreement to be, for once, jointly and severally, *careful* at somebody else's expense no longer.

Chapter Thirteen

Cornelia's Voice

. . .

Cornelia sings at the house of the Acilii with her mother's instructions arranged inside her like furniture in a room she is permitted to use but not to own: one song, not the Greek; bow to the empress's freedwoman first, because power sits in odd chairs; if the Avidii are there, they are to be greeted as old friends of the family, which by the vintage, the gods and the Greek banker's other rooms willing, they will be able to pretend to have been for years.

She sings the Roman song, a setting of a poem about a woman keeping a house through a war — all the songs for girls are about women keeping houses through wars the men are having elsewhere, and Cornelia, who is sixteen and has been educated well above the safety limit, has begun to notice that the keeping is always the woman's glory and never her choice. She sings it beautifully. She has her Lentulus grandfather's ear and her mother's discipline, a combination that produces, in a drawing room, something perilously like feeling.

Young Avidius is there. He listens with his whole large, shipping-money attention and afterwards, in the supervised eddies of the room, says to her the thing that renews her mother's faith in the match and Cornelia's in humanity, which are not always the same faith: “You should sing the Greek one for people who'd know. My father says a thing wasted is a thing stolen twice.”

“Your father,” Cornelia says, “sounds like a warehouse.”

“He does. It's why there's money.” Avidius grins, unpatrician, unrepentant, entirely without the sullenness Marcus is currently touring Rome with as a philosophy. “I'm not clever like your brother. I'm not going to be a senator who quotes at you. Ships, accounts, a house that won't leak into the dining room — I can do those. If this marriage

happens, nobody'll forbid your wrist to be touched by a music master. They'll just pay him better than your father does, so he respects the merchandise." He winces. "That came out wrong."

"It came out honestly," Cornelia says, surprising them both, "which in my house is what coming out wrong is called."

Servilia, watching from across the room with a mother's optics — able to read a conversation by its shoulders at forty paces — revises, by perhaps half a degree, her private estimate of the Avidii. Money from grain. A boy who can wince. There have been worse foundations under the Cornelii; she can name two without leaving her own marriage.

■

At home Cornelia does a thing she has never done: she asks her father a question in the atrium, at clients' hour, in public — where public means slaves and ancestors, the two audiences a Roman girl is raised to ignore and therefore the only two she entirely trusts.

"Father. If the committee is about houses where men tell the truth after dinner, why does no woman sit on it? We are, I think, the dinners' main consequence."

Lentulus, who has faced down embassies, experiences the specific vertigo of a man whose child has used his own forms against him correctly. "Committees," he says, "are composed of senators."

"Yes. I sat through the tutor too." She is holding her music, not crushing it this time; her hands have learned something this month. "Marcus says the woman on the Caelian keeps Rome's real minutes. He says it to be troublesome, but he isn't clever enough to invent it, which in Marcus amounts to evidence."

"You will not repeat your brother's bath-house evidence at the Acilii."

"I will not repeat anything at the Acilii. I will sing one song, not the Greek, and be a wall." She looks up at the masks, all those smoke-dark uncles of wax. "Did any of them ever ask their daughters a question,

Father? Or is that the Greek song too — the one we keep for people who'd know?"

He should rebuke her. The rebuke is written; his family has been issuing it in fair copy for three hundred years. What he hears himself say, in the atrium, at clients' hour, in front of slaves and ancestors, is: "What would you ask the committee, if you sat on it?"

Cornelia's face does the thing faces do in this family at moments of unminuted honesty: nothing, thoroughly. Only her voice admits the earthquake. "I would ask it why a house where women are paid is a scandal for inspection, and a house where a daughter is dowered to pay a banker is a temple of the ancestors. I would ask it to define *registered*."

"It would not answer."

"No," Cornelia says. "I sit through dinners. I know the sound of the Senate not answering. It is my dowry, in a way. We all bring something." She bows, correctly, and goes to her lesson, and the lyre begins, and is corrected, and begins again — and Lentulus stands among the masks with his daughter's question filed in no book his Greek keeps, and thinks of another girl, at seventeen, with a stylus behind her ear, correcting the scansion on a line about a woman at a loom, and how the Cornelii have been trying to strike that one useful word — *unpaid* — from the record ever since, at compound interest.

Chapter Fourteen

The Committee Reports

. . .

The Senate in the morning is a theatre that has agreed to call itself a constitution. Sun through high windows, the benches filling in order of a precedence everyone affects not to calculate, the emperor's letter read by a secretary with the flat delivery of a man who knows the words will outlive everyone in the room except the building. Lentulus sits where a former consul sits, in the sightlines of power, and listens to a debate about harbour dues with the portion of his mind the Avidii have under option, and with the rest composes, for the last time, the speech he is no longer going to give.

He had drafted it the way his family drafts everything: thoroughly, in periods that could support an aqueduct. *That the city which taxes a trade owes that trade its regulations; that young men of family are mortgaging their grandfathers to freedmen's bankers; that what the aediles cannot find, the Senate has declined to see.* It is a good speech. It would have been quoted in baths. It names no house and aims at one, which is rhetoric's oldest laundry service.

What he gives, when called, is the report. It is four minutes long. A general registry, quarterly fees, inspections at stated hours by appointment of the aediles, twenty-three categories of establishment, penalties for unregistered minors and unfree persons held without manumission papers — a clause he inserted at dawn in his own hand, with Felix the barber waiting, in language tighter than anything the committee's draftsmen produced: *no house to profit by a person whose* no *has no legal existence*. He hears Acilius shift on the bench at the clause, hears the room decide it is a fine sentiment and will be no trouble, hears, under the shuffle of assent, the small, specific silence of men recalculating which of their private arrangements the clause has

just described in public Latin.

Postumus, afterwards, in the portico: “That was either statesmanship or surrender. Your family does both in the same accent. Which is the Senate to put in the minutes?”

“The registry will pass.”

“The registry would have passed in December, before you sent a man to measure one woman's doorways at dawn. Now it passes *over* you, old friend. Syria—” Postumus, who loves him, and has that licence, does the un-Roman thing: he lowers his voice for a truth instead of raising it for a crowd. “Acilius tells me the secretaries have begun to say *Hadrian's people for the east*. Athens has been writing letters. Your name is — spoken, Lentulus. In baths. As steam.”

Lentulus watches the Forum performing its noon: the changers, the litigants, the column stone baking in its yard. “I piloted a morals registry through the Senate and put the freedom of the women in it in words they cannot unwrite without reading them aloud. If Syria is the price, Syria was always going to be paid by someone in some currency. My father—” He stops, surprised by the route. “My father would call that a provincial sentiment.”

“Your father,” Postumus says, with feeling, “has been dead nine years and still schedules the household. Come to dinner. My wife has a singer who does Greek, and she sings it for people who know, which tonight, I fear, means us.”

■

The news reaches the Caelian, as all news does, in three strengths: the door-book version by noon, the baths version by dinner, and Diomedes's version, which is the facts with their shoes on, by the time the evening guests are at the fish. Antonia hears them all. Her house is to be registered quarterly, like the tax, like the licence, like the weather. The clause — Diomedes reads it from the posted text with the neutrality he uses for death notices — about persons whose refusal must have legal

existence, she hears standing still in her own kitchen with a tasting spoon struck dumb in her hand.

The pastry cook, who has strong views on saffron and none that he voices on politics, says, “Mistress?”

“More salt than that, in the sauce for the Alexandrians. They will be back now. Men come back when a house has survived the Senate; it is like a recommendation from a temple.” She gives him the spoon. “Diomedes. Read the clause again.”

He reads it again. Latin, exact, unlovely — the most beautiful letter she has ever not received.

“File it,” she says, “with the tax receipts.”

“Which quarter?”

“Between the quarters. With the rest of his correspondence.”

Chapter Fifteen

Saturnalia Postponed

. . .

Winter lays its flat hand on the city: smoke, short light, the poor burning what the rich have renovated out of. Vibius the fuller declines in the manner of his trade, which is to say by water. The cough brings up the vats' whole history; the guild sends a physician who speaks kindly to Prima and uselessly to the disease; the baker's mother sends soup with inspections in it and finds, to her own surprise, that she is staying to administer both. She is a hard woman, but hardness in Transtiberim is just tenderness that has been charged by the hour for forty years, and Prima, watching her future mother-in-law wipe her father's chin with a cloth she herself has hemmed, revises a ledger she did not know she was keeping.

Antonia hears of the decline from Eirene, who hears of it from Barbatus, who has started walking Prima to the crossing on his own time and bringing back, with the emptied lantern, the news of the street the way other men bring back winnings. Antonia does the things that do not constitute interference in the filings of her conscience: the guild pension enquiries discover a forgotten entitlement; honey of a quality that needs no discussion arrives from a supplier; the physician's second visit is paid before the first has been billed. She stops there. She has built a life out of knowing where a kindness becomes a claim, and she will not begin her motherhood — the word arrives and is set down carefully, like a full glass carried across her own courtyard — as a purchase.

She goes herself, once. Not as the mistress of the Caelian consulting a tradeswoman; veiled, in a cloak Eirene calls her widow-inventing cloak, with Barbatus at a distance that suggests he is escorting someone else entirely. The fuller's house is two rooms and a lean-to over the vats' yard, and it is ordered with the ferocious neatness of people who know

disorder is the first luxury they will be blamed for. Vibius is propped against the wall-bed, grey as undyed wool, and he looks at Antonia for a long moment with eyes that the trade has made professionally sceptical about the true colour of anything.

“The thread lady,” he says.

“The house on the Caelian,” Prima says, flustered, “has come about the hangings for spring, Father. I told her you were to rest.”

“I am resting. It's my busy season.” Vibius's breath goes in like something being wrung. “Sit, mistress, if a stool is not beneath you. Prima, put water on. The mistress drinks—” he looks at Antonia again “—watered wine and not much of it. Working women.” A pause, which the cough fills in its own handwriting. “My wife worked in Baiae.”

“Prima told me. Stairs.”

“Ninety. She counted everything so it wouldn't count her.” The old man is holding the edge of his blanket the way men hold a rail in weather. “She kept what she was given to keep, my wife. Garments. Money. People.” His eyes do not leave Antonia's face. “We were decent people in the way that matters, I hope. We continued after the paying stopped being the reason. Twelve years after. A long soak, mistress. Most things come clean if you don't rush it.”

Prima is at the hearth with her back turned, very busy with water that is already hot. Antonia understands that she is being given, by a dying fuller in a two-room house across the river, the exact respect of not being named. She repays it in kind: “The guild speaks well of this house. The spring hangings will want a firm hand. Your daughter's dowry, I am told, is to include her tools. My house will commission her trousseau work at her own prices. It is how we file respect, across the river. Quarterly.”

Vibius closes his eyes. A smile moves under the greyness like a fish in the Tiber, briefly visible, unquestionably there. “Then we're all filing the same thing, mistress. In different books.”

On the walk back, Barbatus maintains his fiction of escorting nobody until they are at the bridge, where he says, to the river, in the voice men

use for the fights they are remembering instead of the ones they won: “In the arena we had a word for a man who holds the rail and jokes. We called him *not beaten yet*. The fuller's not beaten.”

“No,” Antonia says. “He is being succeeded. It is different, and worse, and nobody makes songs about it. Which is why women write the accounts instead.”

■

She tells Prima nothing that day, and nothing the next, because a fuller is dying at the pace of water and a girl is heating honey and counting stairs so they do not count her, and because Antonia Cassia, who has waited nineteen years inside a false report of a death, can wait until a true one has had its mourning. There are debts you do not collect during a deathwatch, whatever the currency. She has written the clause somewhere herself. Between the quarters.

Chapter Sixteen

A Funeral Across the River

. . .

Vibius dies in the hour before dawn, when the city's poor do most of their important business to avoid troubling the light. The guild pays for the pyre, as the guild pays for everything the trade has first made necessary. Prima washes the body with the guildswomen, who are kind in the competent way of women who have washed everything the world produces, and lays in the shroud a needle — not his, hers; her first, blunted now to the colour of river water — because a fuller goes out of Rome in the garment he made of his life, and she was, whatever the books in whatever hands may say, his making in every way the gods inspect.

The funeral winds through Transtiberim in the rain. It rains in Rome for funerals of every class, out of fairness or habit. The baker's family walks in the position of almost-relatives, which the baker's mother discharges like a magistracy. Marcus, who has heard of the death the way he hears everything, through the plumbing, comes to stand hatless at the procession's edge in a plain cloak; he does not approach; Daphne's return of a necklace has taught him at least the outline of the lesson that grief is not an audience. Barbatus walks the whole route in the neighbourhood's ranks where he has no legal place and an entirely unchallenged one, carrying, when the bearers tire, the bier's front pole without being asked, in the manner of men who express condolence by weight.

Antonia does not come. She sends Eirene, who has buried people from every century of her own life and knows how to be present as furniture: steady, unremarked, holding what needs holding. Eirene comes back across the bridge in the evening with wet hems and a report in her filing voice. “She did her father's washing proud. The baker boy

kept hold of her elbow at the pyre like a man steadying a ladder — not taking the climb off her, just holding the ladder. I liked him for it. The mother cried where nobody could itemise it."

"And Prima?"

"Counted the guildsmen as they came past the pyre." Eirene wrings her hem into the courtyard drain with strong wrists. "Under her breath. Mouth open on the numbers. Antonia, my love, you cannot wait out of delicacy much longer. Grief makes people honest at retail. Somebody at those vats is telling that girl, tonight, with wine in them, the story of the hennaed woman. It is what funerals are for, among the poor: the redistribution of the truth."

Antonia looks up from the tax receipts, which she has been arranging for two hours in an order comprehensible only to the recently bereaved. "Tomorrow," she says. "Here. Not at the vats. I will send Barbatus with a commission urgent enough to be respectable."

"And if she's already been told, badly?"

"Then I will tell her again, well. It will not be the first thing in this city I have had to launder."

■

Lentulus hears of the fuller's death from Servilia, who tells him at the morning offering in the same tone she uses for provincial appointments, because in their house all intelligence now travels at that altitude, above the weather. "Your other — the girl across the river is burying her father today. Her father," Servilia says, correcting the sentence as a general corrects a map. "The man who raised her. I have sent, through my brother's steward, a sum to the fullers' guild for widows and orphans of the trade, unattributed. It will reach her as the world reaches people like her: late, and through institutions, and smelling faintly of somebody else's conscience."

Lentulus pours the offering. His hand — the household watches his hands at the shrine the way clients watch a banker's — does its work

without visible cost. “You might have told me you meant to send it.”

“You might have told me, at any point in nineteen years, that you had a daughter. We are even, husband, in the great Cornelian ledger. We have both been settling your youth at a distance and charging the house for the mileage.” She sets the cup in its ring. “I knew Baiae. I did not know she lived. Your father charged my ignorance as the price of my cooperation, and I paid it — I want that in whatever minutes you are keeping now, in whichever of your rooms. I married a settlement, Lentulus. I made it work the way rain makes a roof work: by finding every hole for nineteen years. Do not now make the girl into one.”

It is the longest speech of their marriage. The slaves have withdrawn at its first sentence with the drilled instincts of a household that knows which weather is for indoors. Lentulus stands at the little shrine with the Lares gleaming dully in their niche — household gods, custodians of exactly this: the sanctity of a family's arrangements — and understands that he has been forgiven nothing and condemned of very little, which in Servilia's bookkeeping is the state called *marriage*.

“What would you have me do?” he asks.

“The dowry, through the guild, as agreed with —” she does not say the name in the shrine room; names, like knives, are put away in her house after use “— as agreed. Then stay away from the girl's life with the same talent you have employed for nineteen years, but this time as a kindness she can spend. And Lentulus—” Servilia turns at the door with her veil arranged and her war over for the morning “—when Cornelia marries the Avidius boy, which she will, you will stand there like a man who has given a daughter, not settled a debt. We owe the register that much acting. It is the one tax your class still pays in full.”

Chapter Seventeen

In the Order of the Evening

. . .

She tells her in the small room off the courtyard where the linen is kept, because it is where Prima's hands will know what they are for if the rest of her forgets. There is a commission on the table — spring hangings, genuinely — and Eirene within call, and the door not quite shut, which in Antonia's house has always been a policy about conversations: nothing true here should require a lock.

Prima comes in mourning, which in Transtiberim means her best dress gone dark at the edges and her hair done by the baker's mother into an arrangement of great respectability and no mercy. She has her work-box. She has, Antonia sees at once, been told something badly already — not the thing itself, perhaps, but its approach: the averted vat-women, an old woman's funeral wine loosening the phrase *the money stopped*, the way a room changes its temperature when a girl who was *theirs in every way the gods inspect* enters it. Grief has made the neighbourhood honest at retail.

"You sent for me about spring," Prima says.

"I sent for you." Antonia sets her hands on the linen, flat, the way she tested the courtyard wall for damp on a January morning when all the year's catastrophes were still correctly unscheduled. "Prima. I am going to tell you my life. Not because you asked, and not in the order of your questions, because your questions will be better afterwards. Interrupt anyway. It is a family failing."

She tells it in the order of the evening. The house on the Quirinal. The mirror held at seventeen. A line of Greek about a woman at a loom, and a word said before it could be stopped. A young man's laugh. Teaching, and what houses call teaching when one party cannot leave them. A muster morning, a contract read upside down — *with her*

increase — stairs in Baiae, a midwife's hennaed nails, money in a sleeve, a report: *a girl, not strong*. Standing up anyway, because the alternative arithmetic did not permit standing. Freedom in a will, loans to women, two tables, a house, a name assembled from good materials with no one's permission. And then a hanging with a border of small red flowers, and a needlewoman counting with her mouth open, and thread bought across the river by a Greek who kept his face like a book.

Prima listens the way she sews: entirely, with her whole posture given over to not dropping the work. At *the money stopped* her hands go still in her lap. At *not strong* she makes a sound that she converts, with a nineteen-year-old's ferocious governance of herself, into breath. When Antonia stops, the room contains linen, light through a high window, and two women at a table with twenty years laid on it like a length of cloth awaiting the shears.

■

"The wrist," Prima says at last. She turns her left hand over. The pale mark, the half-closed eye. "My mother — my *mother* in Transtiberim — used to say it was where the goddess of the river kept her thumb on me so I wouldn't be lost. She said every kept thing has a thumbprint." She looks up. "She knew, then. All my life she was telling me in that way. And Father. *Keeping especially.* That was — he said that to me, a month ago. I thought it was the fever being fond."

"It was your father being accurate. It is the family's other failing." Antonia's voice performs its duties. Her hands remain flat on the linen, holding the cloth of the world in place by main housekeeping. "I will tell you his name too, because you are owed the whole invoice. But understand what names are in this city: his will open no door for you that your needle hasn't, and it may close several your betrothal needs. That is not my shame speaking, or his — though we both keep accounts in that currency — it is the tax office. Everything is the tax office, in the end. I have paid it for twenty years to be let alone. I propose to go on

paying it for you."

"Is it—" Prima stops. She looks toward the courtyard, where Marcus's laugh, some evenings ago, arrived ahead of him like a herald. She does the arithmetic of faces. Dark brows. A mouth open on a count. A senator's son who shared, for an instant at a doorway, something she had filed under Rome manufacturing girls. "Oh," Prima says, with a seamstress's bleak admiration for a well-hidden join. "The committee."

"The committee."

"And the boy who corrected — whom I corrected. In your dining room. About his sister."

"Your brother," Antonia says. "Half, by the law's arithmetic. Wholly, by the arithmetic your mother kept. When you told him not to talk about his sister that way — I want it in the record, since no clerk will put it there — you were the only person in Rome that evening speaking of the Cornelii as a family. Including the Cornelii."

Prima is crying now, in the way of her trade and her river: without sound, achieved at the eyes, wiped with the back of a wrist that has work to do. "I don't know what to call you."

"Antonia will do. I assembled it myself. It has held heavier." She moves then — slowly, in the order of the evening; nothing true here requires a lock, but some things require asking — and takes the girl's left hand in hers and turns it, palm up, thumb resting, for one breath, beside the pale mark rather than on it. "Your mother in Transtiberim counted stairs so they wouldn't count her. She counted you, Prima. Every day of your life, at her own rates, and the count came right. I am not arriving to re-audit her. I am arriving, late — the family opens things late — to say that the report was false, the money was a crime filed as kindness, and the daughter lived and sews better than anyone in Rome. The rest is dowry and spring hangings, and will keep until it doesn't."

Outside, the house performs its afternoon: the cook arguing with Alexandria by way of saffron, Barbatus telling the porter a story whose preamble lengthens with each telling, a dove on the tiles with its soft stupid music. Prima picks up, because her hands require it and so, she

understands, does every woman in her blood whichever riverbank filed them, the spring linen, and begins the border.

“Red flowers again,” she says, when she can. “You'd think a fine house would vary it.”

“A fine house repeats what works,” Antonia says, “and calls it taste. Show me the stitch that doesn't remember itself. I never learned. Hairdressers' daughters; we only learned to hold the mirror for other people's repairs.”

They work an hour. It is not a reconciliation, there being nothing to reconcile except the past, which does not attend meetings. It is the thing itself, which Rome, for all its Latin, has only short words for: kin, at a table, with work between them so their hands could be honest while their faces caught up.

Chapter Eighteen

Marcus Learns a Word

. . .

Marcus discovers he has a sister the way he discovers most structural facts about his family: late, loudly, and in the wrong room. The room is the baths. The instrument is a dice creditor with a cousin at the fullers' guild, where a dowry for a fuller’s daughter has just been registered in circumstances the guild's clerk described, in drink, as *Baiae money, old money, Quirinal-handled* — the three adjectives travelling, as information does, faster disreputably than clean. It reaches Marcus between the warm room and the cold plunge, unattributed, deniable, and with Prima's trade attached like a label. He stands in the plunge with the water shocking up his body and the arithmetic shocking up his mind — faces at a doorway, a correction in a dining room about a sister — *his* sister, as it transpires, twice over — and does the first adult thing of his life: he does not say it aloud in the baths.

He goes home. He finds his father alone, which the household arranges for him with a speed that tells its own story; Servilia, it develops, has been scheduling this conversation since the oysters, and intends it to happen in a room with no knives in it. The study qualifies. There are only scrolls, and the dented mirror, and three centuries looking on from the corridor.

“Is it true?” Marcus says. He has rehearsed seventeen openings between the baths and the Palatine, each more forensic than the last. This is the one that survives the doorway.

Lentulus, who has had weeks, has rehearsed one, and it deserts him even faster. He says, “Yes.”

The boy sits down without being offered the chair, which in this house is an earthquake in a minor key. “The needlewoman. Daphne's — the woman at the house. Prima.”

“Vibia Prima, of Transtiberim. Betrothed to a baker. Nineteen.” Lentulus hears himself delivering a client's particulars and makes his voice change gear, at cost. “Her father, who raised her, is a month buried. Her mother, who raised her, is two years dead. They were decent people in the way that matters.” He is quoting a dead man's tablet. Quoting is what is left when the family runs out of original sentences.

“And the other mother,” Marcus says. It is to his credit — his father notes it with a grief that has pride in it like a stone in a shoe — that he does not make it an accusation. He makes it a request for the record.

“Antonia Cassia was a slave in my father's house. She was seventeen. I was twenty-four, which my family called a mitigating factor and history should call the whole charge sheet. When she was pregnant she was sold south on a morning I was at a muster, by a father settling a marriage — your mother's and mine, Marcus; your existence is minuted in this too, which is not your fault and is now, unavoidably, your information. The child was reported dead. The report was purchased. I asked once whether there was a child, and accepted an answer in statesman's Latin because the Latin was cheaper than the truth. She lived. She sews. She corrected your manners in her mother's dining room before either of you knew why it fitted.”

Marcus is looking at his hands. They are his mother's height and his father's appetite and for once entirely still. “All winter,” he says, “you've — we've — the committee. Her *house*. You inspected her house at dawn for a province. While my — while she was sewing the border in the next room.”

“Yes.”

“Did you know then?”

“I knew nothing then that I had not taken nineteen years to avoid knowing, which is a worse sentence than the one you asked for, so I will give you the plain one: no. I opened my father's tablet in February. Your mother has known since our first month, and married the settlement anyway, and if you intend to distribute blame in this house you will find the queue forms behind your grandfather and extends through me. It

does not reach her."

"I wasn't in a queue," Marcus says. "I was at the baths." He stands up, sits down, a young man doing geometry with furniture. "Does Cornelia know?"

"No. Your sister is to be married in the summer into a family that has already surcharged us for embarrassability. She will be told —" Lentulus consults, visibly, the new ledger, the one kept between quarters "— when the telling is for her benefit and not our relief. That distinction is apparently the whole of morality. It has taken this family three hundred years to itemise it, and we owe the wording to a woman on the Caelian."

Marcus laughs once, a sound with no herald before it. "She gives good advice, that woman. *Drink your wine slowly, Marcus.* I thought she was being a hostess. She was being —" He stops at the word. They both look at it, where it stands in the room like an uninvited client at the morning hour: not *mother* (not his), not *ruin* (not anymore), not *the woman*, that bath-house filing. Something for which his education, expensive and classical, has handed him only the Greek. "She was being kin."

"Kin," Lentulus says. "Yes. It is the word your family has been avoiding at the full rate of eloquence. Learn it cheaper than I did, Marcus. That is the whole of the inheritance I can improve on your grandfather: the wording."

■

He goes to the Caelian that night — the household will report this; households report everything; that is what the plumbing is for — but he does not go in. Barbatus is at the door in his weather of a body, and Marcus, who has swept past Barbatus forty evenings through sheer pedigree, stops on the threshold as at a temple he has not been purified for.

"Is she — Prima. Is she here, working?"

“Young master,” Barbatus says, in the tone he keeps for men deciding, “the mistress's needlewoman keeps guild hours now. Mourning. And the spring work's done at her own table, at her own prices. It's an arrangement the whole street admires.”

“She's to be married.”

“To the baker. Wedding's after the mourning, guild permitting. Good family. Mother like a customs office, which in a baker means the bread's honest weight.”

Marcus stands in the doorway of his father's committee's most famous casualty, a senator's heir with a sister sewing trousseau across the river and a word newly in his pocket with Greek roots and Roman consequences. From inside comes Daphne's voice, doing, for people who know, the Greek song. “Give the house my —” he says. He cannot find a noun small enough to be true. “Tell the mistress a client of the house is learning manners. She'll know the rate.”

“I'll tell her,” Barbatus says, “the vowel sounds and all.” And watches him go down the Caelian in the spring dark at a walking pace, which for Marcus, Barbatus reflects, is as close as the young ones get to a religious procession.

Chapter Nineteen

The Borrowed Spring

. . .

Spring arrives in Rome like a rumour that turns out to be true: almond first, then the markets changing their prices and their smells, then the great column in the Forum rising drum by drum inside its scaffolding, the war spiralling up toward its own statue at a pace even the baths' plumbing can keep up with. Prima works her trousseau at her own table, at her own prices, with a dowry now inscrutably enlarged by a Baiae bequest that the baker's mother has inspected like a hem and pronounced, in the guild parlour, with deep satisfaction, *stitched straight*. The baker’s son — Titus, broad-handed, smelling permanently of warm crust, steady at ladders and pyres — holds whatever she hands him in the way of grief or linen without taking the climb off her, and Prima, who has had a winter of finding out what people are by what they do at doors, treasures the findings in order.

She goes to the Caelian on Tuesdays. Not as staff; the door-book, Diomedes has seen to it, now holds a category for *tradeswomen related by commission*, a formula of such elastic dullness that no aedile will ever measure it. They work. Sometimes they do not work and walk in the courtyard among the overwatered roses while Eirene practises, loudly, being elsewhere. Antonia tells it in pieces now, not evenings: her mother's hands in other women's hair; Baiae stairs by the counted dozen; the Naples widow whose will did the work of angels out of spite at a son-in-law; the first dining room, two tables and a lamp-seller's credit; the pastry cook's arrival, which Prima already knows by the evidence of his saffron disputes. Prima tells it back, her order: the vats, the counting, the thumbprint of the river goddess, the father who held a rail and joked. Between the two versions, on the courtyard stones, a family is being attempted the way the fullers attempt a stained garment: slowly, without

rushing the soak, in water changed as often as honesty requires.

“Does Daphne know?” Prima asks, stitching. “She looks at me now like someone reading under the line.”

“Daphne suspects an entire library. She has the singer's disease: she believes every room has a song under it. I have told her that I pay you over the rate because you are the best needlewoman in Rome. It has the virtue, in this city, of being nearly true.”

“And Marcus.” It is not quite a question. The needle goes in, comes out. “Barbatus says he came to the door and stood there like weather.”

“Marcus is learning manners at the full rate. His family does nothing by instalments except debts.” Antonia watches the border grow: red flowers, spring issue. “He will write to you, eventually. It will be a terrible letter, full of Greek, and entirely sincere. Keep it with your tools. A woman should have evidence of what men cost in their own handwriting.”

Prima laughs, and Antonia hears — files it, with Diomedes exactitude, in the third book, the real one — the sound her own laugh made at seventeen, before it was trained, in a house on the Quirinal, over a line about a loom. It does not undo her. It has, if anything, the opposite effect; the sound arrives like a sum coming right at the second count. She gets up to be about the house's business before her face can make an entry the tax office could audit.

■

At the Palatine house, spring is a calendar of bridal administration. The Avidian match is concluded — *allied*, the families will say until they die — and Servilia goes through the ceremonies of it as through a province she intends to leave better governed than she found it: the contract, the auspices, the staggering, priced choreography of two houses becoming one and pretending it is a festival rather than a merger. Cornelia assists with the dreamy competence of a girl who has decided, privately and against all the songs, that she will keep some part of the house inside

herself unregistered. She has taken, that spring, to singing the Greek one for her music master — who has been paid better, by Avidius in advance, and no longer needs to touch anyone's wrist for any reason.

On the day the contract is signed, Avidius the father lingers in Lentulus's study over Falernian that predates both their ambitions. “Your committee did you no favours in the east,” he says, harbour-fashion, stating the tide. “I lose a governor for a son-in-law's father. I gain a senator with clean hands and a new registry with his name on the clause my ships' chaplains are already quoting at the crews, may the gods restrain their enthusiasm. Overall —” the great evaluator's shrug “— I call it cargo landed. Not the manifest we filed. Landed.”

“You," Lentulus says, “are the first man to tell me that this year in that tone.”

“I unload grain. Tides waste more fortunes than storms, senator, by arriving slightly not as promised.” Avidius sets down his cup precisely in its predecessor's ring, a dockside man made good performing, perfectly, the oldest rite of the house he is marrying into. “We need not discuss the Caelian ever again in this room, I think. My son eats there less than he did, your son stands in its doorway like a penitent, and the woman who runs it has just renewed her wine contract with my partner at a price that suggests she knew the vintage before the grapes did. Rome, eh? The accounts all settle, one way or another. The only choice we get is the currency.”

Lentulus looks at him for a long moment, this former unloader who has just quoted his own dead father's final advice back to him without knowing a letter of it, and experiences a sensation his family has historically confused with indigestion: kinship, upstream, where no committee has jurisdiction. “To landed cargo,” he says, and they drink, two old Romans of entirely different manufacture, in a study full of paper.

Chapter Twenty

The Clause

. . .

The registry passes into the city's habits the way weather does: complained about, evaded at the margins, priced into everything by the second quarter. Antonia files her house — the upright hand, the fees on the day, the women's legal conditions entered like a roll of honour, which in the book's intention they are — and discovers, as she has discovered every regulation aimed at her survival since Baiae, that compliance, pursued to the point of theatre, is the best camouflage a working house can wear. The aediles' inspector returns in the spring quarter, by appointment now, and is given the pastry cook's almond cakes as a matter of administrative routine. He measures no doorway. He asks after the new stove. Rome has decided that the house on the Caelian is an institution, and Rome protects its institutions with the same energy it denies its people: totally, and without apology.

What Rome has not entirely decided is what to do with the clause. *No house to profit by a person whose refusal has no legal existence.* It was drafted, if the city only knew it, at dawn by a barber's client in a sentence — the single fully honest sentence, Antonia privately believes, of Lentulus's public career — and it passes through the courts that spring and summer like a coin through a market: cited by an advocate here, *distinguished* (that advocate's word for buried standing up) by a praetor there, ending up, as such coin does, in the purse of a freedwoman of the Subura who uses it, in September, to walk out of a lodging house near the Carinae on its proprietor, a man who had held her manumission money — *against breakages*, as his paperwork put it — for six years. She walks out with her papers, her savings and a copy of the clause made by a scribe who charges her half, the revolution coming as it does in Rome not with trumpets but with discounts.

Daphne hears the story at the baths and tells it in the small dining room with a singer's instinct for the final note. “She walked past him, they say, holding the paper like a torch.”

“Paper burns,” Antonia says. “That is why we also keep the Greek.” — meaning the banker, meaning the copies, meaning Diomedes three hands, meaning everything she has learned about survival being a filing system with a soul. She looks at Daphne, who is twenty-two and free three years and holding, these days, real stones of modest size purchased with her own fees and kept, by house advice, in the Greek's strongbox against a bad winter. “Your contract here comes up at the new year.”

“I know the date. Singers count bars.”

“Renew it at the new rate, with the clause cited in your own hand at the foot.” Antonia pushes across a tablet on which Diomedes — who has aged, this year, a full decade in the eyes, as people do who keep other people's centuries in thread drawers — has written the terms in the hand reserved for things that must look boring to survive. “Every woman in this house. One by one. If Rome is going to register us, it will register *that* in this house first.”

Daphne reads. The room is quiet. The house beyond performs its evening overture: water, linen, the pastry cook whose saffron has this week been vindicated by two separate Alexandrians. “He wrote this,” Daphne says finally. “The senator. In the committee that was supposed to close us.”

“He wrote a sentence. What it closes and opens is our business.” Antonia stands; the evening requires her in three rooms at once and she will accomplish it, as ever, by being fully in one at a time and letting the house's memory do the rest. “Sing the Greek tonight, Daphne. For people who know. I am told there are more of them every quarter.”

■

In the Forum the column has cleared the rooftops. Tourists from the provinces stand in its scaffolding's shadow with their heads back and

their mouths open, counting, exactly as Prima counts stitches. Lentulus passes it on his way from a committee — a real committee now, on aqueducts, which flows through his remaining public life at a respectable rate — and a foreman he half-knows tells him the inside stair is continuous to the top now: a man can climb inside the war, when it is dedicated, and come out above it.

He walks home the long way, past the Greek's office, where he does not call; past the Basilica, where his agent is performing confidence in two languages; up the Palatine in the cooling light, a senator of ancient lineage and diminished prospects whose name the baths now pronounce in the past tense of Syria and the present tense of one clause that law students have begun, this term, to be set to argue about. Acilius has written that Hadrian, from Athens, inquired of the clause's draftsman — *a Cornelius with a freedwoman's conscience*, the secretaries are saying, which is the kind of joke that gets a man remembered in the wrong way by the right people, or the other way, in reigns to come.

At home there is a letter half-written on his desk in Marcus's hand — Greek, terrible, sincere; his son leaves drafts like flags — addressed across the river. Lentulus does not read it. He puts a fresh sheet over it, weighs it with the dented mirror, and goes to stand a moment among the masks in the last of the light.

Choose better, his father wrote, dying, in the hand that gathered itself at the ends of lines.

“I chose worse for thirty years at the full rate,” Lentulus tells the wax, conversationally, as a man settles with his creditors in private. “The interest is the estate now. I am merely keeping it lit.” The masks say nothing. They have been saying it, eloquently, for three hundred years.

Chapter Twenty-One

A Wedding in the Morning

. . .

Cornelia marries young Avidius on an auspicious morning in the early summer, with the whole expensive machinery of a Roman wedding making its noise around her: flutes, torches at noon, nuts thrown at futures, the bride's saffron veil worn — Servilia's last act of generalship — like a banner rather than a shroud. The groom winces twice, once at the contract's Latin and once, gloriously, at his own relief. Marcus behaves. This is minuted by no one and noticed by everyone: the heir of the Cornelii is sober, attentive, kind to old women; the baths will take a week to find a sinister explanation, the truth — that he has been reading his own letter for a month and learning the cost of language — being unsuited to plumbing.

Antonia receives an account of it from three directions, as she receives everything: the door-book (guests of both houses dine on the Caelian that week and talk, as men do, in the order of the courses rather than the questions), the Greek (the dowry's settlement has released, through agents, a significance of payment toward Campanian paper), and Eirene, who has a cousin in service at the Acilii and no shame anywhere in her system.

“She sang at her own wedding breakfast,” Eirene reports. “One song. The Greek one. Her mother, they say, looked at the ceiling as if consulting an upstairs neighbour, and let her. And the Avidius boy cried where the flutes could cover it, which the cousin says is the most patrician thing she's ever seen a man do.”

“Let her,” Antonia says, tasting a sauce. “That is Servilia's whole art, according to Diomedes, who reveres her like a rival firm: knowing which instructions to be disobeyed in.” She looks across the kitchen to where Prima, installing the summer hangings, is standing on a stool with

pins in her mouth, engaged in not falling off the year's whole metaphor. "Prima. When you marry your baker — guild, mourning, and your future mother-in-law's calendar permitting — you will not have flutes at noon. The neighbours would report the household to itself."

"I shall have bread," Prima says around the pins, "at all hours. It compounds better."

"You will have," Antonia says, with the air of a woman filing something between quarters, "whatever this house can send across a river that smells of respectability and keeps like money. Which is to say: also bread. I am rich, Prima, not imaginative. The imagination in the family has always been on the stairs side."

The kitchen laughs — the whole kitchen, the pastry cook from Alexandria laughing in Greek at a Roman widow-inventing joke — and Prima, descending from the stool into the world's ordinary level, looks around at the big stove, the arguing empire of it, with an expression Antonia can read as easily as a tax receipt: *this, too, is a house where women keep things standing; we merely charge admission to the keeping, which in Rome is called every name except honest.*

■

Servilia, in the week after the wedding, does the thing no committee drafted: she calls on the Caelian. Not at dining hour. At the dead middle of the afternoon, veiled in the style women of her order wear to temples and assignations of state, with one slave who waits in the street with the chair and the family talent, bred over generations of service, for being furniture. Barbatus announces her by no name at all, in the doorway, in the voice of a man reporting weather of an imperial size: "A lady by appointment with nobody, mistress."

They sit in the small dining room, sized — Antonia decides in mid-breath — to nobody's self-regard at all: two chairs, the house's best water, a bowl of the pastry cook's least argumentative cakes. Two women of forty in a city that has arranged their lives as a diptych: the

one kept by the family like its standard in battle, the other sold by it like surplus baggage after one. Neither has ever been allowed, by the minuting habits of Rome, to be the other's contemporary. In a room, at a table, with cakes, the fact becomes sayable, the way things in this family do, by not being said.

“You gave her the clause,” Servilia says, without preamble, because preamble is for men who schedule. “My husband. For your women to cite over their contracts.”

“He gave the Senate a sentence. The house has adopted it at the usual rates.”

“My daughter sang Greek at her wedding.” Servilia selects a cake, inspects it like a minor treaty, eats it. “The whole city will decide I have lost authority. I find I have gained a daughter-in-law's family who pay musicians properly. It is the best exchange I have made since marrying the Cornelii, which the gods may file under their own irony.” She looks, then, directly — it is said in the Palatine house that Servilia's direct look has ended more this year campaigns than the prefect's office. “The girl across the river. Is she—” A search, through registers: *provided, settled,* the whole dowry of un-saying. Servilia, who has run out of quarter in which to file things, finishes the sentence like a woman, at last, in her own hand. “Is she happy in her arrangement, Antonia? Baking and hems?”

“She is stitching a life at her own prices,” Antonia says. “With a man who holds ladders. She knows what knowing is worth here and spends it in her own street. That is as close to happiness as my people file, Servilia.”

“Your people.” Servilia considers the cakes. “And mine. My son has written her a letter.”

“I advised keeping it with her tools. Evidence of what men cost, in their own handwriting.”

“It will be Greek and terrible.”

“I said so too.” Antonia, to her own extreme inconvenience, feels the sentence arrive that she has not minuted and cannot invoice. “He meant

it well. In our families —" she stops. Re-files. "That is new. That can stay."

Servilia rises. The visit has lasted exactly the length of a temple call; the slave in the street will report a temple call. At the door she looks back across the small dining room, the plain good furniture of it, the house beyond beginning its evening the way a ship begins a tide. "We were both bought, you know," she says, conversationally, as one quartermaster to another. "The currencies differed. I believe that is what my husband's clause is about, draftsman though he was of everything else. Do not let the law students explain it to you. They will make it smaller."

"Come again when the committee is forgotten," Antonia says. "The cakes improve by quarter. It is our whole fiscal policy."

"I do not make social calls I cannot describe to my household gods." Servilia arranges her veil with hands expert and, for the first time in Antonia's observation of them at shrine-distance, not quite certain of the fold. "But I may send for the recipe. Rome will call that the beginning of the end, and for once the baths will be right at their usual rate of accuracy."

Chapter Twenty-Two

Letters from Athens

. . .

The emperor will go east; that much the stone yards know, the granaries know, the letter-writers of Athens know at flattering length. Hadrian writes to Rome in the accomplished hand of a man collecting a world: architecture, cults, old friendships renewed like leases. His name goes up one side of the city's future and down the other. Syria goes — the secretaries settle it over the summer like a cloth over a table — to a safer pair of hands, a man whose private geometry contains no Caelian angles, no clauses. Lentulus receives the news from Acilius in the baths, where all great disappointments in Rome are steamed for tenderness.

"It was the clause, in the end?" Acilius asks it gently; there is a consul's kindness that consists of not requiring a man to watch his own autopsy.

"It was the appearance of a man who might, in a province, write another one." Lentulus settles into the warm water up to the ribs; the shoulder from Moesia gives its opinion in the old language. "I find I do not believe in the east anymore, Acilius. Not as a cure. My father governed provinces to keep from governing his house. The house is where the interest accrues. You may tell Athens I said something about my health."

"I shall tell Athens you are wanted on aqueducts."

"Aqueducts," Lentulus says, with feeling, "are the one public work a Cornelius can supervise where what flows downhill is only water."

He does not rage, which the household finds more alarming than rage and Servilia finds, correctly, elegiac. He takes the aqueduct work with the whole force of a disappointed competence; inside the year, two leaking arcades on the road to Praeneste will bear, in small unglamorous lettering no tourist will ever photograph with their mouth open, the

name of the curator who made the water arrive where the maps had always claimed it did. Marcus, watching his father choose maintenance over monument, writes the fifth draft of his letter, in which the Greek is suddenly half the length and the sincerity twice, and sends it across the river by Barbatus — who charges, as messenger, one new-mended cloak strap, the house's real currency — with no seal and his own name, which costs him more than any seal in the collections of his ancestors.

■

Prima reads it at her table, twice, with the baker's bread cooling beside her in rows like the Forum's columns, and then, as advised, puts it with her tools. She writes back in Latin without a single Greek word in it, four lines: that she is well; that the shop will bake for the guild feast; that he is not to give her sister Cornelia messages he lacks the standing to deliver; and that if he wishes to be *kin* — she has the word from Daphne by now, the plumbing having delivered that too, disreputably and clean — he can begin by doing nothing where her name is spoken at his family's table, noisily, for about nineteen years. “After that,” the letter ends, “we will see what the figures say. It is apparently the family poetry.”

Marcus keeps this letter in the scroll-case under his grandfather's mask, in the sticking cupboard, where sealed tablets ripen. The household, which thinks in plumbing, decides that the young master has become religious. Servilia, who knows the cupboard's exact inventory of the century, instructs no one about it at all. The masks look down. One day, Antonia reflects when the story completes its migration to the Caelian — by way of Barbatus, who tells it as a fight he once saw in which nobody died, the rarest kind he knows — one day someone will open all the cupboards of that family at once, and the smell of old wax and newer ink will describe Rome better than the column will, whatever height it reaches.

Chapter Twenty-Three

The Vintage

. . .

The vintage comes to Campania like a debt falling due: men in the rows before light, the presses, the year's whole borrowed weather turned suddenly, crushingly, into fact. Antonia goes south in the autumn on the Greek's business that is her business — an investor is entitled to inspect an olive grove, indeed to taste its grievances — travelling with Diomedes and a mule-driver whose opinions on emperors would constitute treason in any province not hardened by long exposure to mule-drivers. She has not been back to Baiae in twenty-one years. The road insists on reminders the way roads do: a hillside town climbed by steps; a well-dressed girl at a fountain holding, steady as a standard, a tray that is absolutely a mirror.

He is there because the vintage requires owners as well as creditors, and because the Greek, who has survived forty years by arranging rooms, has arranged for once a grove. Lentulus among his olives looks less like a senator than like a man auditing trees that have read his family's accounts for three centuries and remain, professionally, unimpressed. The agent does the talking. The Greek does the not-talking, in two languages. Antonia walks the terraces with the business end of her mind uppermost — drainage (poor, old the Roman way), trees (good), press (a disgrace she is already pricing) — and understands, with the part of her the business is protecting, that she has brought herself to this ground on purpose. The eyes do it, eventually. Cities can be filed. Ground cannot. This is her money's ground now, a useful share of it. It is also, in a book no Greek keeps, the ground she was sold south *from*: the muster, the contract, the south itself like a direction on a coffin.

“The press wants replacing before next year,” she says, because she came to say things that could be minuted. “Whoever holds the paper after this vintage should insist on it, or the yield will file its own report.”

“The marriage has paid the Greek's first significance.” Lentulus picks an olive, not ripe, and puts it in his mouth anyway, either from habit or penance; the bitterness crosses his face like weather. “The remainder — you are being paid, Antonia. At the full rate. I wanted you to hear the estate say so with its mouth full.”

“I hear quarterly. It is my civic religion; you may have read of it.” She looks down the terraces to where the sea does its old indifferent glitter, Baiae-ward. “I climbed stairs down there for two years with water that weighed more than I did, by the end of the summers. I own paper on your trees now. If a poet of my acquaintance wrote it he'd be sent back to the kitchen for saffron abuse.”

■

“I have thought—” he begins, and stops, because what he has thought has taken him nine months to come down to this terrace to say without a committee to hold it. The presses groan below. A overseer's whistle, somebody's laugh, doves. “I have thought a man should be able to apologise in the order of the evening, too. Not the questions. Yours would be unanswerable at my rates.”

“Then in the order of the evening,” Antonia says, and folds her hands, and lets him.

He tells it. The muster. The study smelling of wax. The question asked once; the statesman's sentence accepted; twenty years marching with a stone in the shoe and calling the limp a style. He tells it without the Senate in it, which for Lentulus is nakedness beyond any baths. He does not say the word *love* because they are forty and the word has been taxed out of their bracket; he says *I let my father choose the currency*, which in Cornelian is the same confession with the ancestry left in.

Antonia listens the way she listens to men after the fish course: for the truth under the arrangement. It is there. It has the unsatisfying shape of truth, which does not unlock rooms or unclimb stairs. It merely stops charging interest at the moment of its payment, and not an hour before.

“You were twenty-four,” she says at last. “I have Marcus's measure now; I know what your family's twenty-four is worth in the market. I was seventeen and *unpaid*, which is a different currency, and no apology is legal tender for it anywhere in this empire. So we will not pretend. The money is settled quarterly. The girl is settled better than money. The clause —” she pauses, and finds, to her housekeeping soul's surprise, something approaching warmth available, unbolted, between the quarters “— the clause is walking about Rome in other women's hands, Lentulus, doing what no apology of yours could stock. If a Cornelius must pay his debts, I will let the record show he paid in infrastructure.”

“Aqueducts and adverbs,” he says, with the first unguarded smile she has seen on him since a courtyard she does not visit. “My grandfather is revolving in his mask.”

“Your grandfather is filing it. Masks can't move; that's their whole tragedy and your family's business model.” She turns back toward the presses, the agent, the Greek's beautiful silences. “Replace the press, Lentulus. Your olives deserve machinery that isn't a metaphor. So, if we are itemising, do your children. All —” she lets the plural stand on the terrace in the autumn light — at length, in the open, between the press and the sea “— of them.”

They walk down between the trees at a proprietor's pace, two Romans in early middle age with a shared minority holding in each other's ruin and a settlement, finally, in the only currency that has ever cleared in this city: work done on the ground, in season, by name.

Chapter Twenty-Four

What the Column Shows

. . .

They dedicate the column the following May, and Rome, which has watched it climb for two years inside its scaffolding, receives the reveal the way it receives everything imperial: by first applauding the emperor and then, having discharged glory, getting on with the serious business of trying to read it. The frieze goes up and up in its spiral: bridges, camps, battles, surrenders, the emperor addressing, the emperor sacrificing, the emperor — carved at intervals close enough that a man at ground level can keep finding him like a heartbeat — while all around him the war happens to other, smaller people, who carry and build and burn and are carried. From the courtyard you can read the beginning and the high middle blurs. For the rest you would need to be a bird, or the architect, or dead and put up there in a pot of gold at the top, as they say the emperor's ashes will be: the one reader of his own war with a perfect view being history, which in Rome means property.

Antonia stands in the same margin she stood in for the Forum's dedication, veiled respectably, the purple-dealer still making room out of an old debt now refinanced by gratitude. But the company has reorganised itself around her the way water reorganises around a stone it has decided to keep. Eirene is at her elbow. Prima — married since the winter, in a baker's wife's good wool with her tools' dowry half converted to a share in the bakehouse oven — stands at the other, at a distance that family keeps in a crowd full of aediles: close enough for history, far enough for paperwork. Marcus, who has taken to being civil in public forums with the concentration of a man defusing his own youth, inclines his head to the party from across the contractor's wives with a discretion that costs him visibly and is therefore, by every moral the city runs on, nearly worth something. The baker Titus holds Prima's

elbow the way men hold ladders, and looks up at the imperial spiral with his mouth open, counting.

“What can you see?” Prima asks him.

“The beginning. And men with baskets. There's always the men with baskets, if you look where the emperor isn't.”

Antonia looks where the emperor isn't. She is good at it; it has been her civic religion's other service. In the carved crowd at the column's base the stone has them all: auxilia in their foreign trousers, engineers, women with bundles at the edges of camps, the whole freight of an empire moving on the backs the inscription will not name. She thinks of the names in Diomedes third book, wax renewed quarterly so some histories melt; of a fuller and his wife keeping a child after the paying stopped being the reason; of a woman in the Subura reading a Claudian clause aloud to a lodging-house door; of every *unpaid* person holding the mirror steady at seventeen while the carving was done elsewhere. Rome will read this column the way it reads everything: from the bottom, getting tired. She does not hold it against the stone. Stone is only as honest as the height you let people read it from.

Across the courtyard, in the lane that opens for them, the senators pass: Acilius, consular, benign; Postumus, telling a story to a priest's chin-strap; and Lentulus, in wool that still costs more than a horse, with Servilia beside him in grey that costs more than the horse's opinions. He does not look for Antonia. It is still a discipline. But as the lane closes he does something that only three people in the crowd can read — one of them baked this morning, one of them keeps three sets of books, and the third counts stitches with her mouth open — he touches, briefly, two fingers to the edge of his toga where the old scar's mirror-image would sit, under the left ear: not a sign, not a signal, only a man feeling for a fact on his own skin in a public place. Felix always leaves the scar. Some men like to think the decision is fresh every morning. He is not one of them anymore. The lane closes.

■

That evening the house on the Caelian is full in its ordinary extraordinary way. The column's shadow, two hills away, is at that hour complimenting everything. Daphne sings a new song — Greek verses, a Roman setting, about a woman at a loom — and in the last stanza the faithful wife does the thing the poets have never yet permitted her: she presents her husband, home from the war at last, with the accounts. It gets the laugh and then it gets the silence, which in Antonia's room is the more expensive response. Men of business look into their cups. Someone says it will never play in the theatres, and Philomela, who has taken to harmony the way praetors take to *distinguishing* things, says that is because the theatres only sing the first frieze of everything, darling, the part where the emperor is still legible.

Antonia moves through the rooms. The damp has not come through the courtyard wall this spring: a new drain, Cornelian-supervised, aqueduct-adjacent, invoice impeccable, sees to it. Diomedes books, in the second hand now more often than the first, total themselves with less arguing. The house will be registered, taxed, inspected by appointment, and let alone, which in Rome is the compound noun *peace*. At the hour when the guests begin to be steered, waterproofed, toward litters and back streets, Barbatus brings a folded message with no seal, and stands looking at it in his fist like a man who has finally been handed the last of a kind.

It is from Prima. — *The shop has the guild feast. We will want the big room's hanging for the bakery door that day, if the house can lend what I sewed it. The child will be born by harvest, Titus says, who knows about rising. If it's a girl she will be taught letters before thread. If it's a boy, thread first, then letters, so he knows what the letters cost.* At the foot, in the writing that Barbatus taught no one and Daphne taught her half of: *I count everything so it doesn't count me. We're even, nearly. Which in the family, I'm told, is a kind of fortune.*

Antonia stands in the doorway of the great dining room, where the hanging in question draws its red border round the evening. Eirene, passing with the lamps, says nothing, having spent thirty years learning

the precise weight of that currency. Antonia folds the message once — precisely, as she has folded others, between the quarters of the tax receipts where all the important correspondence of her life has been filed since a young man taught her, among other thefts, the letter that begins her name. “Tell Barbatus,” she says, “the house will bring the hanging itself on the morning. By the front street. In a cart with ribbons, if the pastry cook's nephew can be trusted with colours.”

The lamps go up. The city does its night shift: bakers and fullers and clerks and column-carvers sleeping the sleep of the unnamed. Tomorrow there will be registrations, favourable winds for Avidian grain, a leaking arcade on the Praeneste road acquiring small unglamorous lettering, a wedding or a funeral or a girl with a mirror learning to read over somebody's shoulder the exact words that will one day be the beginning of her. Rome is the mistress of the known world, says the inscription programme. It is also, says the house, settling its accounts by lamplight, quarterly, in three hands, a fuller’s daughter at either end of it, holding.

Chapter Twenty-Five

Every Favour a Debt

. . .

A year is not an ending. Rome disapproves of endings; it has aqueducts instead. Things arrive where the maps claimed they did, late, by gravity and maintenance, and the city drinks without inquiring into the small unglamorous lettering. But a house keeps its own calendar. A house counts from the morning the damp came through a wall in the shape of a country it had never been to, and from an inspection notice left before dawn, and from the sound — still the truest minute Antonia owns, more reliable than any portent the colleges sell — of a needle going in, and coming out, and the flowers along a border learning how to be the same and not the same.

So let the record, in whichever hand survives the quarter, close the books on the following. The child across the river is born by harvest, a girl, in the lean-to room above the vats where frankly so much of the century was laundered. She is called, after business in the family that the baker's mother calls respect and Daphne calls orchestration, Lucia Vibia — the river first, the light before it, paperwork after a decent interval — and she has a thumbprint, if a person were fanciful, on the inside of one wrist, and she will be taught letters before thread by women competing on the point like rival firms. The bakehouse flourishes at the rate of honest weight. The hanging with the red flowers goes back and forth across the bridges on feast days until the neighbourhood begins to date things by it, which is how traditions, like debts, acquire the patina of having been inevitable.

Marcus goes, at summer's end, as a junior officer to an eastern staff, not his father's war, which has gone to safer hands, but a real one, with baskets. He writes home in Latin of steadily improving plainness. From Antioch he writes once to Transtiberim: three lines, no Greek beyond a

place-name, and an unsuitable present of writing tablets for a niece not yet born when he sent them, which Prima puts with her tools, evidence admissible at last. Cornelia, from a house that no longer leaks into the dining room, becomes the Avidii's connection to every singer in Rome worth paying properly, and corresponds — through the house's careful channels, at the usual rates of sororal paperwork — with a needlewoman of remarkable hems whose trousseau work her household commissions above the market. The letter in which she first guesses why is never sent. Servilia, who has scheduled everyone else's acts of this drama for nineteen years, sends instead, on the suitable feast, a recipe request. It comes back copied in Diomedes second hand, the one things live in. The pastry cook, learning that Servilia has made his almond cakes for a committee of aqueduct widows, takes to calling himself the pastry cook to two empires, and has to be sat on, kindly and specifically, by both.

Lentulus grows older the way his family goes into decline: with great dignity and improved water pressure. His name is spoken in baths, as steam; it is carved, also, in small letters where things work. Hadrian comes home from Athens and the future clanks gently up the Palatine in Greek dress; the emperor goes east to his war at last, to the drum-rolls of the stone yards, and the old men who stayed behind to mind the city's plumbing find themselves, to their discreet surprise, in something resembling favour. It lifts nobody to a column. It keeps the fountains running. Lentulus, inspecting an arcade in the second spring, is heard by an engineer to say that history is mostly maintenance and the rest is scaffolding. The engineer, who wears foreign trousers and has read exactly the legible part of the frieze, reports this in the baths as philosophy. It does the rounds. It reaches the Caelian in the door-book version by noon.

■

And the house. Let the record show the house. Registered, taxed, inspected by appointment, its women signing their contracts with a

clause in their own hands at the foot — Daphne first, in letters big enough for auditors, Philomela with a flourish praetors would call distinguishing. The library of *names* the city is convinced it keeps, it keeps exactly as it ever kept them: in Antonia's memory, unminuted, ageing like wine rather than wax. What has changed, if the aediles cared to measure a doorway they no longer measure, is that the house has begun to be described at dinners as respectable. Antonia treats the word the way her house treats glass jewellery: she acknowledges the intention and returns it beautifully. Respectability is a lane that opens. She has spent twenty-one years learning how lanes close. She will take the peace and keep the paperwork.

On the last evening this record keeps — for houses, like columns, must declare a dedication date somewhere, or the scaffolding never comes down — the lamps are being trimmed, Diomedes is failing, on purpose, to notice Eirene correcting his Greek by ear, Barbatus is telling the night porter a story whose dishonest preamble has achieved its final, perfected length, and Antonia Cassia, who was born with nothing worth the law's remembering, stands in her own courtyard with her hand flat to a wall that has stayed dry a full year along a drain whose lettering nobody will ever read. From the great room, the sound of women counting — stitches, bars, coins, stairs — comes as it has always come in this house, under the music, like the true plumbing.

In Rome, every favour creates a debt. She has made a life, and a house, and — in the third set of books, the real one, filed between the quarters among unsigned notes and one folded message about ribbons — a family, out of knowing to the last figure what the debts were. Every secret carries a price: she has paid hers in the only coin that kept its value in the getting, which was work, done on the ground, in season, by name. And the past, however carefully buried —— the past came back across a bridge one Tuesday at a time with a work-box, and sat in the courtyard, and counted with its mouth open, and asked for nothing but thread at its own prices.

She takes her hand off the wall. The plaster is warm now, evening-warmed, hers. Somewhere across the river a child is being counted to sleep. Somewhere on the Palatine an old man is choosing, nightly, at compound interest, better. In the Forum, above them all, a stone war climbs toward a pot of gold ashes and the one perfect view; and at its foot, unregarded, the men with baskets hold up, as they always have, the legible beginning of everything.

“The books are straight,” Diomedes says from the doorway, in the second hand, the one for things that must look boring to survive.

“Then we are even, nearly,” Antonia said. “In this city that's a fortune. Put the lamps up. Rome is coming to dinner.”

. . .

The End